



POST- COMMUNIST GROUNDS In Search of the Commons

Edited by
Neda Genova

POST- COMMUNIST GROUNDS

Dear reader,

We ask you to accept this book as a gift and consider a donation to a collective of your choice, according to your abilities. We offer a non-exhaustive list of groups presently working for what we consider to be the necessary work of building common grounds.

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Anarchist Black Cross Belarus, which offers support for anarchist political prisoners in Belarus: <https://abc-belarus.org/en/supporters/>

Assembly, a portal for informal journalism and grassroots initiatives in Kharkiv, Ukraine: <https://assembly.org.ua/>

Doxa, an oppositional media based in Russia about war, dictatorship and inequality: <https://doxa.team/about>

Healthworkers4Palestine, global coalition of health workers working for justice and prosperity in Palestine: <https://linktr.ee/healthworkers4palestine>

OVD-Info, helping political prisoners, monitoring repression and analysing civil society in Russia: <https://ovd.info/en/front>

Kharpp, a UK-based charity supporting refugees and rebuilding infrastructure and homes at the Polish-Ukrainian border: <https://kharpp.com/how-to-donate/>

Konflikt, a militant group of workers based in Bulgaria supporting the creation of autonomous workplace organising: <https://kon-flikt.org/en/who-are-we/>

Kurorti, a community art space run by independent artists in Georgia, supporting marginalized groups: <https://www.facebook.com/kurorttti>

Politzek.me, which offers support to political prisoners and their families in Belarus: <https://politzek.me/en/donate>

Spilne/Commons, a Ukrainian journal for social criticism: <https://commons.com.ua/en/donate/>

Stowarzyszenie Egala, one of the collectives supporting people on the move on the Polish-Belarussian border: <https://egala.org.pl/o-nas/>

Solidarna kuhinja, a Serbian collective responding to poverty and hunger with solidarity and mutual aid: <https://solidarnakuhinja.org/solidarity-kitchen/>

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In Search of
the Commons**

**Edited by
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Post-Communist Grounds.

In Search of the Commons

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The logo for the Institute of Network Cultures features a stylized, abstract network of interconnected lines and nodes, resembling a web or a neural network, positioned above the text "Institute of network cultures".

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Commoning on Post-Communist Grounds. Introduction

It is early on a Saturday, the morning of our second day at Bidston Observatory near Liverpool in May 2023. People are sleepily milling about the kitchen, making breakfast, conversation, and room around the large wooden table that has become one of the sites we keep returning to for meals and discussions. I am sleepy, too, for we had stayed up late the night before. It's 8:20am, my mind is fluttering back and forth between the unfinished bowl of muesli in front of me and the group discussion planned for shortly after breakfast, for which I still need to prepare. Then, through the morning fog and the surrounding chatter, comes the question: 'Why are you using the term "post-communism", Neda? Why not "post-socialism"?'

I am not ready for this conversation; it is way too early. I mumble something about 'communism' as a horizon; communism as a question that needs to be kept open in the present; and what kind of relation the prefix 'post' articulates *vis-à-vis* 'communism' today. I think (hope) that I can get this second coffee and finally wake up, but another person has in the meantime joined our exchange. We start discussing the difference between 'real-existing socialism' and the horizon of communism, about how our present-day looks different if you are positioned in Bulgaria, Lithuania, Poland, or the USA, how it might depend on your family history, experience of migration, educational background, political practice (or lack thereof)... The conversation keeps pulling in more and more people as they come into the kitchen. Disagreements start showing, and it is not even 8:45am yet. I didn't plan for this; I start feeling a little frustrated. Couldn't this all have waited until later? I clear my bowl, someone's doing the dishes. A person finally blurts out that they are worried about having the word 'communism' in the title of a publication they're involved in. Someone else brings up the fact that in Anglo-American literature the designation 'post-communism' is mostly used by anti-communist scholars. Another questions how important it is for all of us to agree on the meaning of 'post-com-

munism' or, as it were, of 'communism' today. After all, even if many of us are engaged in political organizing on the Left, this is not why we have gathered over this long weekend. Things get chaotic, we talk over each other, we become less patient, uncertainties start showing. Disagreement and doubt also seep into our post-breakfast discussion, which keeps halting and circling back to precisely that issue that we already knew we weren't going to agree on.

It isn't until much later – far into the night when we are dancing on the observatory's roof to tunes from pretty much everywhere – that I feel the bad air has finally been dispelled. We hug, we go to sleep. On the next day, we clean, we talk a little, we head back.

Coming Together, in Struggle

Why put this anecdote at the beginning of a volume dealing with the commons? Why not instead recount any of the less conflicted, more wholesome moments that did accompany our collaboration surrounding this publication: the way we organized our learning and exchange, or the joy when strangers became collaborators and friends?

One of my hopes in doing so is to fend off, at least temporarily, the temptation of painting the commons – or practices of *commoning* – in a too romanticized manner. Far from being devoid of conflict and controversy, commoning can very much be productive of friction and unease for those engaged in its practice. Commons are a terrain of struggle and negotiation as much as they can be a site where alternatives to capitalist enclosures can be probed (though never secured). This is because, when we common, part of what we attempt to do is instantiate an alternative mode of sociality and to displace habitual ways of making sense and knowledge in common. These practices might not always be smooth and frictionless – indeed, they can be accompanied by conflict and strife – but it is likely that it is precisely these moments that will prove most instructive in the long run.

In our case, one generative aspect of that displacement of habitual ways of making knowledge had to do with the peculiarity of the site we gathered in: Bidston Observatory Artistic Research Centre (BOARC) near Liverpool. An important concern when choosing to stay in this 'self-organised study site for research, communality and experimentation', as BOARC describes its operations on its website, had to do with the wish to gather somewhere where boundaries and constraints could be played with and modulated. By this I mean that I was concerned with situating our collaboration from the

start in a place with its own distinct character and history, which would *require* something of its guests. Living in this self-organized study space, hosted in the building of a former observatory on top of a hill, surrounded by woods, shrubs, and heathland, necessarily meant that distinctions between manual and intellectual work, artistic and reproductive labor, and free and productive time were disturbed. Sharing the responsibility for the very material conditions of coming together by distributing reproductive labor – doing the dishes, mopping the floor, putting the washing machine on, tidying up – seemed to be important if we were to take seriously the task of studying together in common. The need to collectively consider different needs when negotiating access to and the availability of spaces and resources became a way of grounding our discussions on the commons in concrete practices. Making space for simply disappearing into the woods, wandering about, exploring the area, taking time away and time for non-sense, appeared to me as important as keeping the possibility open for a difficult but important conversation to begin precisely when it wasn't supposed to.

A Terrain for Experimentation

This volume is a provisional outcome of some of the conversations we started at Bidston Observatory Artistic Research Centre in May 2023 and which, this is the hope, will be continued into the future, while involving others in them. This book is a collection of interventions seeking to explore and activate practices of commoning in post-communism in a range of genres and media forms, with a specific interest in developing experimental aesthetic practices.

Part of the concern of this volume is with contributing to a re-orientation of discussions about the commons away from prevailing frames of analyses, which tend to 'assume that emancipatory ideas of commons and commoning come from the West'.¹ On par with this supposition is the devaluation of experiments in commoning situated elsewhere that engage different historical experiences of struggle against enclosures. This includes not only various efforts of organizing reproductive labor, public infrastructure, or free time during state socialism across the so-called 'Eastern Bloc', but also the experiences of anti-imperialist, agrarian, and anarchist struggles and revolts in these regions that may as well have

¹ Ana Vilenica, 'Who Has 'The Right to Common'? Decolonizing Commoning in East Europe', in Noah Brehmer and Mary N. Taylor, *The Communist Horizon. Futures Beyond Capitalist Urbanization*, Vilnius: Lost Property Press, 2023, p. 12.

predated or, as it were, outlived the formation of socialist states. The volume brings together contributions that depart from differently constituted 'post-communist grounds' to reshuffle and remix their composition, setting them in productive relation to questions that define our present-day: from an intimate engagement with the feminized experience of labor emigration in contemporary Georgia to the disappearance of spaces of everyday creativity in Poland to accounts of the challenges of internationalist organizing on the Left today through the prism of the collective *LeftEast*. While some of the contributions engage historical and archival materials from different contexts, none of them employ a reifying approach towards the past. Instead, each works with different materials, media, or modalities of writing – from poetry to illustration, from essay to collage to movement score – to chart alternative coordinates in our present and future grounds of coming together. They attest to what Noah Brehmer and Mary N. Taylor, both also contributors to this volume, write in their introduction to *The Communist Horizon*:

Far from a 'desert', the postsocialist terrain is rich with experiment, inspired by excavations of the past and enhanced by the international and transversal connections in the present.²

So, what form did experimental, collaborative work on this volume take? Since we first gathered in the Observatory in May 2023, contributors to the book had multiple occasions to share their work-in-progress and provide feedback to each other – an attempt to build at least some principles of horizontal (self)organizing into the editing process. Again, this is not to say that this process was smooth and frictionless; or, that I have not had to make editorial decisions, at times to the effect of selection and exclusion. What I do hope shows through when engaging with this volume, however, is the consistent attempt to conceptualize methods, media, and modalities of thinking, speculating, and experimenting in common as thoroughly embroiled with the topics discussed, questions posed, and grounds charted – indeed, together they compose what Celia Lury has described as 'problem spaces'.³ Consequently, if this book is to work as a proposition for a possible arrangement of a 'ground to stand on',

² Noah Brehmer and Mary N. Taylor, eds., 'Introduction', in *The Communist Horizon. Futures Beyond Capitalist Urbanization*, Vilnius: Lost Property Press, 2023, p. 3.

³ Celia Lury, *Problem Spaces. How and Why Methodology Matters*, Cambridge, UK/Medford, MA: Polity Press, 2021.

in the words of Peter Linebaugh,⁴ then it matters greatly *how* it was composed and *how* we came to ask some of its central questions.

Commoning and (Post)-Communism

What do we mean when speaking of the 'commons' and what is the relation of commoning to 'post-communism' in the context of this book?

Commoning is the name of a practice and a form of relation that is set in opposition to the capitalist enclosure of more-than-human ecologies, time, knowledge, and creativity. There is a definitional indeterminacy surrounding the 'commons', in so far as the term 'carries with it a promising but *unspecified* sense of an alternative'.⁵

Linebaugh is an important interlocutor here, both politically and methodologically, because of the present volume's interest in exploring the potential of the commons *vis-à-vis* post-communism. Contrary to many accounts, which tend to diagnose the consequences of the collapse of socialist regimes in countries from the so-called 'Eastern Bloc' in the late 1980s and early 1990s as indicating an end to political imagination and the almost complete undermining of the capacity to envision alternatives to capitalist domination, Linebaugh's reading of these events is different. For him, the collapse of the Soviet Union sits on par with the Zapatista uprising in Mexico in 1994 because it meant that it 'became possible to think of communism without the totalitarian state, and [that] the issue of the commons had become an actual source of armed struggle in many parts of the world'.⁶ This is notably a much more hopeful proposition than accounts we might be familiar with by authors such as Nancy Fraser, Mark Fisher, or Chantal Mouffe, who insist that we live through times that have been vacated of any sense of an alternative to the capitalist *status quo*. In my view, Linebaugh's perspective carries with itself the possibility of approaching both the disintegration of state socialist regimes and their aftermath – sometimes referred to as the problematic term 'transition' – through narratives that go beyond those of loss, lack, and total failure.

To come back to the relationship between the 'commons' and 'communism', elsewhere in the volume *Stop, Thief!* that brings together writings by Linebaugh from over two decades, he defines

⁴ Peter Linebaugh, *Stop, Thief! The Commons, Enclosures, and Resistance*, Oakland: PM Press, 2014.

⁵ Linebaugh, *Stop, Thief!*, 142; emphasis mine.

⁶ Linebaugh, *Stop, Thief!*, 5.

the relation in the following way: if '[c]ommoning practices persist among workers and peasants, communism consists in the *generalization* of such practices'.⁷ Moreover, commoning and communism carry, we might say with Linebaugh, different narrative possibilities and imply different subject positions: while evidence of commoning appears as a transgression or a crime in minor narratives, oral tales, and anecdotes, communism, as a condition that aspires to be generalized, is accounted for by professionals like journalists, philosophers, economists, and so forth. Finally, commoning for Linebaugh is always local; it 'is a basis of proletarian class solidarity, and we can find this before, during, and after both the semantic and the political birth of communism'.⁸ Linebaugh's account thus allows for a productive differentiation between communism and the commons, as well as for seeing the relation between these as something dynamic and spanning multiple scales. Negotiating the specific ways in which commons and communism inform each other and how they are situated towards each other can be one way of defining the role of an emancipatory politics for the future, and this is also how I would like to propose reading the use of the term 'post-communism' in this volume. Rather than being descriptive of a given state of affairs, it can be seen as a speculative invitation to keep alive the issue of the temporal relation towards communism: if we accept the premise that communism is a generalization of workers' and peasants' practices of commoning, then can this truly be a matter only of the past? And, conversely, if we do position ourselves as successors of this condition, then what knowledge, skills, and experiences do we *already* have at our disposal and what, where, and from whom do we still need to learn – and unlearn?

⁷ Linebaugh, *Stop, Thief!*, 206 emphasis mine.

⁸ Linebaugh, *Stop, Thief!*, 213.

⁹ For instance, as recounted by Zhivka Valiavicharska, Tolstoyan vegetarian communes in Bulgaria in the beginning of the 20th century were often established on privately-owned land that was 'given' to the communities. With notable exceptions, such as that of the Proslav commune near Plovdiv, these communes tended to be short-lived because landlords often took back their land back after it had been cultivated by workers (Zhivka Valiavicharska, 'The Vegetarian Commune in Proslav (Plovdiv) and the Tolstoyan Communities in Bulgaria' (Contemporary Debates in Post-Socialist Theory and Practice, London, 2024), <https://projects.history.qmul.ac.uk/cerees/2024/02/21/cerees-mini-series-contemporary-debates-in-post-socialist-theory-and-practice/>). On commoning as a form of governing of shared resources, see: Elinor Ostrom, *Governing the Commons. The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015).

Figuration on Post-Communist Grounds

In the vast literature on the subject, 'commons' may, however, also be used in a *specified* manner: namely, to describe communities that are engaged in the common management and governing of ecological resources such as pastures, woods, or rivers, without necessarily disturbing relations of private property⁹ or a rights-based legal regime. Arguably, this informs part of the reason for Stefano Harney and Fred Moten's suspicion towards the notion of the commons, which they depict as a 'set of resources and relations that we, as otherwise exploited and expropriated people, build or protect, manage or exploit'¹⁰ and to which they counterpose the 'undercommons'. While the former conception requires a person 'as an independent, strategic agent', the 'undercommons is the refusal of the interpersonal'.¹¹ It points towards a condition of interrelatedness that doesn't require such a subject position and that is instead 'an attachment, a sharedness, a diffunity, a partedness'.¹²

While I do share in the wish to activate modes of being that are not based on conceptions of finished persons (which are a form of enclosure), my contention is that the 'commons' as a name for a broad range of collective practices that aim to put forward alternative ways of organizing and living sociality, with human and non-human others, does carry the potential to disrupt precisely the forms of identification and subject formation that Harney and Moten seek to distance themselves from. An approach to the commons, informed by the work of Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari¹³ with their attention to processes of homogenization *and* heterogeneization, stratification *and* dispersal, the formation *and* dissolution of territories, would consider the movement between specification and indeterminacy to be constitutive of the operation and conceptualization of the commons.

Here, Olga Goriunova's¹⁴ work on digital libraries and repositories as knowledge commons can be instructive. Drawing on Silvia Federici's analysis in *Caliban and the Witch*¹⁵ which argues that the self-identical, homogenized subject that is cut off from the

¹⁰ Stefano Harney and Fred Moten, 'Plantocracy or Communism', in Maria Hlavajova and Wietske Maas, *Propositions for Non-Fascist Living: Tentative and Urgent*, Utrecht: BAK (basis voor actuele kunst), 2019, p. 52.

¹¹ Harney and Moten, 'Plantocracy or Communism', p. 52.

¹² Harney and Moten, 'Plantocracy or Communism', p. 54.

¹³ Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus. Capitalism and Schizophrenia*, London/Oxford/New York/New Delhi/Sidney: Bloomsbury Academic, 2013.

commons is an invention of capitalism, as well as on the writings of Mihail Bakhtin and Gilbert Simondon, Goriunova introduces the notion of 'subject positions' *vis-à-vis* the commons. In her figuring of the commons, they appear as:

practices, forms of knowledge, action and cooperation, dynamic technical infrastructures that have corresponding subject-positions: they nurture and sustain specific subjects. Such subjects are techno-aesthetic figurations...¹⁶

The witch or the pirate constitute subject positions, as do, in Goriunova's account, the underground librarian, the public custodian, and the multiform bibliographer. What is important to understand is that the conception of subject position here is different to that of finished persons who dispose of or manage countable relations or rights.

Hence, a question emerges about the kind of subject positions that may be figured and crafted on the post-communist grounds that we're engaged in composing and recomposing: what are the aesthetic and narrative tools, the technical infrastructures and alternative notions of sociality that we already have at our disposal in these terrains – and how do we want to collectively reimagine and reconfigure them? And, more pertinently: how might these subject positions, practices, and forms of knowledge coproduced on hybrid, unfinished grounds challenge the orientations and tendencies that we encounter within the dominant geographies and spatio-temporal orderings of the so-called 'post-communist condition'? What new temporal links and connections to uneven pasts may we want to propose against the violent, infantilizing logic of temporal belatedness and 'lag' imposed on populations from formerly socialist countries?¹⁷ What lessons can we draw from these pasts – without romanticizing or reifying them – in terms of specific practices of

¹⁴ Olga Goriunova, 'Uploading Our Libraries: The Subjects of Art and Knowledge Commons', in Cornelia Sollfrank, Felix Stalder, and Niederberger Shusha, *Aesthetics of the Commons*, Zurich: Diaphanes, 2021, p. 41–61.

¹⁵ Silvia Federici, *Caliban and the Witch*, New York: Autonomedia, 2014.

¹⁶ Goriunova, 'Uploading Our Libraries: The Subjects of Art and Knowledge Commons', p. 48.

¹⁷ Boris Buden, *Zone des Übergangs: Vom Ende des Postkommunismus / Zone of Transition. On the End of Post-communism*, 1. Aufl, Edition Suhrkamp 2601, Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 2009;

commoning against capitalist enclosures that we want to reinvigorate but also concerning those mistakes, cruelties, and injustices we must commit to never repeating? What kinds of collective subjects do we want to form and what will our alliances look like, against the racist and environmental violence of national borders?

What follows is a set of propositions for such common grounds, which, however, do not chart out a unified, self-consistent territory with a singular historical subject. The grounds outlined here should rather be considered as paths that *may* be taken. They oftentimes adopt a speculative mode and in doing so also require a leap of imagination from the reader. Revisiting the contributions to this volume, I cannot help but notice a certain quality of airiness, an openness and generosity that is present consistently throughout: formally and aesthetically – in terms of their working methods and approaches – but also as this relates to the kinds of themes and questions they have chosen to engage with.

Such is indeed the case with Rastko Novaković's contribution *Our Figures on Communist Grounds*, which takes the form of a montage of a range of materials and densely layered references. Screen-shots from D. W. Griffith's short film *A Corner in Wheat* (1909) are woven together with handwritten passages from Vincent van Gogh's letters, writings by Simone Weil, Svetozar Marković, and paintings by Millet and van Gogh. These fragments – which at times clash with and at other times echo each other – wrestle with representations of figures of farmers and manual laborers and their role in programs of spiritual and political uplift, revolution, and regeneration. Land ownership appears not merely a question of 'management' but rather a complex set of relations between people and nature, figures and soil, progress and pride.

Olia Sosnovskaya also uses the method of montage to compose movement scores for three protest choreographies that emerged during the 2020-21 uprising in Belarus. In *Scoring Political Movement and Its Exhaustion*, she brings together various quotes of testimonies, archival materials, media publications, her own writings as well as documentary images such as maps, schemes, and photographs produced during the mass protests. The protest choreographies thus assembled – protest marches, gatherings, and solidarity networks – are haunted by the violence and erasure that the protests were subject to, but together they also resolutely chart a ground of solidarity and cooperation amidst and against state and police violence.

Hanna Grzeškiewicz is also concerned with calling forth alternatives to the present-day reality, with her site of intervention being the region of Białowieża – one of the last remaining and largest old-growth forests in Europe, which the fortified border between Poland and Belarus cuts through. Her *Speculations on a Borderless Forest Feminism* shifts our attention to those silvan ecologies, legends, rituals, and sonic reverberations that do not heed the barrier erected through the forest. Her text follows a 'seasonal' rhythm and, similarly to Novaković's and Sosnovskaya's contributions, also engages different materials, including musical recordings that set in motion alternative visions for the region.

In *Soil-making and the Grid of the Atlas: Histories and Imaginings of a Queer Trans Socialist Herbalism*, Miha Brebenel continues the engagement with land and ecology as political terrain but also one for speculation and experimentation, to critically appraise the role of soil science in the solidification of patriarchal and ethnonationalist narratives in state socialist Romania. In their contribution, composed of textual fragments written in different voices and styles, along with collages featuring found educational materials, they seek to counter the imperial and colonial legacies in which pedology is complicit in the sedimentation of masculinist fantasies in the Romanian nation state and its masculinist fantasies.

Aleksandra Fila's contribution shares with Brebenel's the concern with revisiting the vestiges of state socialism, with her account focusing instead on its history and aftermath in Poland. In her essay adopting auto-ethnographic methods *Losing Common Ground. Common Spaces of Everyday Creativity and their Enclosures in Post-Socialist Poland*, Fila brings our attention to the emancipatory role of common spaces – especially those pertaining to social reproduction and creative expression – created during state socialism, and of their privatization and dissolution in the post-socialist period. The text, whose author is part of the generation born and raised in the 1990s era of enclosures, is also a call to forge alliances with our grandmothers, a refusal to let their stories and lived experience be silenced.

The need for intergenerational conversations surrounding the question of what to do and where to go in the face of loss, enclosure, and erasure is taken up again in Aleksei Borisionok's *Closed Factory Library: Notes on Workers Movements in Belarus*. His collection of three notes engages with the neglected history of labor movements in the country through the prism of two sites and one proposition: a factory library, now closed, where the author spent much

of his childhood; the story of a failed attempt to visit the Museum of the Workers' Movement in Minsk, managed by the Federation of Trade Unions that supports Alexander Lukashenko's regime; and an engagement with 'comradely aesthetics' *vis-à-vis* a reading of a work by visual artist Uladzimir Hramovich.

xenodata co-operative (Sasha Anikina and Yasemin Keskin-tepe) also depart from experiences of loss, subjugation, and war; their *Diagrams: A Series of Failures* may also be read as a poem that has adopted the form of a conversation, or as a ritual against alienation. Their contribution is composed of propositions and questions in words, graphs, and images that dwell on the possibility of assembling a collective political body – against the totalizing diagrams of both Soviet cybernetics and the new diagrammatic order of neoliberal capital and 'big tech'.

Nino Gavasheli likewise proposes a conversation that unfolds amidst absence, or rather, distance. Her *Georgian Migrant Women Diary* is made up of a series of illustrations that figure the spaces and perspectives of women who have emigrated from Georgia – with outward labor migration a pervasive experience across post-socialist countries. The words accompanying these illustrations, which Gavasheli has collected from letters written by women practicing care work in Western Europe, destabilize pre-conceived expectations about the kind of affective attachments that may be forged or lost when making such a move. The illustrated diary – which can itself be seen as an act of imaginative care – is meant to be shared with other women who are considering emigration in the future.

Noah Brehmer's essay for this volume, titled *As If This World No Longer Existed: Three Theses on the Crisis of Political Belonging*, tackles the question of the role of friendship and comradeship in political organizing, but also of 'movement messianism', which arguably circumvents both. The text adopts a dialectical method – with each of the three sections of Brehmer's 'treatise' featuring a thesis and an antithesis – and concludes with an amiable and critical letter from an anarchist friend. Thus, the essay opens itself up to future conversations, which it actively seeks and engenders through its propositional, dialectical form of writing.

The volume's concluding contribution is made up of a set of fragments from a conversation between Mariya P. Ivancheva and Mary N. Taylor, two members of the collective *LeftEast* that maintains the eponymous web publication. *Fragments towards a Post-Socialist Networked Commons: LeftEast as Praxis* offers an earnest, detailed

engagement with the history of the collective, the lessons learned from its decade-long collaborative activist work, and in particular the role of in-person 'encounters' in developing the collective's publishing practice. Embracing minor details and process, the authors intersperse throughout the incomplete and overlapping fragments of conversation maps, diagrams, timelines, and citations that enrich an understanding of its layered character.

As this brief sketch shows, despite the many common threads that crisscross the contributions to this volume, they also vary in terms of their methods and themes, as well as the kinds of sites and resources towards which they direct their hope for future, more equal common grounds. This may well be tied to the varying political orientations of the authors, as well as the extent to which political organizing plays a role in their practice more broadly or not; these are differences that ought to be attended to in the act of reading as a kind of antidote to homogenizing and harmonizing accounts of the commons. What the contributions, I believe, all share with each other has to do with their capacity to work with vulnerability, and to follow methodological paths that are adventurous and risky yet crucial to do justice to the questions posed. In doing so, they consistently avoid the pitfalls of turning the work – be it textual, visual, or sonic – into a fortress, a kind of enclosure. Their experiments function as acts of commoning, and for the gift of this I want to thank Aleksei, Hania, Mariya, Mary, Miha, Nino, Noah, Olia, Ola, Rastko, Sasha and Yasemin. Thanks for your generosity and trust in walking and asking questions together.

Many have crossed paths with us in the past months; without their insights, trust, and willingness to open spaces for thought and action with us, this publication wouldn't have been possible. Here I would like to especially thank our hosts from Bidston Observatory Artistic Research Centre for welcoming us into this singular space of commoning and experimentation. Thank you, Brendan Curtis, for turning our stay at BOARC into a feast to remember. Thank you, Ana, Lisette, and Ilona for the questions you brought to our table. Thank you to Krystian Woznicki from Berliner Gazette for supporting the project from the very beginning and helping it travel far and wide. Thank you to Maria Chehonadskih, Mirna Pedalo, Alexei Penzin, and Mijke van der Drift for your generosity in sharing your time and knowledges, as well as to Celia Lury, Olga Goriunova, and Matthew Fuller for your indispensable advice in moments of doubt and uncertainty. Thank you to Stephanie Jones for making things possible

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Our figures on communist grounds

Again I am copying Bertolt Brecht - something he wrote in 1940:

The emotions always have a quite definite class basis; the form they take at any time is historical, restricted and limited in specific ways. The emotions are in no sense universally human and timeless.

The following pages follow the shape of a film from 1909: A Corner in Wheat. Made by that bastard - D.W. Griffith.



Van Gogh to Theo, 16 Nov 1883

A black stretch of earth, flat, unending, a clear sky of delicate lilac-white. The earth sprouts that young corn as if growing a mould of it. That is what the good, fertile lands of Drenthe really are – and all in a misty atmosphere. Think of Brion's *Le dernier jour de la creation* – well, yesterday it felt as if I understood the meaning of that painting. The poor soil of Drenthe is the same, except that the black earth is even blacker – like soot – not lilac-black like the furrows, and overgrown in a melancholy way with perpetually rotting heather & peat.

I notice it everywhere – chance effects on that infinite background: in the peat moors, the turf huts; in the fertile areas, those most primitive hulks of farmhouses & sheepfolds with low, very low little walls and enormous mossy roofs. Oaks all around. Journeying through these parts for hour after hour, one feels that there really is nothing but that infinite earth, that mould of corn or heather, that infinite sky. Horses and men seem as small as fleas. One is unaware of anything else, however large it may be in itself, one knows only that there is earth & sky.

However, in one's capacity of a small speck watching other small specks – leaving the infinite aside – one discovers that every small speck is a Millet. I passed a little old church, exactly, but exactly like *L'église de Gréville* in Millet's little painting in the Luxembourg. Here, instead of the small peasant with the spade, though, there was a shepherd with a flock of sheep alongside the hedge. In the background was a vista, not of the sea, but of a sea of young corn, a sea of furrows instead of waves. The *effet produit* was the same. Then I saw ploughmen, hard at work, a sand cart, shepherds, roadmenders, dung carts. In a small roadside inn, I drew a little old woman at her spinning wheel, a small dark silhouette out of a fairy-tale – a small dark silhouette against a bright window through which one saw the bright sky and a little path through the delicate green and a few geese pecking at the grass.

And then, when dusk fell, imagine the silence, the peace!



Imagine then a short avenue of tall poplars with autumn leaves, imagine a wide muddy road, all black mud, with heath stretching to infinity on the right, heath stretching to infinity on the left, a couple of black triangular silhouettes of turf huts, the red glow from small fires shining through the small windows, with a few pools of dirty, yellowish water reflecting the sky, in which fallen trees lie rotting into peat. Imagine that sea of mud at dusk with a whitish sky overhead, thus everything black against white. And in that sea of mud a shaggy figure – the shepherd – and a mass of oval shapes, half wool, half mud, jostling one another, pushing one another out of the way – the flock. You see them coming, you stand in their midst, you turn round and follow them. Laboriously and reluctantly they work their way up the muddy road. The farm beckons in the distance, a few mossy roofs and piles of straw & peat among the poplars. The sheepfold is again like a triangular silhouette, the entrance dark. The door stands wide open like a dark cave. The light of the sky glimmers once more through the chinks in the boards behind it. The whole caravan, masses of wool and mud, disappears into the cave – the shepherd and a little woman with a lantern shut the doors behind them.



Simone Weil writes in *The Need for Roots* (1943):

Physical labour is a daily death.

To labour is to place one's own being, body and soul, in the circuit of inert matter, turn it into an intermediary between one state and another of a fragment of matter, make of it an instrument. The labourer turns his body and soul into an appendix of the tool which he handles. The movements of the body and the concentration of the mind are a function of the requirements of the tool, which itself is adapted to the matter being worked upon.

Death and labour are things of necessity and not of choice. The world only gives itself to Man in the form of food and warmth if Man gives himself to the world in the form of labour. But death and labour can be submitted to either in an attitude of revolt or in one of consent. They can be submitted to either in their naked truth or else wrapped around with lies.

Labour does violence to human nature. At times there is a superabundance of youthful energy eager to spend itself and not finding a suitable outlet; at other times there is exhaustion and the will has ceaselessly to supplement, at the expense of a very great strain on itself, the lack of physical energy; there are a thousand and one pre-occupations, worries, anxieties, a thousand and one desires, interests which take the mind elsewhere; monotony brings with it disgust, and time hangs with an almost intolerable heaviness.

The human mind dominates time and ceaselessly and rapidly surveys the past and the future, leaping over any sort of interval; but he who labours is subject to time in the same way as inert matter that can only move slowly, from one moment to the next. It is in this way, above all, that labour does violence to human nature. Which is why those who labour signify the suffering labour causes them by the expression 'finding the hours drag'.

Consent to suffer death, when death is there and seen in all its nakedness, constitutes a final, sudden wrenching away from what each one calls 'I'. Consent to perform labour is of a less violent nature. But where it is absolute, it is renewed each morning throughout the entire length of a human existence, day after day, and each





day it lasts until the evening, and it starts again on the following day, and this goes on often until death. Each morning the labourer consents to perform his labour for that day, and for the rest of his life. He consents to perform it whether he feels sad or happy, worried or ready for amusement, tired or bursting with energy.

Immediately next in order after consent to suffer death, consent to the law which makes work indispensable for conserving life represents the most perfect act of obedience which it is given to Man to accomplish.

It follows that all other human activities, command over men, technical planning, art, science, philosophy and so on, are all inferior to physical labour in spiritual significance. It is not difficult to define the place that physical labour should occupy in a well-ordered social life. It should be its spiritual core.

Svetozar Marković writes in *Serbia in the East* (1872):

From an economic standpoint, the zadruga is a primary association of both producers and consumers. But there is an economic feature which sets the zadruga apart from all contemporary combinations for production and consumption and that is that it produces everything it needs. That which the zadruga obtains through purchase on the side is so negligible that it isn't worth a mention. Ordinarily, the zadruga buys salt, iron tools, some crockery and that's nearly all. This ability of the zadruga to obtain everything it needs to survive stems from patriarchal life itself. The needs of all its members are small and can be met through homegrown production. The division of labour, in the contemporary sense of the word, where one person produces only one product and obtains all the others through buying and selling, does not exist in a primordial society. The zadruga produces everything itself: food, clothing, footwear, linen, tools, the house – everything. Through its internal order, the family zadruga would not be able to produce all the necessities in a developed society, and that is the cause of its demise with the development of civilisation. However, it is notable, that all kinds of contemporary thinkers on society deem such a society to be an economic ideal, in which each of its members would alternate doing a variety of jobs, such as correspond to their natural aptitudes and capabilities, rather than being chained to a single job like the contemporary European worker is. A society also in which each member, through a mutual obligation between all members receives necessities, and does not have to obtain through buying and selling ninety-ninth-hand that which one could obtain first-hand. Simply put: the contemporary economic ideal is very close to the principles of the economic order which exists in the zadruga.



Shall we gather at the river?

Now that regimes formerly opposed in ideology are directly united by Technology, a productivist progress weighs more cruelly than water, earth, air and fire – a world dominated by Technology is lost for Liberty. As this field of catastrophe stacks and folds, the woman's voice speaks to us of war again: I realised then that anything can burn... Even blood burns... Figures be mutilated, the Bomb burning shadows into concrete. Then fish, birds, cats, people – all the living figures of <M> suffering and dying; the seas churning a choke of nurdles, the ground scarred by lakes of solar mirrors and the aquarelle palette of lithium ponds – how distant from daydreams of angels separating fighting swans.

Shall we gather at the river?

Very often the idler is but a someone to whom it is repugnant to spend all their life making the eighteenth part of a pin, or the hundredth part of a watch, while feeling the exuberant energy which they would like to expend elsewhere. Often, too, s/he is a rebel who cannot submit to being fixed all their life to a work-bench in order to procure a thousand pleasures for the employer, while knowing themselves to be far the less stupid of the two, and knowing their only fault to be that of having been born in a hovel instead of coming into the world in a castle.

Shall we gather at the river?

The dead die hard, they are trespassers on the beyond, they must take the place as they find it, the shafts and manholes back into the muck, till such time as the lord of the manor incurs through his long acquiescence a duty of care in respect of them. Then they are free among the dead by all means, then their troubles are over, their natural troubles. But the debt of nature, that scandalous post-obit on one's own estate, can no more be discharged by the mere fact of kicking the bucket than descent can be made into the same stream twice. This is a true saying.

Words and images

After Jean-Marie Straub, Danièle Huillet *A Proposal in Four Parts* (1985)

Bertolt Brecht *Short Description of a New Technique of Acting which Produces an Alienation Effect* (1940)

D. W. Griffith *A Corner in Wheat* (1909)

Simone Weil *The Need for Roots: prelude towards a declaration of duties towards mankind* (1943)

Vincent Van Gogh *Letter to his brother Theo* 16 Nov 1883

Svetozar Marković *Serbia in the East* (1872)

Jean-François Millet *The Angelus* (1857-59)

Vincent Van Gogh *Two Peasant Women Digging in Field with Snow* (Feb 1890)

Georges Bernanos *France Against The Robots* (1945)

Svetlana Alexievich *The unwomanly face of war* (1985)

Iri Maruki and Toshi Maruki *on the Minamata Mural* completed in 1980

Stanley Spencer *Separating Fighting Swans* (1933)

Vanessa Machado de Oliveira *Hospicing Modernity* (2021)

Simone Weil *Oppression and Liberty* (1943)

Robert Lowry *Shall We Gather at the River?* (1864)

Phill Niblock *The Movement of People Working* (1973 – 2023)

Peter Kropotkin *The Conquest of Bread* (1892)

Samuel Beckett *Echo's Bones* (1933)

Scoring political movement and its exhaustion

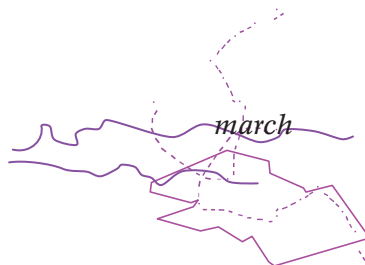
On the following pages I propose movement scores for three kinds of protest choreographies — understood in a broad sense as certain political movement formations or collective actions — that have been crucial during the 2020-21 uprising in Belarus. These are the protest march (or walk), the gathering (neighbourhood celebrations and protest actions, occupations of public space, strikes, techno parties) and opaque solidarity networks (Telegram chats and political prisoners' support).

Movement score connects the past — as a trace or a document of an action — with the present moment, when it is read and embodied, as well as with a multitude of its potential future enactments. Drawing from dance theory, socialist literature on revolutionary mass celebrations and various guides, instructions and protest marches' routes published during 2020-21 uprising in Belarus, here I understand 'movement score' as any kind of graphic transcript of movement (including text) that intersects multiple temporalities in its enactment. It is used as a conceptual and methodological tool to address collective movements (bodily and political) in post-socialisms, and to question the linear time of the political event, as it is thought exclusively in the categories of failure or victory, or in the straightforward transition from socialism to post-socialism. This project moves between library, rave and revolution in the time-space of the anti-governmental uprising in Minsk in 2020 and its aftermaths; between archival materials and bodily experiences as well as the way in which they are inaccessible. It derives from my desire for the event to last, to establish more complex temporal and corporeal relationships between the political events, archives and political projects, and to re-assemble collective protest choreographies by conveying the experience of them into a possibly shareable tool of movement scores.

These scores are composed through a montage of various quotes: testimonies, essays, interviews, fiction, archival materials, media publications, my own writings alongside images that document the uprising: maps, schemes, and photographs. I borrow from the method of lecture-performance, where excessive quoting, rep-

etition and recomposition of textual and visual materials invite alternative modes of reading, narrating and interpreting. In those, overlaps, exhaustion, ruptures and stumbling may also be articulated, while playing with discursive power and triggering the emergence of new, unintended meanings, affects and fantasies.

After the shared embodied experience of the revolution in Belarus, of being subsequently dispersed in exile, imprisoned and prevented from mobilizing inside the country, our bodies are now connected through memories, imaginaries and language, in the mismatching synchronicity of movement, reading and writing.



13.09.2020 •

Plan of the ~~March~~ of Heroes

Main column

14:00 ~~gather~~ in the area of Nezalezhnastsi avenue, Niamiga street

15:00 ~~move~~ through Ramanouskaya slabada and Frunzenskae metro to Tsimiariazeva street

Through Tsimiariazeva, [we] ~~come~~ out to the crossing of Pushkin avenue and Arlouskaya street.

From there to Victory avenue

~~reach~~ Arena-City by Victory avenue, from there [we] ~~walk~~ to the presidential residence.

17:00 The space of historical legacies of anti-fascism resignified through the protesters' bodies and their choreographies, through their ~~subversion~~ of the official choreography of military parades.

To ~~walk~~ through the spaces that violence has alienated us from; to ~~occupy~~ space, history, time.

~~Gather~~, as usual, in your neighbourhood and ~~walk~~ to the Nezalezhnastsi square together, by 14.00.

Last Sunday, police attacked some columns while they were still small ~~gather~~ closer to the centre and make it fast. ~~Protect~~ each other in case of attack.

Over 400 people will be ~~detained~~.

Movement routes of columns from various Minsk districts to the city centre.

Plan of ~~movement~~ for the column from (Zavadski, Leninski and Partisanski) Minsk districts

12.30 – groups of March participants from (Zavadski and Partisanski) districts, as well as from (Serabranka) micro-district meet by the metro station (“Tractor factory”). [We] ~~move~~ to the city centre down the (Daugabrofskaya) street.

11:07 ~~cops~~ minivan

13.20 – ~~come~~ out to the (Nezalezhnastsi) avenue near (Victory) square, meeting the column from (Perski and Savetski) district.

~~Move~~ towards (Nezalezhnastsi) square.

*Plan of movement for the column from the (Maskouski)
Minsk district*

11:07 cops minibus

13:00 – groups of march participants from (Bylevichy, Malinauka and South-West) micro-districts meet near the station. [We] wait for residents of the eponymous micro-district and start movement down the avenue.

13:00 cops minibuses

13:15 – [we] meet residents of by the building of the executive committee of the district.

13:30 – encounter: while the police is blocking the march, get to the column / gathering point by rumours, accidents, witnesses, Telegram messages, intuitions, occasional en-counters.

13:30 – pass by the and go further along

14:00 – [we] gather in the area of avenue, street

14:00 riot control vehicle riot police plainclothes cops

13:40 – move through the city, avoiding arrest, driven by the desire and effort to join the march, fear of detention, joy of encountering friends on the way, strangers walking in the same direction, encountering smaller columns, merging sprawling.

13:50 – 13:40 – [we] meet the column from district at the crossroads of and streets.

14:44 scattered in the backyards

photo_2020-11-01_13-55-32.jpg

*Plan of movement for the columns from the (Frundzenski)
Minsk district*

13:00 – groups of participants of the march from micro-districts meet at the start moving towards

13:20 – Political agency sensed corporeally, as a joyful militancy of encounter and exposure of mass dissent through bodies demonstrating in public space, normally suppressed and concealed by the state for the illusion of people's unity.

13:30 H. said, "When you see a friend in the crowd and they see you, and you see each other."

13:45 – anti riot barriers

13:40 – [we] ~~unite~~ with the column from district at the intersection of and streets.

13:50 – The idea of political movement ~~grasped~~ only through proximity, and thus occurring as personal, sensual and intuitive.

14:00 – [we] ~~gather~~ in the area of Nezalezhnastsi avenue, Niamiga street

14:00 – the joy of ~~joining~~ others, a continuous effort to ~~walk~~ together, interrupted, non-linear route, alerted, detouring, bypassing, being aware of space, contingency, watching out for cops, being exposed to the view, (un)familiarity of the city.

16:29 mass ~~detentions~~

09.2020

March of Justice! Towards Supreme Court, Surround the Palace!

The main column:

14:00 – gather

15:00 – ~~moving~~ towards ~~is closed~~, take the first ring to

After a history of failed protests since 1990s, one believed in the capacity of a great mass of people ~~gathered~~ on the streets to change the state system. But instead of being a triumphant rupture, the revolutionary moment lasted for [42] months.

If ~~is blocked~~, go to the via

leave our posters

“And what we are left with are aftermaths [of political catastrophe], in which the present seems stricken with ~~immobility~~ and pain and ruin; [...] a present “that stands out in its ~~arrested movement~~”, that could be nothing more than “the endless and melancholic repetition of itself”¹.

~~surround~~ the palace and wait for

Plan of ~~movement~~ for the columns from the northern Minsk districts

13:00 ~~meet~~ at the

waiting for

students, employees
who live in the neighbouring districts. start moving along

13:03 – Collective movement beyond the liberal idea of freedom as freedom of mobility (for the few).

13:20 – meet the
near the

go together to

15:50 crackdown

16:00 – escape, don't run, link up, take refuge in a stranger's car, flat, disguise your march as a walk, try to gather again, desire of proximity, disperse, leave avoiding arrest, message friends, check detainees' lists, repeat.

Plan of movement from (Loshitsa and Kamvolny kambinat) district

13:00 – [we] meet at the palace of (formerly the palace of the) and move to the centre along Street.

13:40 – at the intersection of and Street, wait for groups from the and districts, then walk along street. If it is blocked, exit to Avenue via any parallel street.

15:44 cops van

13:00 cops minibuses

13:00 cops minibuses

14:16 cops minibus

13:02 cops minibuses

11:07 water cannon

11:07 cops minibuses

14:44 water cannon

15:38 beating

11:07 plainclothes cops

14:00 riot control vehicle riot police plainclothes cops

13.00 – K. says, look around – turn your body a little in the opposite direction, slightly turning the head, so its movement is unnoticed (by the police.) Turn around and walk backwards, observing (to estimate the number of people, remaining unnoticed by the police).

Plan of movement for the columns from the (Aktsiabrsky) Minsk district

13.00 – ~~meet~~ near the
for

~~move to~~

wait
in organised

manner.

Usually the bridge over the railway tracks is blocked. You can go through the railway station or meet the column from the neighbourhood at the intersection of and .

13.00 – When does the movement start? When you walk out of the house, when you join a friend, when you join a column, when columns unite, resist, hide, escape? In the left hip or in the torso?

13.20 – Since S. obviously couldn't hold a flag with her hands, a friend made slings for it, so she usually carried a flag on her shoulders.

Plan of movement for the columns from the (Central) Minsk district

14:00 – [we] gather in the area of avenue, street

13:30 – When in Minsk in 2020, it is impossible to not be part of the protest. Is it necessary to form a column when we are already everywhere?

13:30 – Not limited by the dynamics of continuous movement of the marches, the political struggle trespassed into daily practices and movement of ordinary bodies, with their fragility and irregular rhythms.

14:30 – The main gathering point is the area of the metro station. We gain critical mass and walk towards street, where we meet the columns from

districts of Minsk. We go out to Avenue along Garadski Val Street. If it is blocked, exit via any parallel street.

14:30 – Once I didn't make it to the march. The fear of just being outside paralysed my body.

I tried to move slowly, but not being able to adjust to the common speed of the march, I failed to catch up with it. Being left behind

the event, I felt that we all would eventually fail.

04.10.20

March of Liberation

photo_2021-03-05_11-03-57.jpg

18:00 – all workers go to Square, where, on behalf of the strike committees, they put forward our popular demands and start a ~~sit-in strike~~.

19:00 – Sometimes U. felt pain hanging in the back of the head, along the spine. He didn't walk towards the explosions, he wouldn't be able to run. On Sundays, he would walk many kilometres in a march while he would hardly leave his home during the week. While walking, he'd always look around, fearing the police vans.

20:00 – From Nezalezhnastsi Square we go to the detention centre on demand the release of all detainees and political prisoners.

20:01 – Though early marches still were more or less safe, beautiful and massive, H. got tired very quickly. At some point she couldn't chant anymore, she had no energy, she already had said everything – how many times can it be repeated? Mouth wouldn't open, she had no air.

Plan of movement for the column from (Zavadski, Leninski and Partisanski) Minsk districts

12.30 – In the autumn 2020 Vika Biran writes in her prison diary, the march was large, no one was detained until it was dark, and everyone went back to their districts. My new friend was detained near Uručča. They beat him during the detention, then they stopped.

13.20 – In December 2021 H. says, she is exhausted and she is ready to mobilise, sometimes she imagines: at night the news about a victory arrive, I get up, go outside and all the people there are hugging and we are dancing; this sick fantasy carries me.

Plan of movement for the column from the (Maskouski) Minsk district

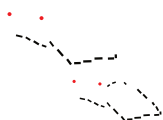
13.00 – *In September 2020* coming back from the march, the body is completely exhausted. After the 12 km walk, after continuous anxious and attentive muscle tension: keeping an eye on the police, keeping an eye on safe places. Revolutionary time is the time of exhaustion.

13.15 – *In February 2024* Dusty Whistles recounts that struggles move in circles, through repetitions of emancipation and burnout; that's why we need archives. She doesn't have hope, but she has desire.

13.30 – *Nour Shantout* recounts hope is a privilege, those born in generations of trauma can't have it. Struggle comes out of the site of hopelessness.

13.40 – *In 2009 Eve Tuck* writes, desire necessarily complicates our understanding of human agency, complicity, and resistance.

13.50 – *In December 2021* G. says that night gives him energy to live during the day, marches didn't do that anymore.



march routes, walk move



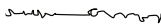
march lines, gather



crowd contour, run



tree map, meet encounter



crowd outline, friend



bodies, blocked



tear / points in space, wait



tear / points in space, repeat rehearse



crackdown yandex, arrested detained



In 2019 Ana Vujanović writes: 'public space is not the main site of politics' anymore and 'live gathering of people in public is irrelevant.' I wonder, if the space of a page is a site of action.

In December 2020 in Minsk H. says,

At the neighbourhood protest actions, there were very few emotions, it was more of a duty, a necessity to go out – still, it is some movement. Actions are modest and simple: do some little action for 10 minutes – and disperse; block the road for 5 minutes – disperse. Return in the evening, stand along the road, wave flags. But there was no drive, I couldn't even chant, I don't even have energy to talk about them now. I recall the earlier days.

²"Holiday of Enthusiasm and Struggle". M., 1930

As general protest marches became more and more unsafe again and public space – more policed, there was a move towards greater politicisation of the semi-public and private spaces: yards and homes. Through festive neighbourhood gatherings, various partisan actions and support networks, etc – more intimate, secretive and semi-visible, featuring more sustainable ties and relations to space, and still not completely avoiding crackdowns. At yard parties, political agenda might not have been openly pronounced, however it was this agenda that drove the gathering. Festivity resisted the on-going political repressions and state violence, reclaimed public space and life alienated by violence, state (itself often manifesting its power through official celebrations), police, consumption, or the fading of post-Soviet infrastructures. Transformed by the event, yards became places, shared, welcoming, with flickering traces of dissent spilled into the mundane.

To walk from one protest yard to another [14.5 km].

In Soviet mass revolutionary celebrations, it was claimed that the affective power of the festival could serve to intensify solidarity and collectivity, and for emancipation from alienation and proliferation of struggle in the times of revolutions and protests (Mazaev 1978).

[Socialism] has a tremendous impact on the thoughts and feelings of people all over the world,
 writes Lithuanian SSR "Knowledge" publishing house in Vilnius in 1980, on page 4; ordered by reader with higher education degree Сасноўская on 12.02.2019 at 17:40:00.

The festival promotes the unity of young hearts in a common impulse for peace, mutual understanding and friendship. It becomes an effective means in the struggle for happiness,
 writes "Youth" publishing house in Kyiv in 1982, ed. by Lysenko A.V., on page 7; ordered by reader with higher education degree Сасноўская on 12.02.2019 at 17:51:50.

It awakens, raises, calls to struggle and victory, unites, strengthens, ignites the flame,
 writes Bardin I. in M. in 1925, [Moscow Worker], on page 44; ordered by reader with higher education degree Сасноўская on 21.09.2020 at 9:08:10.

The preparatory work for the festival creates the appropriate mood in which [students] go to the demonstration and feel no less responsible than when performing on stage,
 writes Polyakov V. G. in M. in 1925, on page 8; ordered by reader with higher education degree Сасноўская on 09.09.2019 at 12:31:31.

³"Festival of Youth". Kyiv, 1982

Scenario of the opening ceremony.....p. 18

Scenario of a celebrationp. 67

Scenario of the evening of friendship.....p. 103

Scenario of the final concert of days of friendship..... p. 95

"Festival of Harvest", M., 1925

The main objectives of the celebration..... p. 7

Preparation for the holiday..... p. 7

Order of the celebration..... p. 51

“Festival of Youth”, Kiev, 1982, 228 p.

“Festival of Youth”, Kazan, 1956, 39 p.

“Festival of Youth”, M., 1957, 51 p.

“Festival of Youth”, M., 1956, 46 p.

At a ~~rave~~, at the demonstration, affect and joy saturates the body with a belief that political agency and togetherness are still possible; and this sensation, against hopelessness and tragedy, is political in itself.

But rather than being a political event as such, rave is desire, a trigger, a tone of language and motion.

In 2009 Eve Tuck writes: “...desire [...] interrupts the binary of reproduction versus resistance...”

In 2022 away from Kyiv Anton Lapov says,

I don't think it is possible to create political relationships and political agenda in the club without action on the streets. But normally such things can't last long.

In 2021 in Minsk G. says,

In the first month of the protests, parties were cancelled. Later, when most of the club scene resumed their regular party rhythm, in the smoking rooms the only talk was about the protests. Not articulating their political position openly is OK for the clubs, it is already clear that it is not pro-regime, and if they got shut down for political activity, it won't make it any better to anyone.

In 2021 in Minsk P. and K. say that the largely precarious club scene in Belarus generally lacks solidarity.

In 2020 in Minsk the general protest marches on Sundays and the Saturday night parties were rather mutually exclusive.

In 2020 in Minsk H. says,

Every evening probably after the first big march on 16 August, people were gathering to dance and sing. On 1 September we came to the square and there were a lot of students. When cops arrived, older women organised the rest: guys in the middle, encircled by several rows of women and girls, facing the street. Arms linked-up,

obviously, but more as a symbolic act than as actual protection. And so, we all swayed and sang Kupalinka, over and over. Kupalinka-kupalinka, dark night. Dark night, where is your daughter? The song ends, and then again. We didn't know how long it lasted (probably half an hour) and why the cops left (they were probably ordered to). But we realised that if we left the square individually we would be detained, so we walked in rows, arms ~~linked up~~, close together. It was an interesting experience for me.

To link up arms with other protestors in order to resist indiscriminate arrests.

To do a ~~link up~~ according to technique, one needs to believe it would actually help you, despite being weaker than the riot police, and to be willing having a confrontation.

To do a ~~link up~~ as a necessary gesture of acknowledging the state violence and resisting its normalisation, as learned from H. in Minsk in 2020, when she says, the night when I was detained, it was no longer a ~~link up~~, but an embrace – I remember standing with the girls and holding each other and ourselves, protectively; and being pulled out, from the side, someone already falling.

Few cases of Minsk club scene members' open engagement with the 2020 protest: streaming mixes to be played at protests (Radio Plato, sometimes together with queer activists), DJing at protest marches (DJ Papa Bo, later arrested).

The suggestion to make a joint ~~rave~~ during one of the first general protest marches was rejected by most of the club scene, claiming it was not the right time for joy and party, since it was shortly after one of the protestors, Alexander Taraikovsky, was murdered by the police. Later, it was no longer safe to arrange it.

On August 13, 2021, any ~~gathering~~ in Belarus could be criminalised, such as: workshops, city guided tours, exhibitions, sauna, birthday parties; but club parties (except queer parties) happened as usual. If the state doesn't consider clubs to pose any danger to the existing political system or to have political agency, could this opacity be used politically, so that a politicisation of the body develops unnoticedly. Or would opacity rather be a strategy for survival, a temporary refuge for the few?

To hold hands with friends

For example, after you run, run somewhere to a safer place, hold hands to calm each other. Or, hold hands when it simply feels amazing being at the protest, as learned from H. in Minsk in 2020. She says, the most common gesture at the protests was an embrace. When you see someone you know in the crowd, and you see each other, and you are happy to see that you are both OK, and that you are fighting for the same thing, that you have a matter in common, and you are here together, in this space, for this matter – that kind of an embrace.

In 2021 in Minsk G. says,

During the uprising, we organised only one Petushnya queer party. It was rather intimate; for those who don't go anywhere but Petushnya it was important to feel the community, to know that everyone is alive and not in prison.

⁵*“Holiday of Enthusiasm and Struggle”, M., 1930*

⁶*“Celebration of Struggle and Cheerfulness”, Voronezh, 1934*

⁷*“The Rebellious Holiday [...]”, Moscow / Leningrad, 1926*

⁸*“Celebration of Life”, Moscow / Leningrad, 1925*

They say you can place “celebration” and “revolution” next to each other, linked by an “and”. They say: “celebration and revolution”.

Read the name of the book filed by number 351 in the list of 927 sources, containing the word “celebration” in their title, published in the USSR before 1991.

The choir of texts: The texts tirelessly repeating each other, speaking in unison, echoing the synchronous movement of the bodies who perform them.

Attach words to bodies – in the form of an instruction or as an adjective: joyous, young, cheerful.

The joy can't be endured by a single body, it can't be contained in a single word either. The whole corpus of texts – 927 – can't

be grasped by a single body. Read endlessly. Quite literally, the political movement 'must be learned, rehearsed ... practiced, and experienced. Again and again, and again, and again, and in every repetition, through every repetition, renewed'.

Look at the text. Reading is a gesture. Trace the geometry of its lines, its shapes, its routes, trying to slip off to the margins. In the stillness of a page, try to imagine the preceding and the forthcoming move. Wonder, how to do things with words.

⁹*Appendix 1. Slogans. 17. Use the summer to also fight (...)*

~
To stay (not run).

In the course of duty, around 17:20 at Lenin Square in Mozyr, a mass gathering of citizens was noted: namely three women and three men, who, in the presence of other passing citizens, stayed in one place for a long time without moving, thus publicly demonstrating their mass gathering. Subsequently, after being approached by the police officers, in order to prevent them from holding a mass event (picketing), they took measures to move to another place, taking different routes, in particular, to 35 Sovetskaia Street, where they again gathered together and continued their public stay without movement in one place, in connection with which this group of citizens was detained by the officers, quoted by "Paleska Viasna" newspaper, April 4th 2022.

In 2020 in Minsk H. says,
every evening we gathered on Nezalezhnastsi square and danced. On one of those evenings I was with my girl-friend. When we arrived, everything was joyous, but I noticed that she was scared (though already having been at more violent actions). I said – if you're scared, go, you don't have to be there, but she said – how can I go? She was scared, but she stayed. It was important for me that she stayed (because of me), and it was such an important turning point within myself – not to run away. I'm not sure I said it out loud. I felt it so much with my whole body. I'm a very anxious person, so I always notice when I firmly stand on the ground.

I think it was such a moment. I saw why I was there, I realised my position clearly, that I had a right to be here and we were here together. When I was detained, I didn't run away either.

In 2021 in Minsk G. wonders,

Do parties play a special role now? I used to think so. Now I don't know if people are really escaping something or just partying. But I'd probably leave if the nightlife shut down, and a lot of people around me would leave too. Events at night give energy to live during the day. Protest marches don't work anymore.

How to embody revolutionary time through movement?

Can the gesture/movement be repeated (by same or other bodies, at different times and space)?

Soviet revolutionary mass celebrations suggest that revolutionary event and revolutionary affect can be repeated. That the singular event of the revolution re-emerges in the celebration as its affect.

To repeat protest gestures outside of the protest, during the protests, in winter 2020-21, in Minsk in the middle of a friend's living room. To isolate the gesture from the movement of the whole body, from the movement in the crowd. To repeat it several times, attempting to make sense, to grasp, to learn. Such an operation could be extractive. And it could be an exercise when through repetition and rehearsal a political movement is made less spectacular, less dramatic, more of a routine. At that time the protest had become a certain routine too, part of daily life; and daily life, to some extent, had become a protest.

How long does a revolutionary event last?

The question arises from Soviet books on revolutionary mass celebrations, where the revolutionary event lasted until 1991. It arises from the experience of the crushed 2020 uprising in Belarus and from the refusal to accept its failure. It arises as a corporeal post-rave melancholia of the exhausted body, of the night-time spilling into the day. ▲

When movements are exhausted, affect reverberates and can generate desire. Thus, imagining and remembering become the same

act. Writing, on the contrary, is time.

How long does the affect of the revolutionary event last?

How long can a movement last?

What stays in the body after the event?

Buck-Morss, S. asks,

Can revolution have any other time but the present?

Susan Buck-Morss, *Dreamworld and Catastrophe: The Passing of Mass Utopia in East and West* (Cambridge, Mass, London: The MIT Press, 2000), p.144.

on 21.09.2020 at 9:08:10 in Minsk, reader with higher education degree Сасноўская reads on page 28,

this year, the [...] celebration is not a symbol of the victory of the future, but a triumph of the present.

Lepeshinsky, P. N. ... Proletarian Class Holiday. – [Kharkiv] : Proletary, 1925. – 30 p.

Badiou, A. is asked,

– We’ve just spoken about the structures of our time. You oppose to these the possibility of the event. What, though, is, in fact, a political event? [...] how can we prepare for it?

– ‘To be prepared for an event’ means ... recognising new possibilities. Since the event is necessarily unforeseeable ... preparing for the event consists in being disposed to welcome it.

[...] First, by remaining faithful to a past event, to the lessons given

to the world by that event. This is why the prevailing order [...]

tries to show that past events haven’t created any new possibility

[...] that nothing really happened, or, better yet, that what hap-

pened ... caused a new horror, a new order or a new regression.

[...] then [...] political subjects are [...] in a situation upon which

events of the recent or distant past still have an impact. The polit-

ical subject is, then, the interval between the past event and the coming event.

Alain Badiou with Fabien Tarby, *Philosophy and the Event* (Oxford: Polity Press, 2013), p.13.

20.09.2020 at 14:10:52 in Minsk, reader with higher education degree Сасноўская reads Guidelines for celebrating “May 1 –

Festival of International Workers’ Solidarity”, published in Kyiv in

1987, just 4 years before the USSR collapsed, written in a language that hardly differs from celebration guidelines published in the 1920s, in the 1950s, in any place in the USSR. It is written in a language that seems to deny time, the time that has passed since the revolution, as if the event still lasts. In a language, that appropriates land.

¹⁰ *Celebration of International Solidarity Vilnius, 1977; Moscow, 1974; Moscow, 1928*

¹¹ *Celebration is Always with Us Moscow, 1988*

Lorey, I. writes on ~~revolutionary~~ time, 'Now-time' is not a bridge or a transit from the past into the future. It is stretched out and intensive present. It is not an event of a great, one-off break, but an enduring unfolding of affective connections, an 'affect virus' [1] through which new socialities emerge. 'Prefigurative practices' diminish the gap between the present and a revolution to come. Either in the symbolic sense, by imagining and enacting alternative social structures on small-scale experiments, or in an actual sense, of embodied practices of horizontal social relations, self-organized counterinstitutions, alternatives imagined and rehearsed.

Isabell Lorey, 'The power of the presentist-performative: on current democracy movements' in *A Live Gathering: Performance and politics in contemporary Europe*, ed. by Ana Vujanovic, Livia Piazza (Berlin: b_books, 2019), p. 38, p. 42.

"We outrun time"

Scenario of the theatrical concert report..... p. 32

on 20.09.2020 at 14:10:47 in Minsk, reader with higher education degree Сасноўская reads on page 12,

[May Day] has already since its establishment been not just a cheerful celebration of spring, but a day of dress rehearsal of ... preparing for the struggle for a full and final liberation.

Gornev, A. ... Festival of International Solidarity (May Day). – M. : publishing CC USSR MOPR, 3rd print. Transpechat, 1928. – 28, [3] p.

Scott, D. writes on ~~revolutionary~~ time,

One mode of thinking about 'the temporality of political action'

in the present is to focus on 'the temporality of the aftermaths of political catastrophe, the temporal disjunctures involved in living on in the wake of past political time, amid the ruins, specifically, of postsocialist and postcolonial futures past'.

'And what we are left with are aftermaths [of political catastrophe], in which the present seems stricken with immobility and pain and ruin; a certain experience of temporal aftermathness prevails in which the trace of futures past hangs like the remnant of a voile curtain over what feels uncannily like an endlessly extending present'. A present 'that stands out in its arrested movement', that could be nothing more than 'the endless and melancholic repetition of itself'.

David Scott. *Omens of Adversity: Tragedy, Time, Memory, Justice* (Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press, 2014), p. 2, p. 6.

¹² *Celebration of Struggle for the Future*, Vilnius, 1980

Atanasoski, N. and Vora, K. write on revolutionary time, Now why we have to use the post to think beyond something is another question. For me, the post signifies a more than, a beyond, a not yet, or a what is yet to come.

[...] and as you've mentioned, we were rethinking temporality as one way to re-open historical possibilities that seemed foreclosed after the end of state socialism [revolution?].

Neda Atanasoski and Kalindi Vora, 'A conversation on imperial legacies and postsocialist contexts Notes from a US-based feminist collaboration' in *Postcolonial and Postsocialist Dialogues Intersections, Opacities, Challenges in Feminist Theorizing and Practice*, ed. by Redi Koobak, Madina Tlostanova, Suruchi Thapar-Björkert (London: Routledge, 2021), p. 36.

Campt, T. writes on revolutionary time,

The grammar of black feminist futurity that I propose here is a grammar of possibility that moves beyond a simple definition of the future tense as *what will be* in the future. It moves beyond the future perfect tense of *that which will have happened* prior to a reference point in the future. It strives for the tense of possibility that grammarians refer to as the future real conditional or *that which will have had to happen*. [...] It's a politics of prefiguration that involves living the future now—as imperative rather than

subjunctive as a striving for the future you want to see, right now,
in the present.

Tina Campt, *Listening to Images* (Durham, London: Duke
University Press), 2017, p.17.



page barricade



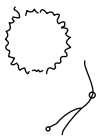
poster curve, read



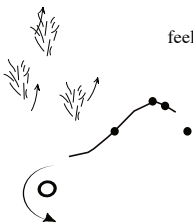
rail scheme, revolution



fire scheme, violence



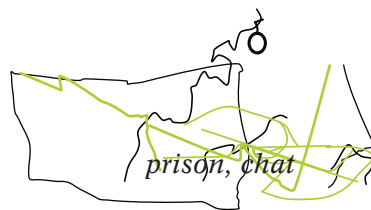
time signs: trajectory lights, rail sabotage part



feelings: fireworks, graph, alien~ation gymnastic



figure, stay



We are on a walk in Angarskaya district with A., we hear the car honks from somewhere behind the forest, we know – at this moment people are blocking the circular road, we read a Telegram chat titled 'Angarskaya 97%'.

It is Monday, evening. We know and we sense how events happen all around us, they end and take place again. The mundane is illusive.

When in Minsk, it is impossible to not be part of the protest. The very pedestrian movement, the very presence of your body in the city – be it in the city centre or in your yard in the residential district – is saturated with the political. Now, every night on the way home we check local Telegram chats for any actions or police raids in the neighbourhood – one does not need to “participate” to get arrested. The protest can be almost imagined as an alien spirit that possesses your body at a certain point of time, regardless of your intention or will. It is interesting to think about political agency here. Deviation, elusion, chance, flicker – like a blaze or a tire set afire.

The body and the space of the city is where the movement starts, gathers, unfolds and then spreads. The police want to extract people from the mass of the protest march, to fire them, arrest in private homes, expel, imprison. But then a new negative mass is formed – of prisoners or those in exile – so the question is how to keep the connection.

9. Political prisoner – my friend. Just be friends [website], <https://poltizek.me>, (accessed by link on December 20, 2020)

@spiskov_net_bot

! Attention

The volunteer group created to help the relatives of the detainees on Okrestina pre-trial detention centre was recognized as an extremist formation by the Ministry of Internal Affairs. For the safety of all group members, it has been deleted.
seen 11.2K 15:48

! Attention

Note that subscription to the channel also provides grounds for criminal prosecutions of citizens who participate in the activities or spread any information in the ~~group~~. In other words, simply participating in the ~~group~~ may not be safe for those in Belarus. Therefore, we decided to clear the history of the ~~group~~ and delete it.
seen 12.4K edited 17:37

“So, finally, there is a moment to start describing my prison experience. I want to start with life hacks: to tell why in prison I was in a cheerful state of mind almost all of the time, I slept normally, I held lectures (5), I was focused and left with a rested head.

As everyone promised, the first three days it was hard. Before the trial. When at the ROVD (local police department) they kept me for 5 or 6 hours in a space of 1 by 2.5 meters, and after 6 hours the KGB officers tried to talk with me about the Coordination Council and its Fem ~~Group~~ (in this space, I first closed my eyes and after 5 minutes I realized that I had already appropriated it and domesticated it and I can easily move around and rest in it). Then at the Okrestina detention centre, after a calm night on a mattress and with bed linen, I was transferred to a cell with dear Yevgeniya Dolgaya, where we had only one blanket for the two of us, neither a mattress nor anything else. We put on the bed what we inherited from the previous “guests”: newspapers, bed linen on top of them and plastic bottles with warm water under the heads (as pillows); we slept in an embrace, covered with one blanket.” Olga Shparaga

https://t.me/spiski_okrestina

The “Okrestina detainees” ~~group~~ was created by volunteers to support the relatives of detainees. In the ~~group~~ relatives communicated, exchanged information about ~~lists~~ that officials don’t provide, about care packages (which ones are not accepted), etc. Although the initiative itself did not violate any of the existing laws, it is not safe to stay in the ~~chat~~.

“fourth day

Yesterday, we were transferred somewhere. To Zhodino, I think. The very fact of moving in space, no matter where to, was joyful. In our small cell in Okrestina I had started going a little crazy. [...] We got our mattresses back for the night, but the other girls didn’t. So, the three of them slept in a two-person cell without mattresses on bare boards with their neighbor L.” Vika Biran

Practical guide on care packages for prisoners from Viasna:

How to give care packages to a person in a pre-trial detention center?

Fill in and sign the application in two copies in accordance to the form.

Both copies of the application, the package, as well as the identity document are to be handed over to the employee of the detention center.

Remember that clothes and shoes should be without laces, remove packaging from all the items, transfer them into transparent bags, it is worth indicating the expiration date. Sausage, meat and cheese should be sliced. Photographs and letters are not allowed.

Note that every detention center has its own rules, so something may differ.

As practice shows, even the staff's mood may affect whether certain items are admitted, so even those that are officially allowed may not be accepted on the day of the visit. Be prepared for this.

"The passage of time without the clock, which we were deprived of in prison, as well as any gadgets, brought me back to Foucault, to the microphysics of time, and since it exists at all, it means that we can outgame power here too. By filling the time with your inner world, memories and, of course, communication and shared experiences. [...] And we shared not only our thoughts, but also anything, right down to underwear." Olga Shparaga

Jackie Wang talks of 'carceral temporalities' and the politics of dreaming: prisons are not just a corporeal but also a temporal regime of punishment, they weaponise time. Pain is normally understood as physical, but prison temporalities leave no visible wounds on the body of the prisoner. In solitary confinement there is an excess of time, prisoners are robbed of temporal agency, of embodied modes of relationality and the use of language. Time is punctuated by meals and so forth.

"What do we want to do every day?

- exercises
- laundry
- washing
- writing practices

- reading practices
- analytical practices and ~~emo-round~~
- daily (multi-scale) resistance practices" Vika Biran

<https://politzek.me/letter>

Write a letter to a political prisoner in 15 minutes:

Greet them, tell them about yourself, and explain why you decided to write.

Hello, writing to you from, my name is, found out about you last week, writing to you because I know that you, I work, in free time.

Share your news, thoughts, and life stories.

Today, yesterday, last week, during this weekend, kids, parents, family, I like, visited in city.

Send good wishes, ask questions, inquire about their opinion, and provide a date.

How are you doing? How is your health? What would you like to know about? I'm really looking forward to your response! Hope to meet you soon. Keep in touch! Sending hugs all the best!

Don't know whom to write to?

"There we go: a new girl came to us and thoroughly influenced our group dynamics. At first, I liked her. Like, [she was] an adult woman with joint disease, but then she pissed me off so hard. She [lectured us], invalidated, fiercely violated our boundaries, and gave advice. [...] And you can't run away. We're all tied up here. We are forced to be 'together.' It's good that she didn't stay with us for more than two days. When we said goodbyes, I hugged her anyway, just like the others. And smiled. We'll never meet again anyway".

"(note – my mother's letter was the only one I received during my entire sentence)".

"They do not allow you to sleep during the day and lie on a bed. We must sit on a hard, narrow bench at the table. We sleep at night with the bright light on. Moreover, I have periods." Vika Biran

List of things admitted in the prison packages:
 zefir, candy, marmalade, halva, chocolate;
 instant potatoes, instant noodles, instant soup, refined sugar, cereals (buck-wheat, oatmeal);
 jerky, sausage, salted lard, salted fish, cheese;
 envelopes, stamps, sheets of paper, pens, folders, notebooks;
 any kind of coffee, loose leaf tea;
 onions, fresh herbs, garlic, cucumbers, tomatoes, paprika;
 sunflower oil;
 nuts, apricots, dates, candied fruit;
 cookies,
 cigarettes, matches;
 toilet paper;
 fruit: oranges, tangerines, pears, apples, lemons, bananas (bananas are not allowed in some centers, please check);
 hairbrush;
 underwear;
 handkerchiefs, stockings;
 hard soap, liquid soap or shampoos (only in transparent bottles),
 toothbrush, toothpaste, (plastic cases for soap and toothbrush);
 (sanitary pads and tampons);
 a pocket mirror (if there is no mirror in the cell);
 skin care cosmetics (cream and deodorant are accepted only in plastic tubes, hard deodorant is prohibited);
 colour pencils, markers, ballpoint pens (red ones are prohibited);
 boiling water heater (low wattage, up to 500 W);
 rubber slippers (not flip-flops);
 electric razor or disposable plastic razors (also for women).

<https://abc-belarus.org/en/2022/05/16/how-do-one-write-letters-to-prisoners-in-belarus-so-that-they-reach-them/>

Most of our comrades who have sent letters to imprisoned anarchists and anti-fascists have most likely not received any response. For those who send letters this situation is also extremely demotivating: it is unclear whether the letter has reached the comrades or not. We still encourage you to write letters, because even the occasional piece of news that breaks through the walls is very uplifting in isolation.

<https://abc-belarus.org/en/>

[send-an-online-letter-to-a-prisoner/?lang=en](#)

After we receive your letters we pass them through our own channels to the comrades in prison.

We do not have the possibility of maintaining feedback between you and the prisoners, so the correspondence will go one way until the regime collapses or the censorship is loosened (which is not expected in the near future).

There is also existential terror of not knowing what will happen. In opposition, there is ungovernable time – time of past generations and future openings, dreams surpassing capitalist and colonial linear temporality. Imagination is excess that prison will never contain. Poetry, song, protest chants create new rhythm and synchronise collective rhythm, a vibrational experience to wake your desire of another world. (*Jackie Wang 'Carceral temporalities' and the politics of dreaming.*)

Not a single day in the existence of the collective has passed without anarchists or antifascists being held in Belarusian prisons. (<https://abc-belarus.org/en/about-us/>)

Take at least 15 minutes to write letters to your comrades. You can write anything you care about, but don't write things that could cause problems for you or your imprisoned comrades. (<https://abc-belarus.org/en/2022/05/16/>)

<https://makeout.space/2020/12/07/from-okrestina-to-berghain-i-write-therefore-i-am.html>

"I was told about several cases of prisoners' resistance: for example, they deliberately laughed out loud, when the pigs brought new boys to make the latter understand that it was OK to live here, and that all those screams were fake. Or they hung white-red-white towels on the battery [radiator]. Or sang loud songs, including 'Mury', 'Voiny Sveta', etc." Vika Biran

A package may not contain prunes, raisins, sunflower seeds, kozinaks, herbal tea, pomelo and grapefruits, Chinese cabbage, salt, books, magazines, crosswords, watercolors, reusable shaving machines, safety scissors, scarves, wet wipes, cotton buds, lighters, and plastic dishes.

“And I did not allow myself to fully enjoy the upcoming freedom, because I knew that after 15 days they could take you for another 15. And then again, and again. I thought how I should subtly tell my friends that we should quickly go away from the gates not to get another subpoena and not make them think that I went completely bonkers in my cell”. Vika Biran

www.spiski.live

Last updated on October 8, 2023. The list is no longer updated, no changes are made to the database.

The information was collected by volunteers of the @spiski_okrestina channel from all available sources.

The database contains information about 38863 detentions from 09.08.2020

<https://abc-belarus.org/en/prisoners/>

Unfortunately, the level of solidarity our comrades receive is decreasing over time, especially when it is almost impossible to organise a reliable communication channel between them and other comrades. But we believe we simply have to provide our comrades with long-term and complete support, and for that we need your help.

Anastasia Kukhta

Become supporter

Krystsina Charankova | Kristina Cherenkova

Become supporter

Jauhien Rubashka | Evgeny Rubashko

Become supporter

Aliaksandr Bialou | Aleksandr Belov

Become supporter

Dzmitry Dubouski | Dmitry Dubovski

Become supporter

Dzmitry Rezanovich | Dmitry Rezanovich

Become supporter

Ihar Alinevich | Igor Olinevich

Become supporter

Mikita Jemialjanau | Nikita Emelyanov

Become supporter

Tsimur Pipija | Timur Pipiya

Become supporter

Dzianis Boltuts | Denis Boltut

Become supporter

Tamaz Pipija | Tamaz Pipiya

Become supporter

Andrei Chapiuk | Andrey Chepyuk

Become supporter

Mikita Dranets | Nikita Dranets*

Become supporter

Aliaksei Halauko | Aleksey Golovko*

Become supporter

Aliaksandr Frantskevich | Aleksandr Frantskevich*

Become supporter

Daniil Chul

Become supporter

Pavel Shpetny*

Become supporter

Aliaksandr Zaitsau | Aleksandr Zaytsev

Become supporter

Akikhira Hajeuski-Khanada | Akikhiro Gaevsky-Khanada

Become supporter

Aliaksandr Kazlianka | Aleksandr Kozlyanko

Become supporter

Mikalai Dziadok | Nikolay Dedok*

Become supporter

Become a personal supporter of a prisoner – someone who takes over financial support of a particular convicted activist.

Read about prisoners who need your support.

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crackdown yandex, detained imprisoned



railway outline, sleep dream



banner curve, write



bullet bureaucracy lines



Speculations on a borderless forest feminism

WINTER

The sky above is gray though not visible for the tree branches intertwining tightly in a rhizomatic crown, sitting heavy atop the multilayered forest bed. The ground is slippery, the marshy soil has frozen to form an icy crust. Walking off the designated path, the one marked out by state foresters, I hear only the ground cracking beneath my feet. As condensed breath moves languidly through the air, my gaze catches up to a stagnant smell. I see more gray ahead, directly above a river whose flow has been severely hindered. The gray is not a reflection of the sky. It is a steel wall, adorned with barbed wire, cutting across a living body of water whose currents no longer have the force to lap at the alien metal prongs.

In January 2022, the Polish government began the building of a 5.5 meter tall and 186-kilometer-long wall that would physically enhance most of its border with Belarus. Part of the wall cuts through the Białowieża Forest (*Puszcza Białowieska / Белавежская пушча*), a 'relic' of a much larger primeval forest that stretched across the European Plain, now one of Europe's last remaining ancient forests. The Białowieża Forest is the largest intact area of ancient biodiversity in 'Europe', managed and divided by the State Forest Departments and Border Guards of two nation states. The building of the wall was decreed by the Polish government as a response to the humanitarian crisis that began at the border in August 2021, arguing that a 'hybrid war' was initiated by Belarussian autocrat Alexander Lukashenko by transporting people on the move across it. In the summer of 2023, many news sources spread the myth of Wagner Group militants masquerading as people on the move to enter Poland. This wall has become a new site of fortification for Fortress Europe, around which tens of people are known to have died, hundreds have gone missing, and thousands have been injured.

In most recent public memory, the Białowieża Forest has become synonymous with modern human tragedy, violence, and illegal pushbacks. When someone says 'Białowieża', many now hear 'border'. Reports of deaths from the forest appear with a seasonal

regularity on social media channels from activist groups, sometimes also being leaked to mainstream media outlets.

Developing in parallel are ecological tragedies, caused by over-management, logging, and conflicting conservation strategies. The height of media attention around the need to protect the forest and against extractivist policies can be traced back to the spruce bark beetle outbreak in spring 2016. This outbreak was used as an excuse to intensify logging, eventually leading to a ruling from the European Court of Justice that ordered it to stop.¹

There has been an observable media-driven insistence to keep the topic of the state-sanctioned humanitarian tragedy separate from the state-sanctioned ecological devastation that is happening in and to the same living being, the Białowieża Forest. Why is this the case? The forest is a complex ecosystem, which includes humans, and the new border wall is a symbol of the inseparability of manifestations of capitalist authoritarian rule that include border politics and extractivist policies. The wall was designed to deter humans from crossing this arbitrary border, but its design also prevents other species from making that crossing.² Border violence is distinctly nationalistic and patriarchal, and is a manifestation of aesthetics of violence, threat, devastation, division, and scarcity. Borders aim to divide and dominate, reinforcing patriarchal structures and societies, and profiting the military-industrial complex. By fighting the institutions and industries that dominate marginalized groups, as well as expressions of capitalism and patriarchy that take the physical form of borders, emancipatory feminist positions must fight for their dismantling as a way of imagining future alternatives.

Who decides what belongs on which side of the forest, who is 'allowed' to cross and who is not? Why should ecosystems be prevented from changing, shifting, growing, contracting, inviting, embracing? Does the wall render the border more real?

¹ ECJ Case number C-441/17, April 2018.

² It has been widely reported in the media that the 'holes' designed for animal crossings are too few and too small, directly interfering with migration patterns.

Spring

'Dziewanna wielkokwiatowa' (denseflower mullein) is a flower whose Polish name is derived from the Slavic goddess, Dziewanna. She is the goddess of spring, life, and nature, and the counterpart to her sister, Marzanna, the goddess of death and winter. Marzanna is the sister whose effigy is to this day drowned in rivers to announce the end of winter in Poland, though the second act of the ritual, decorating a figure of Dziewanna with flowers picked from freshly sprung fields, has been largely forgotten. The word 'dziewanna' resonates in the modern Polish ear with the word 'dziewica' (virgin) or 'dziewczyna' (girl), though older roots of the word gesture towards the divine and the wild, away from associations with purity. 'Dziewanna wielkokwiatowa' is a caring plant used for soothing colds, flu, or stomach ailments.

Adapted from Patrycja Machątek's *Magia Polskich Ziół*.³

What if we imagined the borderlands differently? What if we shifted away from patriarchal imaginaries and searched for alternative narratives, rooted in some of the more repressed histories of the region? In *Niesamowita Słowiańszczyzna* ('Uncanny Slavdom', 2006), the late Polish feminist scholar Maria Janion wrote that while not asking to bring Slavic mythology onto the same pedestal as the current (propagandist, indoctrinatory, glorified) teaching of the Catholic Church and Polish history, she wanted to pose a question: could a new narration of the humanities tell a different history of (Polish/ Slavic) culture and thus help us understand our past, our present, and influence the future?⁴

I would add: could it help us heal?

Janion's approach is attached to the *human* and wears a distinctly anthropocentric cloak. Slavic mythology, however, could be an entry point into imagining alternative narratives that take us beyond such anthropocentrism: its rooting in nature and webbing of the spiritual, more-than-human, and human realms creates a rich well from whose waters new knowledges can be drawn and distributed to nurture our communities, becoming an inspiration for others. The orientation around Slavic also opens a new conceptual plain that predates and overrides modern national borders. There is no clear answer to the question as to where the borders of 'Slavdom'

³ Patrycja Machątek, *Magia Polskich Ziół*, Kraków: Wydawnictwo Znak, 2022: p. 68-73.

⁴ Maria Janion, *Niesamowita Słowiańszczyzna*, Kraków: Wydawnictwo Literackie, 2022.

or 'Slavicness' lie, and I choose not to define these, rather choosing to see them as living practices that continually shift and transform. It is from this deliberate ambiguity that I want to think through what could be a borderless forest feminism.

Inspired by Kodwo Eshun's explorations and undefinitions of sonic fiction in *More Brilliant Than The Sun*, in which he argues for sound as a tool for fictioning an alternative future-reality – in Eshun's case as a contribution to Afro Diasporic Futurism – in addition to stories from nature and Slavic mythologies, I want to point to sonic materials as sites of new imaginaries. The history as written and told through national archives, museums, state education, and other state apparatuses is the narrative of those who have held the reins of power, and who have been building capitalist, authoritarian, patriarchal states through acts of bordering that inevitably constrain our lives. Alternative histories are often told through family archives, local collections, and – crucially – orally. Oral histories told through female ancestral lines, as well as associated sonic traditions, are the ground on which I attempt to compost patriarchal narratives and prepare the soil for future seedlings.

Although the borders around the Białowieża Forest now seem (and as of recently, are) fortified, they have moved innumerable times over the course of the past centuries. The movability of these borders has created individual and collective fluidities amongst the human and more-than-human inhabitants particularly around the borderlands of what is now Poland and Belarus, and further south, Ukraine, living in dialogue directed by the body of the forest. On the Polish side of the border, the area where such encounters and proximities not only occur, but also form the basis of the area's complex, fluid, situated in nature and borderless character are the Podlasie, and, further south, the Polesie regions. The name 'Podlasie' directly translates to 'by the forest', while 'Polesie', 'after the forest'.⁵

It is through two ancestral female practices that continue to be prominent here – *szeptuchy* (literally 'whispering women'), local healers, and *biały śpiew* (white singing), a traditional and collective form of singing – that I want to trace a different Slavic, feminist, and ecological historical narrative, as a basis for an alternative imaginary for the region.

⁵ Different etymological schools argue that the word 'Podlasie' comes from the name of a tribe (*Lachowie*) and is not associated with the nearby forest. However, in everyday word association, this is how the word would be translated and those are the words it would evoke.

Summer

We drive up in a pink car to a local supermarket in Orla (Орля), a small town in Podlasie. It is the afternoon on a hot summer's day. The car park is next to one of the last synagogues that has remained intact in the area and which we have come to visit. As we leave our pink car, we are waved down by an older man on a bicycle and a woman dressed in a bright pink outfit. We walk up to them, and they quiz us if we are here to see Pani Wala. We ask if it would be possible – we had heard of her, she is the local szeptucha. We were told not to look for her as she has been known to cast curses on those who would visit her as if she were a tourist attraction. The lady in pink tells us that it's a bit late but she will take us. She just needs to buy some things in the supermarket. Once she's done, she gives us the address and asks us to follow her on her bike. We follow in our pink car. As we arrive on a quiet street where Pani Wala's house is located, she meets a friend on the pavement, and they ask us to help them fix another bike. As we do this, the lady in pink walks into a house on the other side of the road. After some minutes, she opens the window and tells us that Pani Wala will see us now.

What followed was a ritual conducted by Podlasie's best-known *szeptucha*. The ritual comprised of a mix of traditions, both religious and non-religious. Orthodox icons of the Virgin Mary were lit by a colorful light that bounced around the room. In her thick local accent – sounding more Belarussian than Polish – Pani Wala repeated a mantra many times, blessing us. She told us stories of hiding from the Nazi occupants in the Białowieża Forest when she was a child. The ritual had to be continued the next night by consuming blessed wafers and burning their paper wrappers in a fire, whispering our intentions into it.

Szeptuchy are local village healers. They are mostly of Orthodox faith and are usually older women with a mythical air to them. They are often seen as a mystical phenomenon of the Eastern Polish region, and yet are revered and visited by many, not just by those who live locally. Their practices are seen as something between magic and religious ritual, with stories of miracles and healing travelling through local villages and towns. Some dismiss these as old wives' tales. *Szeptuchy* have a complex relationship with the Orthodox Church – which is only present in this specific region of Poland in any significant way. On the one hand, they are sometimes rejected by the Church due to the pagan roots of their practices and also the

belief that their calling has been received directly from God. On the other hand, they are also known by, accepted, and often collaborate with local patriarchs.

The existence and persistence of the practice of *szeptuchy* speaks to an alternative history (and reality) of the region around the Białowieża Forest. A history that holds pre-Christian, pagan, Slavic beliefs and rituals in an embrace with the local Orthodox faith. That respects the forest and the local natural area. Where local accents suggest that Polish and Belarussian languages have transformed into something that defies the border nearby, similarly to the Forest's centuries-long defiance of it. Perhaps and most crucially, the persistence of the village healers suggests a defiance of the centralized narratives of state and nation that presuppose a uniform belonging to a centralized Catholic Church. It also suggests a pre-cedence for the local area, defined by the Forest, over the nationalistic whole.

*In the morning I will go down to the valley
In the morning, so the songs ring, so 'rusatki'⁶ will hear them
I'll take them to the forest, and I'll go back home
I'll take them to the hollows and I'll go back to my mother
For you, 'rusatki', garlands and for us, young ones, sickles
For you to sleep in the earth, and for us to reap the rye.*
Song text from *Śpiewy Polesia. Ukraina*



Śpiewy Polesia. Ukraina, sung by Zespół Poliny Sydorenko, Rejon Czarnobyl, 2005.

Alongside the practice of *szeptuchy*, *biały śpiew* (white singing) is a second strand of alternative history that has persisted in this region. A folkloristic way of singing with an open throat, it allowed voices to travel across open space or cut through crowded indoor spaces. The traditional Slavic folk songs – sung in Polish, Belarussian, and Ukrainian – connect to daily work, rituals, celebrations, and nature. Their survival has been ensured by women, who are the carriers of this tradition, knowledge, and repertoire.

⁶ Water nymphs in Slavic mythology.

This kind of singing is raw, brazen, cutting through space like a knife through butter. It unsettles the body and soul, unleashes the animal in the voice. It's as if our great-grandmothers, their grandmothers, their grandmothers' grandmothers, and so on and so forth, have suddenly come to voice.

Paulia Miu Kühling, white voice practitioner

This type of singing is not taught by any official state education entity in Poland. Despite being part of the country's cultural heritage, it is only taught in informal local groups or workshops. Similarly to *szeptuchy*, it is a practice that sits uncomfortably vis-a-vis the image of the Catholic nation-state. It defies borders and languages, since the roots of *biały śpiew* are in the Podlasie and Polesie regions that cross the modern borders of Poland, Belarus, and Ukraine. The songs also offer alternative histories of the region – weaving together Slavic mythologies, religious faith, reverence for the natural world, and stories of rural women – these songs do not support the heroic stories of war, rebellion, and sacrifice for the nation as taught by the Polish state. Following the threads in Ewa Majewska's *Feminist Antifascism*,⁷ these songs could form the soundscape of an alternative, feminist commons that lays the ground for alternative visions of the future. Majewska's work on feminist commons, an expression of an alternative world emerging from feminist organizing, is tied to her concept of 'weak resistance' – resistance that is not heroic, but one that invites alliances, heterogeneity, and non-individualism. It functions on the premise of building a new reality based on a utopic idea of the commons and the collective, and not on the reclaiming of the current system. Younger practitioners travelling to the region and learning songs from women who have been singing these songs in the villages for decades, passing on centuries-old songs, is a form of upholding an alternative set of knowledges and practices – a living counterpublic.

Recently, a new wave of artists, who in Poland include Sutari, Ifi Ude, and Otucha Collective, have taken up *biały śpiew* in their practices, making old songs and techniques their own, while retaining a strong connection with the tradition and its ancestors. Ifi Ude, for example, a Polish-Nigerian artist, defines her work as inspired by pagan beliefs and local melodies of the places where she grew up, and her sound travels between Slavic and Igbo folk traditions and

⁷ Ewa Majewska, *Feminist Antifascism: Counterpublics of the Common*, London and New York: Verso, 2021.

mythologies. Her work pushes the sonic imagination of what Slavic culture could be – or perhaps already is.



Tato, tato – Ifi Ude (feat. Bart Palyga, Marcin Lamch)

Following Janion's warning not to put these mythologies on a pedestal akin to Polish Catholicism, we could ask if these artistic practices use the past to imagine a new future or romanticize old traditions to forget the struggles of the present?

...songs live in different contexts. These songs were created to be sung in the community. It's something that lives with us, a sensation that is so powerful. Another conversation that we are having is how to queer these songs, because oftentimes they are, on the narrative level, reproducing things that we do not agree with. And this is especially the case when we talk about intergenerational healing and female circles, and how much healing from patriarchal violence is needed. I'm speaking for myself but also for my mother, grandmother, great-grandmother...

Agnieszka Bułacik, member of Otucha Collective⁸

⁸ "Imagining Futures through Sounding Together". An Interview with the Otucha Collective', in *Kajet Journal* (2023). Available from: <https://kajetjournal.com/2023/10/02/otucha-collective-imagining-futures-interview/>.

⁹ Simona Kossak, *Saga Puszczy Białowieskiej*, Warszawa: Wydawnictwo Marginesy, 2016: 27.

Autumn

The Białowieża Forest has never been and will never be old. Unmoved in its timeless majesty, it continues to be just as vibrant as it was in the millennia that surround it. In its own rhythm, successive generations of trees and annual herbs are born, mature, grow old, and turn to dust. In the blink of an eye, autumn and summer storms and winter snowstorms turn whole swathes of the forest into piled-up debris of broken trunks and branches. With the passage of time, the wounds heal and are covered with the greenery of newborn life.

Simona Kossak⁹

This text only scratches the surface of the complexity of the Podlasie region and the countless stories remembered by the Białowieża Forest. It would nonetheless be a disservice to romanticize the region as a utopia of feminist histories, Slavic mythology, and alternative social structures. This same region votes for the right-wing and employs much of its borderland population in the Border Guard, which directly enforces the capitalist nation-state. The persistent mysticism is an underlayer of these realities, and these pockets of alternative histories are a light to follow on the path to imagining a future that defies border capitalism.

Where do we go from here? How do we harvest these alternative imaginaries into something that can activate long-term social and political change?

Returning to the beginning, the ecological and humanitarian struggles happening around the Białowieża Forest, and the human and more-than-human solidarities that have formed around these fights, show an active defiance of borders. Fighting to prevent interference in the forest ecosystem by State Foresters and their business allies is the same as the struggle to enable the passage of people on the move through the forest. Both form an act of kinship with human and more-than-human entities.

Kin, in the broadest sense, is an active sense of recognition that we are bound up, implicated in one another—not only materially but also in terms of political and historical responsibility. It weaves invisible lines that uphold the body trapped in the thick of the forest or, elsewhere, in the middle of the sea.

Olga Cielemeńska¹⁰

¹⁰ Olga Cielemeńska, 'The Grammar of Belonging: Bodies, Borders and Kin in the Belarusian-Polish Border Crisis' in *Feminist Review* 134.1 (2023): 17.

While this quote refers only to the kinship between humans, I choose to expand it to kinship with the Forest. This kinship is the ground from which new realities could sprout; I wish for a closer coming together of the ecological and the humanitarian movements. I wish for our imaginations to take a few steps forward, to imagine the falling of the wall – in both physical and metaphorical sense – and to rekindle a connection with local nature and practices that actively counter capitalistic structures.

A feminist imagination of an alternative future is in direct defiance of nation-state borders. Borders are the ultimate expression of patriarchal, exclusionary state capitalism. The enforced border that arbitrarily cuts through the Białowieża Forest, a living body, shows anthropocentrism at its worst. The abolition of borders and the celebration of natural ecosystems, their protection through co-existence and respect, and kinship between humans, and between humans and more-than-humans, are what I see as the foundations of a borderless forest feminism. The Białowieża Forest provides a fertile ground for sprouting new feminist practices in this part of the world.



włosy / ناوسی گ / hair – Sutari

The song WŁOSY / ناوسی گ / HAIR was composed by Sutari together with Iranian artists, poets, actresses, performers: Tara Fatehi, Sara Ramezani, Sarah Akbari and Roxana Ghari. The song addresses the violation of women's rights in both contexts. The spoken Persian words organically fall into the traditional Slavic melody. The refrain 'dana dana' expands in meaning through this coming together. 'Dana' means 'wise' in Persian, and 'given' in Polish – but the phrase 'oj dana dana' is a traditional calling to a Slavic water spirit, often featured in songs and carols.

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Soil-making and the Grid of the Atlas: Histories and Imaginings of a Queer Trans Socialist Herbalism

Socialist Herbalism – Prologue

This reflection comes out of an ongoing long-term project that looks at the specific historical and geographic context of Eastern Europe, the Balkans, and the Baltics, in terms of these regions' geopolitical histories of state socialism and their specific visions of science and the environment in relation to conflict, occupation, ethno-nationalism, and the more current protectionist policies around borders, migration routes, and white supremacy.¹

'Socialist Herbalism' as a term and guiding concept seeks to ask how these histories can inform current questions and needs for community practices of care, and in terms of an ecological, artistic or educational knowledge-making.² It addresses processes of marginalization in healing and care practices, in particular around queer and trans people, and asks how networks of artists, herbalists, researchers, and gardeners can self-organize, access mutual aid, and sustain spaces where they can share knowledge and practices around herbal medicine, land, and the body. The project has nurtured the emergence of a collaborative practice and research network and a long-term collaboration with the self-organized Residency and Project Space MASSIA (massia.ee) situated in rural Estonia, through a series of in-person Socialist Herbalism Gatherings and online meetings.

These Gatherings are intended as opportunities to engage in conversation on histories and herbal knowledge, in a self-organized residency space, where practices of communal living and working

¹ See Catherine Baker, *Race and the Yugoslav Region*, Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2018 and Piro Rexhepi, *White Enclosures. Racial Capitalism and Coloniality Along the Balkans*, Durham: Duke University Press, 2022.

² See Maria Puig de la Bellacasa, *Matters of Care. Speculative Ethics in More Than Human Worlds*, Minnesota: University of Minnesota Press, 2017 and Leah Lakshmi Piepzna-Samarasinha, *Care Work: Dreaming Disability Justice*, Vancouver: Arsenal Pulp Press, 2018.

are part of the process of creating temporary collectives. Sharing can happen in the kitchen, in the garden, whilst handling medicinal herbs from the apothecary, whilst doing some of the never-ending reproductive and care labor that soil, plants, human-made environments with roofs, and our own bodies need. If you are interested to join, get in touch.



Fig 1-14. *Familia tradițională merge pe pământ/Traditional Family Walks onto Land*, 2021- (paper collage with found educational materials from Massia Project and Residency Space, Massiaru, Estonia, by author).

Hetero-Grounds on Granular Terrestrial Walks

They were guides on how to walk. They were instructions on how to thread the ground. They were picturing human figures, particular ones. Gendered ones. Traditional family ones. They were thinking of the *mens sana in corpore sano*. They were *figuring* the human body, in the land-scape. In the mountains. In the forests. Showing the gendered family with their child/children walking into the scapes. They were guides in how to travel through the spheres of the national body. Instructions on how to be a social/socialist body. They were guides on how to build the masculine body. The Romanian dead-lift. The gym of the woods. Walk with a stick. Hold on to the ground as you traverse it, as you climb it. The categories were fuzzy. The horizon was trippy, escaping the line, the strip, the grid. Some bodies never seen in this landscape. Queer bodies of monstrous times, the ground was forming between, under and within them; they were bodies sedimented in the soil. Bodies composed, molecular forms that start in the earth, the ground, the feeling of reeling off path.

They were materials. Pamphlets. Small formats. I found them in a former boarding school in a village in Estonia, which now functions as a self-organized residency space called MASSIA. These are the figures you see in the collages: majority white, able bodied, visibly gendered, and paired up human figures, together with maps, routes, indications, and educational materials on natural environments. Giving into mutational shapes. Goo. Butterflies going through their metamorphic stages. Molecular dissections of plants, landscapes, and machines for extraction. Obsessive *figuring* without *figuring out* what is not pictured on these heteropatriarchal terrestrial walks. A first aid image becoming an embrace. Working towards masculine dreams turns into a kink. Insect life stages and earth forming strata move through homoerotic plates. See *fig.1-14*. Statues, hinges, lassoes, a ride through power relations of gender and nation.

Convoluting abstractions leading the zones of enclosure. Body comes in, comes through and through the lines, the angles, the gills of breathing and forming, it attacks itself to become loose. To leave form and shapeshift into divergence, dive low into swampy waters of bogs as they hold our *transcestors*. Leave the body behind and the human, too. Leave language as category and meaning, adopt a crawling stance as you lay a kiss on the shoulder of a transman with a fish head. Hold his figure up from the waist, from behind as he lies down, and let the dragonflies aid his legs vertically on the bench. Work out how to figure and never figure out unless in small gath-

erings, where it is safe to do so. Bundle up a row of nettles, hoard them over your head and wrestle in front of the field, next to the potato patch. They might have been buried in the autumn leaves, growing tubercula: the soil here is as nourishing as anywhere for them. They did well this year, let's throw in a ritual, an incantation, a libation, and a howl. In mourning, soil is a portal.



Fig 11 *ab. Pas cu pas, măsurătoare / Figuring landscapes, 2021-* (paper collage with found educational materials from Massia Project and Residency Space, Massiaru, Estonia, by author).

Nation and Soil-Making – Romanian Black Earth

I also found a book in the basement of a library in London. The Geographic Monograph of The Popular Republic of Romania (P.R.R.) Annex Section, published in 1960, contains a section of maps and an essay proposing a history of soil taxonomy and distribution of such soils across the country's territory. The exercise is double, if not triple in its intention: first, to represent in cartographic form the range of natural resources of the land. Thereafter, to gather resonant scientific validation and coeval resonance with the taxonomies that define rich, fertile soils as an exceptional characteristic of Eastern European geography, through the category of *chernozem* or *black earth/black soil*. And concomitantly, to offer continuity and legitimacy to ethnonational projects of the 19th century, by excavating lineages of scientific research, conversation, and study in line with the work of Russian geologist Vasily Vasilievich Dokuchaev, the most known proponent of the Russian *chernozem* soil type (1883). This three-fold effort came with the intention to re-establish and validate visions of socialist Romanian science as a nation-building project.

In the essay at the end of the above-mentioned Geographic Monograph of The Popular Republic of Romania, the focus is on pedology (from *pedon* – the Greek word for soil) as a specific branch of soil science, which is concerned with the study of how soil is formed, how it evolves, and how it is modelled by the natural environment. There, the scientific figure of geologist Gheorghe Munteanu Murgoci is portrayed as a significant contemporary interlocutor of Dokuchaev, starting from the former's early soil research in 1906. Romanian soil science is thus positioned as an early adopter of the principles of the Russian Empire's Naturalist School³ and of the approach to pedology and pedogenesis (formation of soil) that follows from this school. Murgoci's published cartographic study on Romanian soils (1910) is cited extensively in the monograph. His claim that the full range of soil types found between the Black and Baltic Seas is matched in a relatively reduced Romanian territory, stretching between the Danube and the Carpathian Mountains, is highlighted and celebrated. It seems that a certain search for scientific continuity is sought after in this large-scale national and, at this point in history, socialist scientific effort. In 1948, the monograph states, the re-organization of scientific research in the Popular Republic of Romania saw various state-driven exercises in

³ Saint Petersburg Society of Naturalists, <https://spboc.ru/en>, last accessed 24 April 2025.

plotting out and mapping the resources of the land, and the political attempt here is one of solidifying the monograph as 'the first general synthesis of various pedological studies'.⁴ The insistence on continuity between a reformed socialist science and the existing scientific research completed pre-1948 is clear and the national project prides itself in a kind of knowledge about the land that it wishes to continue: one that is aligned with other socialist scientific projects, a grandeur of knowledge-production not willing to break with the national body of land it sits on and the soil it breaks down into categorical analysis.

To understand the history of soil taxonomy, we need to return and attend to how scientific knowledge production has been mapped onto the Cold War, and specifically to the emergence of geopolitical histories of taxonomic orders. At present, there is an active Russian Soil Classification system, a United States Soil Taxonomy, and a World Reference Base for Soil Resources, making the class of *black soils* difficult to categorize with exactitude. In the so-called U.S. Soil Taxonomy, 'black soils form a distinct cluster that roughly corresponds to the Mollisols Order. However, the taxonomic distance within the group may be significant.'⁵ The differences are generated from historical traditions and are based on pedogenetic concepts. Therefore, establishing the scientific basis for the *black soil* group would need to account for several factors derived from geopolitical, historical, socio-material, and political considerations, such as the 'uniformity of land use, common threats or conservation practices'.⁶ In this study, the authors only entertain such considerations briefly while the rest of the article is dedicated to an extensive quantitative analysis, where *objective soil properties* and *calculation of taxonomic differences* are detailed in data analyses and through visualization techniques to measure the taxonomic distances between different categories. In the conclusion, the interpretation offered by Alexey Sorokin and his collaborators points back to the unaddressed directions of geopolitical, historical, and socio-material conditions which led to the creation of this soil category. Thus, what is proposed as a closing statement is that 'the group "black soils" should be fuzzy,

⁴ Nicolae Florea, Vladimir Markovici Fridland, *Geographic Monograph of The Popular Republic of Romania* (P.R.R.), Bucharest: Romanian State Press, 1960, p. 465.

⁵ Alexey Sorokin, Philip Owens, Vince Láng, Zhou-Dong Jiang, 'Black soils in the Russian Soil Classification system, the US Soil Taxonomy and the WRB: Quantitative correlation and implications for pedodiversity assessment'. *Catena* 196 (2021), p. 1.

⁶ Ibid, p. 2.

and no limits should be used.⁷

From early 20th century taxonomical divisions which were extended into the Cold War scientific competitions, the contemporary interest in establishing the distance between soil categories and bridging that distance appears as the spectre of some need for a *World Ordering* of soils – one that would incorporate the histories of emergence of taxonomies, as well as the taxonomical orders and their similarities and differences. Nevertheless, we can find a challenge and a question in this effort to understand taxonomical differences: how can soil science be understood today, if we consider the long colonial histories and geopolitical realities from which these taxonomic practices have emerged? As we have seen above, the article by Sorokin et. al. appears to end in a confused place: what emerges is a fuzzy ground. The taxonomical differences collude with geo-formations of what the category of *chernozem* – also known as *rich soil* – is, who owns it, and how it can be incorporated into national resources. A quest for regional – read imperial and colonial – exercises repeatedly circles back to self-evidencing how land specificity and exceptionalism are created by politically-driven cartographic efforts, border-making and, most recently, through the re-emergence of questions on the World Ordering of scientific knowledge. The extent to which the initial Russian Naturalist School's classification of soil is deployed via pedological scientific study in the Geographic Monograph of The Popular Republic of Romania is linked to and stimulated by efforts to map and classify land for its use in extractive agricultural practices. In soil science of the 20th century, the emergence of soil as a dynamic, independent, and morphologically complex body is connected to its use in extractive practices, through zoning, planting, and measures to increase productivity as they have been deployed in the formation of nation states, land laws, and the creation of enclosures. In the Geographic Monograph of the Popular Republic of Romania, the cartographic effort is geared toward establishing a geographical present that highlights national resources and the potential for land extraction. Pedology is one specific branch of the scientific study and mapping of land and territory that serves in the solidification of the Romanian nation state. With this vast nation-wide cartographic effort that the monograph exercises, the Popular Republic of Romania claims its exceptional share of resources and subscribes to a narrative of land extraction.

⁷ Ibid, p. 10.

Cartography is a tool of measurement, calculation, land abstraction, and the reduction of a given territory to its exploitable resources, and it has been in continuous use since the Mercatorian territorializations of the 1600s. European soil science (regardless of the taxonomic orders of East/West) has developed and is premised on the spiraled mobilization of obsessions with mapping what's below – the human body, the surface of the Earth or that of bodies of water, as seen in branches of modern science such as anatomy, physiology, geology, or biology. The mapping strategies of the 19th century and their violence complicit with colonialism and extraction, including the racialized lens for visualizing deep into bodies and lands,⁸ are coeval with the emergence of pedology and understanding of pedogenesis (how soil was formed) in what we now call soil science. Mapping the territory, including soil types, and lifting up the category of the chernozem served the P.R.R. in creating a national state socialist scientific vision of the commons as exceptional to Eastern Europe.

Figuring In Taxonomic Fictions

Science is fiction; Dokuchaev's idea of soil was built on an idea of aliveness, of constant movement of the ground. His paradigm of bioturbation (the effects of living organisms on soil matter, e.g.: worms moving through soil) goes: $S = f(c,l,o,r,p) \cdot t$. Soil formation or pedogenesis is a function of (climate, organisms, relief, parent material) relative to time. Long-term interactions of climate and biota with parent rocks create the turning over, the mixture of soil, and sediment. A granular equation with multiple variables, it had the quality of acknowledging degrees of complex participation in the genesis of what we now generally understand as soil, as a biotic and abiotic system of bodies forming through long temporalities and in intra-action,⁹ inter-relatedness. The so-called *parent* rocks and the relief participate in change, they are transformed by climatic elements and mixed in with living organisms. The upper layer of the surface of the earth is, in this paradigm, seen not only as a static rock formation but also, to some degree, as an indeterminate yet calculable equation. The unit for measurement and calculation in the case of soil science is the *pedon*, understood interestingly in soil taxonomy as the smallest reducible unit and at the same time, not

⁸ See Katherine McKittrick, *Dear Science and Other Stories*, Durham: Duke University Press, 2021.

⁹ See the work of Karen Barad.



Fig 3-18. *Întindere pe corp și pământ confuz / Stretch strides on fuzzy grounds* 2021 – (paper collage with found educational materials from Massia Project and Residency Space, Massiaru, Estonia, by author).

as individual.¹⁰ *Pedon* in soil science is a body of soil, three dimensional and possible to section for its so-called soil horizons. The horizon is formed by a multiplicity of soil elements, and the pedon is the unit and the multitude. Composite, made linear, this kind of horizon sometimes manages to trip up category-making.

What can this kind of slippery, fuzzy ground offer towards a *fig-uring* out of what grounds we stand on? Imagine a slippage into a fictional slither of space: we start from a *parent* rock, if you may, from the surface of the earth. Try to go deep but do not exert extractive force.

¹⁰ Alfred Hartemink, Alex McBratney, Robert White, *Soil Science*, London: Routledge, 2009.

Enjoy breakthroughs and composting pleasures, as some sort of soil multitude of *pedons*. We start from *topos* and look for *lithos* (rock), for cracks, for holes to stick our fingers in and caress a geranium peeking out of volcano rests; we hope to be covered in the *rhegos* (blanket) that hugs the surface, without losing connection to depth.

However, Dokuchaev's factor paradigm could be broadened to accept all exogenic bodies, or simply *exons* (E), on terrestrial planets as the function of exogenic factors (ef) activity in time.¹¹ What comes from this proposition is: can we revise what we understand as a body outside of our individual unit of self or outside of the Earth's surface? Given that soils on the Moon or Mars do not neatly fall into the pedological definition, the task is to revise how we define *biota*, or rather, to look at the ways in which we are willing to un-define or multiply our definition of *biota*, recognizing that this is tied to how we define what soil is. Imagining this slither where the function 'f' in the paradigm stands for expanding and originating in zones of elsewhere of exogenic bodies is the speculative invitation that Victor Targulian et. al. offer. Transformation comes here in a scalar sense, lifting the terrestrial to the planetary. Thus, a planetary exogenesis formula is derived as $E = f(ef1, ef2, ef3...)$, and may be applicable to any planet. Multi-planetary study of soil blankets (regoliths) is the horizon proposed by the authors in the conclusion of their paper.¹²

The extension of Dokuchaev paradigm give us possibility (sic) to divide all extraterrestrial exogenic formations into two universal groups: sitons and transons. The goal of extraterrestrial pedology is the study of sitons of other planets, i.e. formed in situ vertically-horisonated exogenic profiles and coatings, with appropriate applying of all approaches and methods of terrestrial pedology. We guess that only the extraterrestrial sitons could be perceived as soil-like bodies, either abiotic or bio-abiotic (in case of life finding on Mars).¹³

From planetary to multi-planetary pedogenesis, pedology elongates itself in this imagination of extra-terrestrial space. The risk of this

¹¹ Victor Targulian, Nikita Mergelov, David Gilichinsky, Sergey Sedov, Nikita Demidov, Sergey Goriaychin, Alexander Ivanov, 'Dokuchaev's soil paradigm and extraterrestrial soils', 19th World Congress of Soil Science, *Soil Solutions for a Changing World*, Brisbane, Australia, 1-6 August, 2010, p. 1.

¹² Ibid.

¹³ Ibid, p. 4.

Lost Hummus

Even if Dokuchaev 'recognized and confirmed the importance of climate, parent material, organisms, and relief as factors that formed the soil—the action of time and humans were considered less important'.¹⁴ The relative effects of time and human actions and interventions in soil were not imagined as strong factors in soil formation, soil life, and soil categories. 140 years after Dokuchaev argued for the soil category of the *chernozem*, soil science research shows that 'the "breadwinner soil" of Moldova and others of the formerly occupied territories of the U.S.S.R. had presented a reduction in hummus content of 43.2%'.¹⁵ This reality was mainly due to industrial agricultural practices used over long periods of time that impacted the soil, such as 'the non-use of organic fertilizers and lack of perennial and annual leguminous grasses in crop rotation' which led to the intensification of 'the process of hummus lost (dehumification) in the chernozems'.¹⁶

Lost hummus asks to be grieved.

The *chernozem* as profiled by Dokuchaev in the 19th century haunts us as an artefact, as an exhibit to be displayed and archived in museified ways. This is how research on *chernozems* started and circulated in world fairs and exhibitions. For instance, in the 1889 *Exposition Universelle* in Paris, 'the most memorable was cubic monolith (about 9.71 cubic meters in volume) of real chernozem soil from Voronezh province, as Russian agricultural treasure'.¹⁷ This piece of soil, the size of a transport container, was excavated in full and travelled to be exhibited. The treasure-status of the *chernozem* was well suited to the boasting and bragging characteristic of the resource races of the 19th and 20th centuries. It continued to form an important point of reference in the scientific imagination of abundant resources for the U.S.S.R. and Socialist Republics like Romania. It was one of the horizons of worldbuilding that was produced as exceptional and inexhaustible, a specific kind of socialist imaginary around soil as resource for growth: vegetal and economic.

¹⁴ Hartemink, p. 89.

¹⁵ Valerian Cerbari, Tamara Leah, Nicolai Leah, 'Typical Black Soils of Moldova – 140 years after its Study by V.V. Dokuchaev', Eastern European Chernozems – 140 years after V. Dokuchaev International Scientific Conference, Chişinău, 2-3 October 2019, p. 59.

¹⁶ Ibid, p. 60.

¹⁷ Ivan Vtorov, *Soil as Museum Exhibit in Russia*, p. 13. medzinárodné Erbe sympózi-um/13th International ERBE Symposium, Banská Štiavnica, Slovakia, 15-20 June 2015, https://www.erbe-symposium.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/04/Abstracts_Erbe_Symposium_13_B_St_2015.pdf, p. 239.

Considering the reality of the over 40% loss of hummus, I turn to Ros Gray and Shela Sheikh's reading according to which the Earth itself can feel wretched 'because its soil—that thin layer of earth at the surface of the planet upon which we depend for life—is contaminated, eroded, drained, burnt, exploded, flooded and impoverished on a worldwide scale'.¹⁸ The Earth and the horizons diffracted from it feel wretched in this case because the study of the chernozem is steeped in imperial science and a monocultural logic of life (vegetal and otherwise) and essentially presents a 'monoculture of knowledge'.¹⁹ The participation of the U.S.S.R. in what Gray and Sheikh have described as processes of the 'wholesale classification of forms of life enacted by imperial science' is visible in large-scale cartographic exercises, like the *Atlas of Habitats and Resources – Medicinal Plants of the U.S.S.R.*²¹ In-depth botanical plates of medicinal plants, naturally occurring and cultivated, are mapped onto types of soil, scapes, and climates, producing readings of the territory of empire, claiming grasses and moss from bogs and lowlands, pine from the taigas, wormwood from desert areas, cedar and birch from the mountains, Mediterranean forests of fluffy oak, healing mushrooms, ginseng and astragalus root from Central Asia.

Soil portals open knowledge grief-holes. In Massia, on one side of the former boarding school building, where these materials were found, a large linden tree fell to the ground where it continues making flowers. In one of the Socialist Herbalism Gatherings, we imagined them as a crip trans elder, lying next to the pond. Three sisters (corn, pumpkin, beans) are planted at their feet. Queer and trans bodies stretched across their trunk and large branches, thinking of how to ask each other about our access needs. The Splitgill mushroom grows abundant on the elder's body, they have plenty of phenotype choices to make gender from (over 23.000). As I lay my body on the elder tree, I remember how I was told that the Pityriasis Versicolor fungus lives on my chest; I imagine it as an expression of hair-like formations. With this hairy-fungi chest, I dream to put my

¹⁸ Ros Gray, Shela Sheikh, 'The Wretched Earth Botanical Conflicts and Artistic Interventions', *Third Text* 32 (2-3,2018), p. 164.

¹⁹ Santos Boaventura de Sousa, 'Introduction: Opening Up the Canon of Knowledge and Recognition of Difference' in Santos (ed) *Another Knowledge is Possible: Beyond Northern Epistemologies*, London: Verso, 2008.

²⁰ Ros Gray, Shela Sheikh, 'The Wretched Earth Botanical Conflicts and Artistic Interventions', *Third Text* 32 (2-3,2018), p. 166.

²¹ A.I Tolmachev, *Atlas of Habitats and Resources – Medicinal Plants of USSR*, Moscow, (in Russian), 1980/1983 Edition.

ear to the ground, next to linden flowers to sooth headaches, chew on some ground elder, and be held by moss and lichen, leaning into crip time, hands stretched, cutting out and gluing together small pieces of paper, imagining fuzzy common grounds through soil horizons we have mourned and broken down. See *fig. 74-116*.

Gratitude for this text's appearance goes to Sepideh Ardalani and the multiple experiments in knowing otherwise shared together in MASSIA and beyond. For slow walks and bed-bound times of co-thinking, co-conspiracy, and collaboration, and for laying on various surfaces together over time: bog, moss, volcanic rock, sand. Thank you to Lucie Schroeder for planting the three sisters by the linden tree and making crip time oracles for zines, and to Csilla Hódi, for the encounter with the Splitgill mushroom and all our ear and queer myco-orientations to come.

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Losing the Common Ground. Common Spaces of Everyday Creativity and Their Enclosures in Post-Socialist Poland

This is a story of spaces once inhabited by our grandmothers, to then be lost both by them and their daughters, our mothers. We, the granddaughters, long for these spaces. This story is told by us, the granddaughters who refuse to let our grandmas walk away in silence; the silence of their lived experiences and knowledges being drowned out by neoliberal triumphalism, accompanied by the noise of conservative reactions. This is a story about the emptiness felt in the 'desert of post-socialism'¹ and about the seeds of life and resistance that germinate under our feet.

Commoning in Post-Socialist Memory

The experiences of post-socialist societies can teach us a lot about the multi-faceted character of neoliberal enclosures and dispossessions – which entail the restructuring of the ownership relation (with private ownership having barely any alternatives), the transformation of ways of working and living (under increased precarity and isolation), and the fundamental shift in values (with entrepreneurialism and individualism displacing solidarity and cooperation of the past). As neoliberalism has achieved a status of global hegemony, those developments reached a planetary scale.² However, the specificity of post-socialism lies not only in that neoliberal policies were implemented in a particularly brutal and often untamed manner and at a faster pace than ever before³ but, above all, in the nature of 'transition', which developed out of a system fundamentally distinct to

¹ Srećko Horvat and Igor Stiks (eds) *Welcome to the Desert of Post-Socialism: Radical Politics After Yugoslavia*, London: Verso Books, 2015.

² David Harvey, *A Brief History of Neoliberalism*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005.

³ See e.g. Naomi Klein, *The Shock Doctrine: The Rise of Disaster Capitalism*, New York: Metropolitan Books/Henry Holt, 2007.

Western Fordist capitalism and Southern post-colonial economies, representing a mix of subsistence built around (often indigenous) commons and (neo)colonial control and extraction from the West.

The state socialist attempt to build a communist society is often approached on the Left as a failure in its totality,⁴ which leaves little to no space for affirmation and learning from the experiences of solidarity and emancipation shared by the people who lived in the regimes which fell in the late 80s and early 90s. This, in turn, results in a general lack of consideration for the former 'second world'⁵ and its people in leftist debates on the commons. If we look at what examples of commoning 'inspire' the major theorists of the commons, it is striking that there is a noticeable absence of any cases related to (post)socialism. Although there have been some recent attempts to fill this gap – a notable example being the volume *The Commonist Horizon* by Mary N. Taylor and Noah Brehmer⁶ – those voices, at large, still do not seem to influence broader, 'general' debates on commons and commoning. This erasure of the 'Global East'⁷ from the maps of commons and commoning drawn by Western theorists is revealing of the epistemological marginalization of the region and its people. This results both from the failure of the 'communist' project, the peripheral position of scholars and theorists from post-socialist countries, and limited global recognition of the vast history of local decolonization debates and struggles. This not only invisibilizes East Europe and its inhabitants, suggesting that their experiences and knowledges are of a secondary nature, but the broader tendency of marginalizing East Europe on the Left,

⁴ See e.g. Silvia Federici, *Feminism and the Politics of the Commons*, Oakland: PM Press, 2019, p. 95.

⁵ With its cold war connotations, the terminology dividing the world into its first, second, and third parts, loses on importance, rightfully being criticized for its Western-centric orientation. However, as the conceptualization of global inequalities graduates towards accenting divisions between Global North and Global South, the Global East/former "second world" is being lost out of sight. This omission, I argue, reflects the positioning of Eastern Europe as an area of irrelevance for the theorisation of the commons. For more detailed discussion see Marta Grzechnik. 'The Missing Second World: On Poland and Postcolonial Studies', *Interventions. International Journal of Postcolonial Studies* 21:7 (March 2019), pp. 998-1014 and Martin Müller, 'In Search of the Global East: Thinking between North and South'. *Geopolitics* 25 (2020), pp. 734–755.

⁶ Mary N. Taylor and Noah Brehmer (eds) *The Commonist Horizon. Futures Beyond Capitalist Urbanization*, Brooklyn: Common Notions, 2023. Other examples include Iva Čukić and Jovana Timotijević (eds) *Spaces of Commoning: Urban Commons in the ex-YU region*, Belgrade: Ministry of Space / Institute of Urban Policies, 2020, or Horvat and Striks (eds) *Welcome to the Desert of Post-Socialism*.

⁷ Müller, 'In Search of the Global East'.

apart from creating epistemic injustice, also affects theoretical engagement with the commons, and, inevitably, weakens the theory itself. Theoretical debates reluctant to consider phenomena such as Yugoslav communal self-management and self-government⁸ or the massive grassroots mobilization of Polish society to sustain general strikes organized in 1980-1981 in response to the economic and political crises of the time,⁹ inevitably lose sight of the not-so-distant history of commoning that occurred on an unprecedentedly large scale. In neglecting these concrete experiences of commoning drawn from socialist contexts, theoretical engagements deprive themselves of relevant knowledge and inspiration concerning how to cultivate commons in the present.

This brings me to focus specifically on state-socialist and post-socialist Poland. As a Polish person, the history of commoning and enclosures there, where my home is, absorbs me the most; my genealogy is firmly entangled with that past, and I'm fascinated by the life paths of women from my family, in particular my grandmothers. In Poland, particularly in liberal discourse, older women are commonly associated with backwardness, blamed at times for the political success of the most conservative forces. Older women are likely to be called 'mohair berets', which refers to the popular type of hat associated with the listeners of the Catholic and Far-right 'radio Maria'. In 2007, the center-right wing party *Civic Platform* (PO) launched an infamous 'prank' campaign, encouraging young people to hide their grandma's IDs, to prevent them from voting for *Law and Justice* (PiS) and allied parties. This not only relieves the actual makers and beneficiaries of the neo-conservative hegemony from responsibility for their actions but also positions one of the most dispossessed social groups as its scapegoat. It also prevents us from recognizing the conservative backlash as a new, neoliberal invention, one that relates to material social relations of (re)production and is not merely an ahistorical cultural phenomenon associated with the group thought of as the bearers of tradition.

What the conflation of the older generation of women with conservatism also obscures is the complexity of older women's life experiences. Both of my grandmothers have been devoted Catholics, but they not only condemned any right-wing fundamentalisms

⁸ Ana Vilenica, 'Who Has "The Right to Common"? Decolonizing Commoning in East Europe' in Taylor and Brehmer (eds) *The Commonist Horizon*.

⁹ Jan Sowa, *Inna Rzeczpospolita jest możliwa! Widma przeszłości, wizje przyszłości*, Warszawa: W.A.B., 2015.

but were generally guided by a system of values grounded in empathy, a sense of justice and equality and not necessarily by prescription to the doctrines of the church. Throughout their lifetimes they were particularly open about bodily experiences related to reproduction and were outraged by the newly introduced anti-abortion policies in the country. Still, what for many years remained less apparent to me and what I've learnt to recognize and appreciate as an integral part of their selves is their rich experiences beyond (grand)motherhood: how many friends they had, how close they were with their neighbors, the hobbies they had, and their need to be engaged in matters of the local community.

My preoccupation with spaces of commoning in state socialist and post-socialist Poland also results from its peculiar history of labor – which still demonstrates the opportunities and pitfalls for the working class. A history that teaches us how to effectively organize in the everyday and in moments of uprising and, most importantly, warns us not to squander the gains won in past struggles by subjecting ourselves to divisions and exclusions.

Reproducing Life in the Polish People's Republic

The narrative of the complete failure of the communist project, which discourages exploring the commons that emerged in its context, is also a consequence of patriarchal generalizations and the erasure of vernacular experiences, particularly those of working-class women – promoted by the neoliberal project of 'transitology', but also observable in leftist and feminist debates.¹⁰ Centering the discussions about state socialism around production has resulted in neglecting the importance of social reproduction and, consequently, in overlooking the commons as the cornerstone of the everyday life of communities.

While focusing on production in our analyses of state socialism, we can, indeed, be overwhelmed by the monstrous power of the state – exercised within the centralized model of capital accumulation, enabled by the rapid processes of industrialization and urbanization, often occurring at the cost of the peasantry. Recently, even

¹⁰ For a critique of those tendencies see: *Agnieszka Mrozik, Akuszerki transformacji. Kobiety, literatura i władza w Polsce po 1989 roku*, Warszawa: Instytut Badań Literackich PAN, 2012 and Zofia Łapniewska, 'First-world aspirations and feminism translocation: In search of economic and leftist alternatives.' in Eszter Kováts (ed.) *Solidarity in Struggle: Feminist Perspectives on Neoliberalism in East-Central Europe*, Budapest: Friedrich-EbertStiftung, 2016, pp. 21-31.

in the field of (industrial) labor studies, more and more analyses are being produced that – rather than stressing the ‘totalitarian’ control of the state – underline workers’ agency in shaping their everyday worlds of labor, including in the factories.¹¹ If we, however, consider reproduction as a starting point for the theorization of (post) state-socialist relations, a slightly different picture emerges. This is due to the crucial role played by the commons in reproducing workers’ labor power and their everyday lives. Social reproduction under the Polish People’s Republic (PPR) – by no means unique in its policies compared to other countries from the Eastern Bloc – was far from fully ‘commoned’. After intensified efforts to collectivize reproduction during the Stalinist period,¹² the privatization, or ‘housewifisation’¹³ of women’s reproductive labor became more prominent. This, as Małgorzata Fidelis explains, was related to the compromise established by the socialist state with the male ‘aristocracy’ of labor – so-called ‘skilled workers’ threatened by the sudden emancipation of their female colleagues.¹⁴

Still, the socialization of reproduction, or, in some regards, its commoning, continued to oil the wheels of people’s everyday lives. Spontaneous initiatives occurring at a local level and state-regulated institutions – often co-dependent and materialized in one single space – both played important roles. In particular, institutions such as the Institute of the Household, ‘Practical Lady’ (sic!) advisory drop-ins, and rural and urban circles of housewives are worth mentioning here. They provided support for the execution of reproductive labor; they equipped women (as it was them still who were burdened with care responsibilities) with material resources and skills, and, above all, gave them platforms to meet and exchange, connecting them to one another to overcome the isolation they would have experienced had they had to perform reproductive labor alone at home.

While analyzing social reproduction – a term encompassing various phenomena – in the PPR’s context, it is often impossible

¹¹ Elizabeth C. Dunn, *Privatizing Poland: Baby Food, Big Business, and the Remaking of Labor*, Cornell University Press, 2004; Aleksandra Leyk and Joanna Wawrzyniak, *Cięcia. Mówiona historia transformacji*, Warszawa: Wydawnictwo Krytyki Politycznej, 2020; Małgorzata Fidelis, *Women, Communism, and Industrialization in Postwar Poland*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010.

¹² Fidelis, *Women, Communism, and Industrialization in Postwar Poland*.

¹³ Maria Mies, *Patriarchy and Accumulation on a World Scale: Women in the International Division of Labour*, London: Zed Books Ltd., 2014.

¹⁴ Fidelis, *Women, Communism, and Industrialization in Postwar Poland*.

to tell apart the reproduction of workers' labor power against the reproduction of communities and their everyday lives. In the PPR, for instance, spaces such as workers' hotels were simultaneously spaces where basic human needs of access to food and shelter were fulfilled, and where social life was cultivated, close relations with others were established, and, last but not least, where leisure and fun were shared. In her book *Women, Communism, and Industrialization in Postwar Poland*, Fidelis approaches those spaces as providing opportunities for young women, workers, and students, often from conservative rural communities, to seek emancipation in the urban space. Becoming part of communities with other young women with similar backgrounds and aspirations, living together and seeking the pleasures of their new lifestyles, they created – and enjoyed – a whole new world.¹⁵

Common Spaces of Everyday Creativity

What interests me most in the history of commoning during the PPR is its creative aspect. I believe that what I am here describing as common spaces of everyday creativity enabled individuals and communities to develop their potentials and to create new forms of everyday experience. With this description I mean to refer to the already mentioned institutions built mostly around reproductive labor, but also a variety of other cultural and free-time initiatives like amateur theatre, tourist and crafts clubs, or allotment gardens. Even if some of those institutions – in particular, the Institute of the Household – tended to transmit state policies in a top-down manner, the majority of the other institutions remained semi-autonomous, often sustained through people's engagement and, I would risk saying, the universal human propensity to common, wherever time and space allows it. Allotment gardens seem to be a great example of autonomy as, in most cases, the role of the state was limited to providing people with land that would later be cultivated and used by them according to their own needs and imagination.¹⁶ As all of these spaces could be situated somewhere on the spectrum in-between

¹⁵ This, however, was not without discontent – with local neighbourhoods expressing disapproval of their 'frivolous' conduct or, in most extreme cases, their fathers attempt to control them at a distance through local authorities. *Fidelis, Women, Communism, and Industrialization in Postwar Poland*.

¹⁶ I approach allotment gardens as commons despite their rental system based on leasing the garden parcels to individuals and families – it is because the individual parcels were small and the whole terrain 'belonged to' and was governed by everyone involved, not to mention the communal ways of living nurtured within those spaces.

state dependency and grassroots organizing, the everyday creativity mediated by them could be neither reduced to alignment with the official ideology and state institutions nor to revolting against them – even if everyday communal engagement enhanced people's capacities to resist, as I will discuss below.

How, then, did the state relate to those spaces in practice? Some of them were organized in neighborhoods, using municipal resources. Still, most of them were operated by large state-owned companies – using their own spaces and funds. In my hometown, Oleśnica, during the times of the PPR, there were three main cultural centers: one municipal and two funded and managed by the local railway and shoemaking industries. In Oleśnica, the buildings of these facilities were centrally placed, integrating them more into the residential area than the industrial complexes – although this varied across different regional, architectural, and urbanist contexts. Quite often, these were some of the most noteworthy buildings in the towns. Their importance was probably most significant in the villages, where culture clubs were typically established within the former estates of the gentry. This can be seen as a material and symbolic revindication of whole centuries of exploitation and violence perpetrated against the peasants.

Commons, Creativity and Resistance

The first question that arises is whether those commons – if they were constituted by only workers from specific companies – were not 'gated', which in debates around the limitations of the commons in contemporary late-capitalist worlds stands for being exclusive and restricted to narrow groups of people.¹⁷ In praxis, they were usually inclusive, at least towards children and young people from the neighborhood. Given that most workplaces had social and cultural infrastructures such as community centers, culture and sports clubs, and had their own holiday resorts, most people had access to some kind of common space of everyday creativity. Some sectors of the industry, e.g. mining, were particularly privileged compared to others, while smaller employers generally offered poorer infrastructure. Very few people were completely excluded from access to any workplace-related commons – here, the position of those trying

¹⁷ George Caffentzis and Silvia Federici use the term 'gated commons' to discuss exclusive type of commons, guided by the interests of their 'shareholders', often hostile to an outside world. See: George Caffentzis and Silvia Federici, 'Commons against and beyond capitalism.' *Community Development Journal* 49 (2014), pp. 92-105.

their hands in the small private sector was most disadvantaged, but often even they could become members of joint associations representing their interests and offering them access to basic social infrastructure.

My Grandma Marylka, a culinary worker, and a member of the food producing cooperative *Spółem* (which exists to this day, and, despite it having shrunk in numbers and limited the extent of its activity, still remains a cooperative) had access to the broad offer of social and leisure infrastructure through the cooperative. This included culture and social clubs for workers and for their children, a canteen, and even healthcare and social work services organized by *Spółem*. Still, my grandma was most impressed by the holiday infrastructure; she recalls her holidays in the *Spółem* holiday resorts in Zakopane in the Tatra mountains during the '70s with great nostalgia, emphasizing the length of her stays (2 weeks as opposed to the mere few days of holiday trips she had before), and the high quality and beauty of the facilities she visited. Those forms of state-controlled 'gating', although suggesting some limitations of commoning in the PPR, are still unparalleled to today's forms of exclusion from the commons based on criteria of wealth and income, as is the case, for instance, with the numerous food or housing cooperatives. These typically newly founded co-ops resemble other gated commons proliferating around the globe in their exclusive and limited character as they tend to be confined to organizing groups of privileged consumers that share similar interests.¹⁸ While those 'gated commons' of late capitalism are available to narrow, privileged sections of society, under the PPR, commoning was a generalized, paradigmatic experience.

Secondly, one could argue that such a territorial and institutional integration of reproduction, leisure, and, generally speaking, everyday life organized around the workplace as the state's 'long

¹⁸ The cooperatives which developed during the time of the Polish People's Republic are a more interesting case: they also exist nowadays in a limited form and are 'gated' in the sense that their members are privileged in relation to 'outsiders'. However, this 'gating' is not always class-related, but rather occurs along generational and biographical lines. For instance, workers from a specific enterprise might form a cooperative, which won't ever be open for new members in the future. Another interesting case is represented by the numerous cooperatives of flat owners in the majority of the older neighbourhoods of cities in Poland. They remain 'cooperatives' just nominally, as they are constituted by private flat owners, whereas the role of the 'cooperative' is limited to merely managing 'common' issues, such as renovations, cleaning of common areas, and gardening.

arm' would inevitably increase the latter's control over the lives of its subjects. However, the Polish context with its regular upheavals of workers, which culminated in the general strikes of 1980–1981 and the eventual establishment of *Solidarity*, contradicts such a claim. It seems that, in fact, the contrary was true: the workers' insurgencies and their capacities to organize and sustain a long-term engagement in emancipatory labor struggles were enabled thanks to the common spaces they shared beyond the factory's hall. Firstly, these spaces facilitated what one could call everyday forms of solidarity. Regular meetings of colleagues and their families along with engagement in practices such as dancing, singing, or gardening strengthened social bonds between workers. Most of those activities were embodied and thus generated specific affective connections and a sense of closeness. Those materially grounded social networks were conducive to the creation of a system of values in which communality, a sense of responsibility for one another, and mutual support played a central role.

The 'event' of *Solidarity*, that is, the formation of a grass-roots trade union organization coordinating a country-wide general strike, was thus enabled by the experience of solidarity in everyday life. The direct understanding of what it means to live in solidarity with others helped people conceive solidarity as a force that connects the individual worker to others, which could later be generalized to millions across the country. Here, unsurprisingly – given their propensity to be the keenest defenders of the commons across various contexts¹⁹ – women played a particularly significant role. After the first negotiation round in August of 1980 between the directorate of the Gdansk Shipyard (where the country-wide protests started) and representatives of the striking brigades, a compromise guaranteeing the end of the strike was agreed. However, four striking workwomen – Anna Walentynowicz, Alina Pieńkowska, Henryka Krzywonos, and Ewa Ossowska – decided to act to ensure the continuation of the Shipyard's occupation. They blocked the shipyard's gates with their bodies and delivered fiery speeches, voicing their disagreement with the gaining of temporary benefits promised by the directorship at the cost of compromising the solidarity with other striking brigades that had joined their struggles for more fundamental change in the direction of workers' self-determination.²⁰

¹⁹ Federici, *Feminism and the Politics of the Commons*.

Creativity is a vital force in forging the link between commons and labor struggles. Intensification of creative endeavors seems to be a defining trait of times of unrest and insurgency. Jacques Rancière approached the propensity of 19th century French proletarians to engage in literary activities as a manifestation of their revolutionary aspirations.²¹ They ceased to comply with the role of uneducated uncreative cogs in the capitalistic social machinery. By writing poems or participating in self-organized schools, they, Rancière argues, expressed claims to fundamental equality with the upper classes, traditionally associated with the production and consumption of knowledge, art, and literature. They were even ready to jeopardize the reproduction of their labor power – preferring to engage in those, usually night-time activities rather than sleeping to regenerate their energy. In a similar vein, Wiktor Marzec, a historian studying the Revolution of 1905, describes the spectacular outburst of grassroots educational and creative engagement by the working class just before and during the revolution.²² He accounts for this phenomenon through the new sense of dignity and aspiration attained by the proletarians, awakened by the hope in a future where their destiny would no longer be pre-determined by the rigid capitalist class order.²³

The intensification of the working class struggles of 1980-81, referred to at times as the 'Carnival of Solidarity', also brought about an impressive flourishing of new cultural and educational initiatives. I want to argue, however, that the pre-existing common spaces of creativity – in particular, those where people could collaborate on artistic projects and collectively develop new ideas, such as amateur theatre clubs or film discussion circles – played a similar function in the everyday before 1980, thus preparing the ground for the eventual moments of political mobilization and affective intensi-

²⁰ A detailed discussion of those events can be found in: Shana Penn, *Solidarity's Secret. The women who defeated communism in Poland*, Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2005.

²¹ Jacques Rancière, *Nights of Labor: The Workers Dream in Nineteenth Century France*, trans. John Drury, Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1989.

²² Wiktor Marzec, *Rebelia i reakcja. Rewolucja 1905 roku i plebejskie doświadczenie polityczne*, Kraków: UNIVERSITAS, 2016.

²³ While I appreciate Rancière's acknowledgement of working-class creativity, I find the fact that he explains its emergence through class-based aspirations to be somehow problematic. On the contrary, I believe that the true revolutionary power of working-class creativity lies in its dignifying, self-fulfilling, and subversive aspects, stressed more by Marzec, and not in the working class looking up to the elites and their bourgeois cultural activities with fascination.

fication. They mitigated social divisions caused by uneven levels of cultural capital and lent dignity to workers, who were not only defined as a productive force at the forefront of communist society according to official doctrine but also, in practice, could engage in different forms of creative expression and making, unrelated to the requirements of another five-year plan. In these common spaces of everyday creativity, thus, workers could perceive themselves as creative human beings, deserving of the rights to self-determination and pleasure. Furthermore, the dignifying character of those spaces and the experience of commoning in the everyday must have affected their self-perception as fully-fledged members of society, thus laying claim to the actualization of the premises of communism through *Solidarity's* revolution.

Gender Politics of the Commons and Their Enclosures

The commoning of the everyday – which I understand as collectively and actively sharing spaces of social reproduction and creativity, experiences of learning, creating, reflecting, and thus, generally speaking, sharing lives – also resulted in the redefinition of gender and family relations. It did not entirely overcome gendered divisions of labor – reinforced by the aforementioned compromise between the state and male 'skilled' workers and promoted as part of the 'Polish way to socialism'. However, this process of commoning did open traditional forms of the family to new experiences and modes of functioning, which became firmly embedded in local communities. Here, the transformative power of commoning was most significant for newcomers to the newly established urban industrial centers, freed from the ties of traditional family relations, and of their places of origin, they often transgressed (hetero)normative patterns and transformed familial, social relationships. Marek, a locksmith from the large pulp and paper plant in Świecie, recalls in a conversation transcribed in Aleksandra Leyk and Joanna Wawrzyniak's 'Cuts' how the social clubs and allotment gardens affected his family life:

Most of the people who came here from all over Poland came on their own, they were, so to speak, a bit orphaned. And here, after working hours, they created such informal families. Great friendships were formed. My sons don't call my friends 'Mr' or 'Mrs' but 'Uncle' and 'Auntie'. And that's a great thing because later on, as it turns out, these great friendships have unfortunately faded away somewhere.²⁴

In the vernacular memory of the PPR, the acknowledgement of the role of the state or state-owned enterprises in mediating reproduction is often expressed through the metaphor of motherhood. Namely, the enterprise is remembered as a caring mother.²⁵ Sometimes this association remained abstract, whereas in other cases it was a specific person who carried this 'maternal', caring relation – as was the case, for instance, with a director and dance instructor at the cultural center of railway industry ZNTK Oleśnica, referred to by participants in the dance group as 'Mummy' (Mamusia). This, once again, urges us to consider the relationship between the 'parental' function of the state, on the one hand, and, on the other, the agency and self-determination of the workers. It is true that the envisioning of the relationship between workers and enterprise as one between children and mother presumes the existence of hierarchies and dependencies limiting individual freedoms. Still, I would argue that by providing workers with spaces and other resources for commoning the enterprises, even if they aimed to enlarge their sphere of influence, this above all empowered workers' collectivity. Also, the quasi-motherly care experienced thanks to the enterprises' broad offer of welfare does not necessarily entail passivity and infantilization related to overt control. I am aware that in contexts with more surveillance and a more repressive state apparatus the emancipatory potential of the discussed institutions might have been significantly lower. In the Polish context, instead of parental control and the loss of agency, the metaphors of motherhood tend to underline the satisfaction of needs and care experienced by workers. Those metaphors, it has to be noted, do tend to essentialize care as a motherly, feminine vocation – however, if we look into what kind of essentialist approaches came to the fore with a neoliberal post-socialist turn, then we will see a far more naturalizing and de-subjectifying approach to both motherhood and care.²⁶

The true disempowerment of the workers, however, came with the displacement of the figure of a caring, if overprotective mother with a patriarchal father who imposed strict financial discipline and ruthless, inhumane labor relations. The masculinization of company management in 'transitional' Poland was literal, given the composi-

²⁴ Leyk and Wawrzyniak, *Ciecia. Mówiona historia transformacji*, p. 222.

²⁵ This appears in: Leyk and Wawrzyniak, *Ciecia. Mówiona historia transformacji*, Warszawa: Wydawnictwo Krytyki Politycznej, 2020; Dunn, *Privatizing Poland: Baby Food, Big Business, and the Remaking of Labor*. Cornell University Press, 2004, and Magdalena Okraska, *Ziemia Jałowa. Opowieść o Zagłębiu*, Warszawa: Trzecia Strona, 2018.

tion of the new cadres, who consisted predominantly of men – from foreign company owners and CEOs to the local ‘Marriot boys’/‘young wolves’ who made fast and spectacular careers. It was also structural, as the new hierarchies and power relations implemented in the course of structural adjustments resembled the ones that underpinned the patriarchal family. Many lost their jobs or were moved to temporary, unstable contracts. For those blue-collar laborers who stayed, the managerial turn brought about a strict work discipline, diminishing agency (as the whole decision-making power was delegated upwards) and a denial of the value of their labor (which was reconstructed as uncreative, unproductive, and meaningless).²⁷

Cuts in the Commons, Wounds in the Community

The enclosure of the common spaces of everyday creativity, entailed by (and in some cases preceding) the privatizations of the ‘long ‘90s’,²⁸ profoundly aggravated those changes. The enterprises’ ‘non-productive parts’, which used to facilitate those spaces of creativity before 1989, were the first to be sold off in the course of restructuration. Quite often, enterprise managers were starting to cut social and cultural infrastructure from their firms to make them more competitive and attractive in the eyes of potential buyers, before the actual privatization had even started. In the best-case scenario, enterprises were washing their hands of financial and legal responsibility for those spaces by handing them over to associations run by workers and retirees who, typically, had some claim to the (joint) ownership. This was a common case for the cooperatives of inhabitants of formerly enterprise-owned flats who then bought those flats, as well as for allotment gardeners’ associations. Sometimes, when one could seek potential profit, those spaces were commercialized as subsidiaries or as independent, spin-off privatized companies. Most common was, however, their complete liquidation.

²⁶ I have analysed those discursive shifts as belonging to a broader phenomenon of housewifisation of women’s labour in the ‘long ‘90s’. See my Master’s thesis ‘Class Wars: Patriarchy strikes back. Backlash and Neoliberal Transformation in the long ‘90s in Poland’ (2022) and “Domestic hens” and “young wolves” in the Polish ‘long ‘90s’. Towards a Feminist Political Economy of Creativity.’ (forthcoming in 2025; in: *East European Politics and Societies*).

²⁷ On managerial turn see: Dunn, *Privatizing Poland* and Leyk and Wawrzyniak, *Cięcia. Mówiona historia transformacji*.

²⁸ According to Kaliński, 7165 state-owned enterprises were privatized between 1990 and 2004 in Poland. Janusz Kaliński, *Transformacja gospodarki polskiej w latach 1989–2004*, Warszawa: Szkoła Główna Handlowa w Warszawie, 2009, p. 57.

'Living proletarians must put their feet some place, must strike from some place, must rest some place, must retreat to some place. Class war does not happen on an abstract board toting up profits and losses, it needs a terrain' – argues the Midnight Notes Collective.²⁹ This leads us to realize the extent to which the social, legal and, finally, physical enclosure of the commons – from the hedging of the land to the new, neoliberal forms of dispossession and displacement – disempowers the working class. Dispossessed from the terrain of the class war, it is also deprived from control over (the site of) labor and all the spaces where (everyday) life is lived, limiting its agency in shaping its experiences. By encountering these enclosures, the working class loses ground in all possible ways.

The consequences of the enclosure of spaces of everyday creativity during the '90s were devastating for Polish society. While individuals lost access to the spaces of creative expression and had to narrow down the reproduction of their everyday life to private spaces like households, entire communities disintegrated as they lost the material grounds that would support their practices of solidarity and cooperation. The smaller the town was, the fewer alternatives to the lost commons appeared on the market. And the poorer the individual was, the worse access they had to the newly commercialized spaces or gated commons. Working-class women were put in especially difficult circumstances: they faced not only impoverishment but also newly increased workloads, having to compensate for the state's retreat from the area of social reproduction. Simultaneously, they were affected by the new forms of exclusions and were marginalized even from the feminist movement characterized by the elitist and pro-capitalist attitudes typical of 'lean in' feminism³⁰ as well as of the labor struggles and narratives of the '90s.³¹ The liquidation of most of the places where they used to share reproductive labor with others in common (such as the previously mentioned 'Practical Lady' drop-ins) made things much worse, sometimes resulting in a vicious cycle of impoverishment. If one was burdened with reproductive work to the extent that it incapacitated one's chances of finding work in the labor market, thus earning little to no money and being unable to afford goods and services, one had to double her efforts in the household, having even less time for paid labor.

Did workers consent to the enclosure of the commons? The

²⁹ Midnight Notes Collective, *Introduction to the New Enclosures*, 10, 1990, p. 6.

³⁰ Mrozik, *Akuszarki Transformacji*.

³¹ Penn, *Solidarity's Secret*.

answer has to be nuanced and take into account the new divisions between workers, with some – for instance women or peasant workers – being more dependent on the commons and hesitant to accept the changes while others enthusiastically embraced their marketization and privatization. The latter group included in particular the male aristocracy of labor in the leadership of what became known as the 'Second Solidarity'. Solidarity – pacified under the almost two-year martial law of 1981-1983 and remaining in the underground for several years after – reconstituted itself at the end of the '80s as a conservative social movement with a much less democratic form, rather than as a union interested in labor affairs.³² Those privileged workers, even if they were not benefiting from the enfranchisement directly, through buying off their enterprises or being promoted to top-management positions, were looking forward to upwards mobility in the form of better material remuneration for their labor. As David Ost has argued, they hoped for the betterment of their individual material situation, whereas the deterioration of labor conditions as such – including decreasing democracy in the workplace or the layoffs of other workers – was for them a cost they were willing to pay. The slogan of *There Is No Alternative* (TINA) had also taken its toll: while many condemned the political and economic changes as inhumane and ruthless, they were often, simultaneously, persuaded that these were indispensable and without any alternative. As research by Aleksandra Leyk and Joanna Wawrzyniak suggests, the majority of people believed that enclosures, as unpleasant as they might have been, were a necessary condition for a better, even if distant, future.³³ In other words, workers were led into believing that cutting off the common spaces they enjoyed under the PPR was a necessary condition for the 'rationalization' of their places of work. They often hoped that this was a price worth paying in exchange for a higher chance of keeping their jobs, which, they thought in the early '90s, from now on was possible only in companies that prospered on the market. Sacrificing common spaces in the hope for security of employment, however, turned out to be an extremely bad deal, as it significantly reduced workers' power in the following years, when an anti-labor campaign launched by foreign and newly formed national capital gained momentum. This resulted in material losses for the working class through massive layoffs, sal-

³² David Ost, *The Defeat of Solidarity. Anger and Politics in Postcommunist Europe*, New York: Cornell University Press, 2005.

³³ Leyk and Wawrzyniak, Cięcia. *Mówiona historia transformacji*.

ary and benefit reduction, and the subsequent precarization of labor in the form of flexible contracts. The political power of the workers also diminished with the increased top-down control and discipline brought by the managerial turn. As much as the existence of the common spaces of everyday creativity prepared the ground for the workers' emancipation and autonomy, their enclosures meant narrowing down the horizons of what was possible.

Phantom Commons in the Era of Disposessions

Similarly, as much as commoning the everyday supported the formation of new ways of being and working beyond the spaces of factory, household, and church, and thus also beyond the limitations of the patriarchal family, the loss of that experience entailed the re-traditionalization of society. As people lost access to the commons, having simultaneously to face much more precarious realities at work, the traditional family and values associated with it gained prominence. The family was presented as a shelter from the hostile and unstable external world, where people were presumed to maintain relations built on care, and not oriented towards profit. The fact that this care was not equally distributed along gender lines and was quite often actually complemented or even replaced with violence was not of interest to the self-proclaimed family defenders, the neo-conservative ideologies mushrooming in the country. For them, the privatization of everything had to logically culminate in the privatization of the everyday and the glorification of the patriarchal hetero-normative family.

Still, in a society with such a rich experience of commoning over the past few decades, confining one's social engagement and creativity within the walls of one's own home was not likely to be desired by many. The Catholic Church did not miss a chance and, as I want to argue, transformed people's loss of the commons into its key asset. In the course of the so-called 'transition period' it became the biggest beneficiary of the changes, in terms of both the wealth it acquired, including land, and for its increased moral power. In many cases, the church and parish rooms were, quite literally, the single spaces where people could still meet in larger groups and experience belonging to some community without the need to spend money.³⁴ Hence, the growing power of the Catholic Church has to be understood in the context of disposessions, which had led to a broad experience of solitude and isolation.

When I first wrote about my grandmothers, I introduced them as

devoted Catholics. However, religion did not always play an important role for them. They became closer to the church in their fifties and sixties – that is in the 1990s and early 2000s – when their husbands passed and when neoliberal capitalism settled in the country, wiping out their local communities.

In the case of Grandma Marysia, the change was radical. I came to know her as someone who attended every religious event in her town, Dębica, and would always inform me that she was praying for me, even – or even more so? – after I renounced any connection with the Church and God. She was a member of the Caritas group in her parish, which she created with other women her age, and they engaged in activities such as the production of handmade crafts to sell for charity. This image of my grandmother contrasts with how my father remembers her from his childhood years: she never went to church and found fulfilment in a variety of other ways such as in her job as a teacher, in her continued post-graduate education, in her passion for reading, and in her vibrant and intense social life, cultivated, for instance, in an allotment.

The commoning that the Catholic Church would offer since the '90s was of a phantom nature. Instead of mutual responsibility and self-determination, it brought about strict hierarchies, disempowerment, and exploitation of the most disadvantaged. While participation in church-related groups, such as through engagement in religious festivities or charity events (e.g. through Caritas) still allowed women, particularly from the older generations, to contribute to something larger, their efforts remained unrecognized (when Grandma Marysia died, the priest coordinating the local Caritas club barely agreed to take part in her funeral). Instead, all the credits went to Catholic dignitaries. These, in turn, were at the forefront of the anti-women backlash of the '90s.

The commons continued to 'haunt' Polish society after the period of enclosures, sometimes in truly nightmarish ways. It becomes most visible when we look back at the mobilizations against the abortion ban, introduced in Poland in 1993 after abortions had been available in the country practically on demand since 1956. When pro-choice activists were protesting in front of the parliament building against the criminalization of abortion, using slogans such as 'My belly belongs to me', one MP responded, exclaiming, 'Let's collectivize those bellies!'³⁵ This phenomenon of

³⁴ Well, at least without a direct compulsion, vide: collection plates.

'commoning' women's bodies is not unique to Poland. It has been observed at least since the proto-capitalist times of witch-hunting, when, as Silvia Federici has pointed out, reproduction and women's labor, in general, was re-constructed as a common good, a natural resource in the service of an entire society – against the backdrop of ongoing enclosures of land and common spaces.³⁶

In 'transitional' Poland, the conjunction of the enclosure of the commons with the commoning of women's bodies has probably gained such traction due to the ultimate betrayal of women (and the working class) by Solidarity, which at that time was still a hegemon in the world of organized labor in the country, even if, as suggested above, it was now uninterested in defending workers interests.³⁷ In 1990, during the second convention of its delegates, union members approved the reforms of the 'Balcerowicz plan' and voted in support for a full abortion ban, which ended with the liquidation of the women's section of Solidarity and resulted in the bullying of the female members of the union who protested against this.³⁸ While losing the ground under its feet, the divided, disintegrated, and decomposed working class did not manage to turn the wheel of transition, kept in motion by politicians, businessmen, and its own leaders. What came instead were even further internal divisions along identity lines of religion, nationality, sexual orientation, and, above all – due to its centrality to the organization of reproduction – gender.

Commoning through Art and Activism Today

This leaves us with quite a grim picture of life in Poland, but this is not how this story ends. Since the 1990s, not only has the feminist movement grown stronger and more intersectional, but the labor movement has also managed to organize in a more inclusive way, beyond the structures of Solidarity, which is nowadays finally discredited as an extension of the PiS government. Here, in particular, the intersectional, inter-generational alliances, such as those between feminists and striking nurses or between tenants' associations and squatters, bring hope. Those at first temporary and occasional collaborations have sedimented into more stable structures,

³⁵ Agnieszka Graff, *Świat bez Kobiet. Płeć w polskim życiu publicznym*, Warszawa: Wydawnictwo Marginesy, 2021.

³⁶ Silvia Federici, *Caliban and the Witch. Women, the Body and Primitive Accumulation*, 2nd edit. New York: Autonomedia, 2014.

³⁷ David Ost, *The Defeat of Solidarity*.

³⁸ Penn, *Solidarity's Secret*.

with the annual Social Congress of Women being an important example of building bridges between different strands of activism. Finally, the most recent resurgence of the powerful pro-abortion movement and the 'commoning' of the streets by feminist and queer demonstrators since 2016 is a form of emancipatory politics, where the private is not only understood as political but where political engagement also transgresses both the private and the public sphere, thus entering the terrain of the commons.

While the recreation of commons – or the preservation of those still in existence – has to be actively fought for, one could also point to small and subtle spatial interventions into everyday life which are already expanding the horizon of what we consider possible and desirable. Joanna Rajkowska's project, *Oxygenator (Dotleniacz)*, is a good example of a pre-figurative artistic practice. In collaboration with Warsaw's major art institutions, renowned artist Rajkowska created a large pond on Grzybowski Square in Warsaw, around which people from the local neighborhood started to gather spontaneously. Her intervention into the space, which used to be traversed in different directions but was barely occupied as a site of meeting and exchange, transformed it into a common space for Śródmieście's inhabitants of different generations. Despite its temporariness, the project engaged people in situations radically different from their everyday experience, which always has transformative potential.

Perhaps the most notable example of an intervention into the everyday life of a neighborhood is *Project Ursus*, initiated by Jaśmina Wójcik in 2012 and further jointly developed by a group of artists and activists over several years. Ursus – which stands today for the name of a district in Warsaw – was a city that hosted a large and famous tractor company (also named Ursus). It had been founded in the 1920s, prospered during the PPR, and was liquidated in the early 2000s. In the course of Wójcik's project, artists and activists worked towards the re-integration of the community of former company workers. Tractor parades were held across Warsaw, and there were collective painting actions, audio walks, and historical photography exhibitions. Former Ursus employees – dispossessed and devalued like other blue-collar workers over the course of transformation – could reclaim the lost spaces belonging to the industrial complex of their former workplace once again and revive their lost experiences of commoning. This happened by providing them with access to the space, where they could both celebrate the past and collectively act to shape the future of the district – the interactions

initiated over the course of the aforementioned activities resulted in the movement to save the factory museum and archives, which turned out to be the most pressing need of the former workers.

Looking at those artistic interventions, one can't help but wonder: does today's commoning need to be facilitated and mediated by art – against the backdrop of the large-scale dispossession of the commons? Or, quite on the contrary, are artists and their participatory projects a part of the neoliberal scheme and, as Claire Bishop suggests in her *Participatory Art and the Politics of Spectatorship*, a compensation for the state's withdrawal from its welfare responsibilities?³⁹ This question won't be resolved here, but it once again drives our attention to the problematics of autonomy, democracy, and the hierarchies involved in dynamics occurring between commoners and 'professional' facilitators backed by institutions and funding. These might be state-related actors or artists and activists, who, on the one hand, commit to the cause and generously share their resources with others, but, on the other, often capitalize on the movements and energies they have shared with others who typically remain nameless.

It seems, however, that in the post-socialist context of Poland, where commons are rarely already in existence due to its difficult history tormented by wars, dislocations, and dispossessions – to prepare the ground for commoning, some kind of enabling support might be necessary. In fact, the more repressive the reactions of state and capital against autonomous attempts such as squatting to reclaim the commons, the more institutionalized practices, countering the hegemony of the repressive institutions of the state might be needed. Last but not least, it has to be noted that as long as projects such as Project Ursus propose a different politics of memory – counter-hegemonic to the dominant one that pathologizes and discards workers' lived experiences – they do not comply with the post-socialist power relations and their historical policy.

Remembering and Finding Home

To contextualize contemporary struggles revolving around commons and enclosures and to connect them intersectionally, we urgently need to deepen our engagement with a feminist politics of memory related to times of state socialism. Whilst today we might experience the commons in typically temporary activist or art projects,

³⁹ Claire Bishop, *Participatory Art and the Politics of Spectatorship*, London: Verso Books, 2012.

and whilst commoning is always a part of our emancipatory struggles, it is rarely organically inscribed into our everyday. This was, however, not always the case and people who remember a different world are still here – and they might be willing to tell us about it. To learn from them, we have to first tune into their stories, which have been drowned out for too long.

Over a year ago, a wonderful storyteller, my Grandma Marysia, passed away, and I will never come to terms with losing the opportunity to ever again listen to stories from her childhood, youth, and adult life. At the funeral, my cousin, her other grandchild, decided to read a passage from the Bible. Knowing him to be an outspoken Christian fundamentalist, I expected only the worst. And the worst did indeed happen: 'One lives only for the Lord, and one dies only for the Lord', he read aloud. I'm not sure whether he attempted to silence his grief by denying anything other than the theological purpose and meaning of Grandma's life, but I know that for me, this felt as if she was dying once again. Later, during the wake, I talked mostly with Grandma's lifetime friends, who recalled their shared youth. They remembered my grandmother as a 'party animal' and shared their fond memories of the time they had spent in common. For example, they spoke of how when just one household would have a television they would watch it together, without any need of an invitation, and treat it as a common good. We agreed that everyday life used to be far more communal than it is today, that my generation has been robbed of something fundamental, and that we could look up to their experiences. Even if this aggravated the sense of loss, there was something uplifting, humanizing, and, perhaps, even anti-fascist in remembering her at her fullest, among the people and in the spaces that used to bring joy and leisure but also purpose and meaning to her life.

The experiences of our grandmothers have been erased from recent Polish history by the elites who furnished the post-socialist conservative neoliberal regime, and this happened with our mothers being complicit, who discarded their wisdom while they went all in trying to get their share.⁴⁰

Today, we, the granddaughters, ought to form a new alliance with our grandmothers while we still can. They are our comrades,

⁴⁰ This is an argument from Agnieszka Mrozik (2012); according to her, the generation of our mothers – women in their twenties and thirties in the 1990s – hoped to be invited to the table of the beneficiaries of the changes. Renouncing any positive aspects of life under the PPR was one of their strategies to achieve that.

who were lucky enough to experience something that is today rather alien to most of us of the generation born or raised in the 90s during the era of enclosures. Federici has described what they and other commoners lived through as 'a powerful and rare experience as that of being part of something larger than our individual lives, of dwelling on 'this earth of mankind' not as a stranger or a trespasser, which is the way capitalism wishes us to relate to the spaces we occupy, but as home'.⁴¹ Wouldn't our grandmothers want to make us feel at home, too?

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⁴¹ Federici, *Feminism and the Politics of the Commons*, p. 77.

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Closed Factory Library: Notes on Workers' Movements in Belarus

These notes comprise my experience as a cultural worker interested in labor movements, which were one of the foundations of the social uprising in Belarus as a reaction to the rigged presidential elections in 2020. Multiple forms of prefigurative political organization emerged during the summer months of that year and sparked networks of self-organization, striking, and labor unrest – feminist and queer interventions both into the everyday life of the city, but also into protest marches themselves. All the professional and social groups were on the streets and protesting in their workplaces – from students to pensioners, from workers to artists. That none of the previous analyses were able to anticipate the scale of the social uprising and its endurance in a seemingly depoliticized society pushed me to think further around the particular role of the workers' movement. It implied and re-invented a variety of tactics and inspired other groups – from black cat strikes and labor disputes, to chaining oneself at worksites such as mines, assemblies, and gatherings. They all went beyond the traditional practice of striking in the context where legal instruments were criminalized. Volodymyr Artiukh proposed describing this set of practices as 'labor unrest',¹ borrowing this term from his research on participation amongst independent unions, workers of state-owned factories, as well as sites of spontaneous unrest; I would like to propose seeing these practices as an unprompted and creative mode of resistance. In conjunction with practicing striking across all kinds of fields of labor, such as cultural, information technology, and care work, this notion illuminated the spectrum and leverage posed by resistance in the contexts of post-socialism.

While putting together these notes in the autumn-winter of 2023, many of the union activists are imprisoned, some have been

¹ Volodymyr Artiukh, 'The Anatomy of Impatience: Exploring Factors behind 2020 Labour Unrest in Belarus', in *Slavic Review* 80 (2021), pp. 52-60.

² The case of Alla Zvirko, member of strike at Minsk Automobile Plant was denied right for political asylum in Sweden.

denied political asylum in European Union countries,² many struggle with their lives in exile, or they take part in the antiwar resistance against Russian imperialism.³ This collection of three notes comprises my observations, already published fragments, personal memories, discussions with friends and comrades as well as speculations on the histories of the workers' movements that still have to be written or imagined. Thinking about the surprising nature of social and labor unrest, defunct factory libraries and inaccessible museums helps me to remember what workers' movements have been and what they can be in the future.

The first note departs from my personal observations on the enclosure of a factory library in Minsk, which I see as emblematic of the contradictions between Soviet legacies of workers' social reproduction, their acts of self-organizing, and the instrumental ideological role played by official unions. I address the specific history of trade unions in Belarus after the collapse of state socialism as well as the disintegration of social welfare, which was slower in comparison to its neighboring countries, yet still pervasive and forceful. I also refer to the process of dismantling union-owned property that does not bring immediate profit for the state or new private owners – such as sanatoriums, factory libraries, and so on.

The second note departs from a failed attempt to visit the existing museum of the Federation of Trade Unions of Belarus in Minsk during the ongoing protests and calls for a general strike.⁴ The museum itself belongs to the Federation of Trade Unions of Belarus, a conservative organization that supports the current political regime. The entry imagines the secret museum of the workers' movement and presents a fragmented narrative, illustrating workers' heritage, the history of past strikes, and contemporary forms of labor unrest in post-socialist countries and beyond. It questions how the strikes have been represented through history and how the notion of the strike as a collective act of disruption and refusal could be represented at all. I am interested in workers' museums as spaces of the commons, of common and unsettled history, which is often neglected and disturbed.

³ The case of Sergey Ereemev, member of strike at Naftan oil refinery, was arrested in Russia with criminal allegations in terrorism. He supposedly was part of the large-scale sabotage at the railway road. Numerous activists and partisans were arrested earlier in Belarus for disrupting railways to prevent the invasion of Russian troops through Belarus in winter-spring 2022.

⁴ This note was elaborated for the Lulu-journal in 2021.

The third note focuses on the notion of comradely aesthetics – a speculative notion, which brings together workers' unrest and contemporary art imagery that operate through similar political and aesthetic approaches. This term attempts to grasp the common features that have enabled the political agency of workers and artists since 2020. I find it productive to speculate on the multiple affective bonds that have made political activism and critical art practice resonate with each other. This note focuses on the notions of comradeship alongside comradely aesthetics through an image by artist Uladzimir Hramovich who works with various workers' histories of anti-colonial and partisan struggle.

Factory Library

When I think about the neglected history of labor movements in Belarus, I imagine the factory library. With a Soviet legacy, the factory would not only be an industrial site of production with its specific forms of extraction and discipline, but also a space for workers' recreation, social engagement, and creativity. The factory and its surrounding infrastructures for leisure and the regeneration of the workforce – sanatoriums, hospitals, trips, events – is one of the focal points of my childhood memories. As one of my parents was working in the factory context, I had the pleasure of engaging with the activities on offer, such as children's sport competitions, art exhibitions, sanatorium stays, and guided tours to other factories and historical sites. In the late '90s and early '00s, the infrastructures of workers' social reproduction were still intact. This was possible due to a specific history of Belarusian politics and post-socialist privatizations. To win votes in the '90s current president Lukashenko instrumentalized the social-welfare rhetoric, which slowed down privatization and the arrival of foreign capital into the country.

However, privatization proceeded with a different velocity than in other post-socialist cities and unfolded according to a different game of power. Through a slow process of gentrification – in the gaps between state repression mostly around the periods of the presidential election (from 2006 to 2011 and then to 2020), these post-industrial spaces were gradually and slowly taken up by redevelopment companies and commercial enterprises. Some of them, hidden behind semi-defunct factories becoming storage units, were taken up by artists, activists, and queers. Mostly for short periods of time, but sometimes for longer, various intersections between social groups have emerged, creating mutated ecologies of work

and leisure. In the same streets that workers would go on their day shifts, queers would now go on nights out. Once we had an event in one of the factory's canteens on the same street that would still serve last meals – soups and kefirs – to us and to workers. Former factories became business incubators, IT-offices, and sleek cafes. The temporality of 'the former' (former factory, former canteen) marks the temporality of redistribution, erasure, and investment.

This was during a time after the 2001 election, a less remembered episode in the political history of post-socialist Belarus, when the head of Trade Unions, Uladzimir Hancharyk, was one of the candidates for the presidency, but would lose to Lukashenko. My elderly comrade, M, was working in the unions and was a part of the candidate's presidential campaign. The stories back then were not written but were passed on mostly orally in reading groups, at punk concerts, and private gatherings. The union's autonomy was suppressed as a consequence of its opposition to the state. Those were the last elections before the subsequent, far more dramatic run of elections in 2006, 2011, and 2020 that are characteristic of the failed state and corrupt presidency. Some time later, another harsh attack on workers' autonomy arrived in the form of the law against so-called 'social parasitism', which was first introduced in 2015 and sought to tax those categorized as 'social parasites'. The state articulated clearly the rift between what it considered to be the useful part of the workforce and what was seen as excess surplus population – parasites, creeps, anarchists. Interestingly enough, protests against the law were already led by anarchist groups, which were met with the most repression from state police. Those protest actions already prefigured the ways in which the movement would work in 2020. The echo of the uprising in which the anarchists called for self-organization kept resonating through society years later.

Around the time of social unrest against the parasitism law, M brought me to the factory. We knew that the factory library would be closed. The rules of entry to the factory were very strict, but our visit was still possible. I remember the experience of being brought through the security check and later on being allowed to choose books from a library that was intended to be closed forever. As a norm in Belarus, the neglect of the social sphere is covered over with rhetorics of social welfare. I remember being locked in the library between a strange, heterogeneous post-socialist selection of books: party literature from Soviet times including classic works by Marx, Engels, and Lenin, a selection of books on psychology,

including Freud's works, gardening and self-help magazines, and so on: vernacular literature that could supposedly cater to the tastes of workers in the mid-2000s.

Being an official member of the Chemical Union and later on coming to occupy a somewhat important elected position, Comrade M was following those developments in real time. We spent years in generational exchange discussing questions relating to labor and the critique of discipline, the role of the unions and their instrumentalization, the attack on independent trade unions, internationalism, the transformation of the working class, and so on. Those conversations sparked debates on political organization, the enclosure of social spaces, lost struggles and histories, and the degradation of bureaucracy and policing of the workers via unions and ideological departments.

M could understand my interest in this weird mix of library books, its seeming dysfunctionality and irrelevance, and we could share our grief for the way everything was developing. Previously working at the factory's laboratory, she articulated a question for me: what do we really want, to work with the workers or to work with test-tubes? She had made her decision – switching her position from the lab to the union office, aspiring to help workers at least in their daily lives, as well as fight against factory management. I was able to bring some of the library's books home – they stayed with me as outdated tools that supposedly no longer would be relevant for the contemporary moment. I imagine that this bizarre mix of revolutionary theory, post-socialist pulp fiction, and gardening and construction self-help books could ferment into guides on survival, struggle, and resilience for the workers who were subject to the eroding conditions of life. I hope that other workers and their friends and families were able to smuggle some more of these books out of the library. Sometimes, I imagine that one day those books will be able to come together again – under another political regime, under different workers' solidarity.

Secret Museum of the Workers' Movement

In 2020, amidst the ongoing anti-government protests in Belarus, me and a group of cultural workers tried several times to get into the museum of the Federation of Trade Unions of Belarus, located in one of Minsk's main squares inside the Palace of Trade Unions. Operated by the official Trade Union Federation, the museum remains unknown and inaccessible to the general public, and is

ostensibly a secret. We tried to enter it directly from the street and corresponded with the Palace of Trade Unions' management – an organization in charge of many other facilities besides the museum. It is simply impossible to access the space as one would a regular institution as it lies within the Palace, which you cannot enter without permission. Additionally, one cannot visit the museum as an individual; you have to organize a group. Though we know it exists, we could never see this hall that narrates the history of Belarus's union and labor movement. The administrator of the museum (possibly the only worker there) told us that the management of the Palace is responsible for granting admission and had, after a series of long conversations, stopped picking up the phone. 'You need to make an application for organizing a visit for your group', 'you need to gather a group of at least ten people', 'you need to get permission from the director of the Palace', 'you need to pay five rubles each', 'you will be contacted'.

I kindly requested permission to arrange a visit to the 'Museum of the Federation of Trade Unions of Belarus' for a group of eight to ten people on October 22, 2020, at 11:00am. The group included cultural workers who would like to get acquainted with the union's history of workers' movements in Belarus.

The administrator never contacted us. Later, over the phone, it turned out that she had contracted coronavirus and did not want to talk about it publicly. She wanted to keep this a secret, so she didn't call us back. The museum got disinfected. Later, our comrade learned from a phone call that there never was a virus and that they simply did not want to take in groups 'from the street'. The museum belongs to the Federation, 'so you will need a certificate from the union committee to get in'. The next evening, it turned out that the Head of the Federation was organizing Lukashenko's biggest rally after two and a half months of mass protests before the day of the general strike. The latter was announced as the primary tool to oust the president, free political prisoners, and stop police and state violence. Probably, the museum staff were afraid of civil disobedience. But how can a visit to a museum, in which there would probably be no one besides us, be considered a provocation? What were they hiding from us? At the end of the day, the pro-government rally was cancelled.

What would the objects and documents in the museum have told us? What would the shelves and the museum guide's narrative have presented to us? Perhaps some objects would be critical of the factories' directorship and capitalists, of the exploitation of labor.

They would then show us solidarity and make other alliances with the body of the worker and other material bodies. They would be comrades who have won back their time. The secret museum would compel us, following Saidiya Hartman,⁵ to 'critically fabulate' the local stories of struggle: as, for example, of Rakaŭ women-smugglers or the Narač fishermen on strike. We can only see this museum in a few poor-quality photographs that are available on the internet. In other towns we visited, where there are also factory museums, such as Zhodzina and Salihorsk, we were also not allowed to enter, as they are protected by security; you cannot get in to see them 'from the street'.

Not only is the site of production hidden from us, but also the history of its struggle. Official displays of ceremonial history – awards, gifts, and portraits – would hide faults, experiences, and organizations. We thought it would be the history of socialism, the story of the poor and the hungry, of those working for pleasure and giving up work, striking and standing in solidarity, doing invisible work, hating power, and offering one's comrade a helping hand. Such a museum would be flickering: present to all within any given moment but able to disappear when necessary, becoming secret.

The October strike was not cancelled. On Saturday, there was a women's march of professions, on Monday a general strike was announced. 'A woman's work is never done'. But what if it ends on Monday?

Comradely Aesthetics

In the last three years, I was able to follow various professional and anonymous creative practices that share similar agitating aesthetics over the course of the social uprising in Belarus in 2020. During the unrest that contaminated all professional and social groups, the rise of multiple visual cultures has been observed. Similar to the vernacular designs of the books from the closed factory library – low-key, catchy, punk, appealing, straight-forward, mingling – these aesthetic objects have circulated as artworks, memes, protesting yard flags, ready-to-print newspapers, graffiti, and so on, sharing a visual style that transgresses the conventionality of art and visual culture in Belarus, dominating at that time in mainstream cultures. Somehow, they have absorbed both avant-garde militancy and post-internet immediacy. The political context of 2020 created the

⁵ Saidiya Hartman, 'Venus in Two Acts', *Small Axe Journal*, 12(2) (June, 2008), pp. 1-14.

conditions where art produced a certain social bond and affective regime. I would like to approach these aesthetic objects produced in the context of political strikes and assemblies through their spatial and temporal configurations. What are the forces that shape artistic and activist gestures and what do they share with each other? One of the ways to answer this question could be found in the notion of solidarity and its specific form known as comradeship. I believe that most of the people who have taken to the streets, who took part in strikes and labor unrest in Belarus in 2020-21, were living through the affect of comradeship.

'Comradeship' is different from 'friendship' as it is not based on personal relations, but rather directly communicates political affect. Comrades are replaceable, meaning that their affect radiates through anonymity, political affinity, and embodied experience. Meeting one's neighbor at the protest march, rubbing a shoulder while blocking the road in a district fast asleep, and sabotaging one's workplace with colleagues; creating meaningful encounters with hitherto unknown people. Without strategy, spontaneously, this political affect was able to mobilize hundreds of thousands of people during the protest marches in summer and autumn 2020. In her book on comradeship, philosopher Jodi Dean sees 'comrade' as a mode of address, as a figure of political belonging, and carrier of expectations for action.⁶ In an essay that builds on these propositions, Frida Sandström writes:

A comradely aesthetics might be the *Umfunktionierung* (functional transformation) of today, where collective processes and authorship are present both within and around the work, but especially in how the work is being made. Such a mindset might allow us to hold a place open beyond our own needs. To host what is not yet there.⁷

Belarusian state politics in support of the Russian war against Ukraine shut down the horizon of solidarity against imperialist violence. Narrating the labor unrest of 2020-22 and acts of antiwar resistance of 2022-24, which were also enabled by professional solidarity networks, for example the acts of sabotage committed

⁶ Jodi Dean, *Comrade: An Essay on Political Belonging*, London and New York: Verso, 2019.

⁷ Frida Sandström, 'Instituting Organisation: A First Note on Comradely Aesthetics' In: *L'Internationale Online* (March 2020).

by railway workers, I would like to bring in a visual work titled 'Yard March' by artist Uladzimir Hramovich from 2023. The work is a digital collage that puts together two images: a socialist-era photograph of the newly built modernist district of Minsk, *Zialony Luh* (Green Meadow), as well as a portrait of the historical anti-colonial figure, Kastuś Kalinoŭski. The main streets of the district were named in his honor as the protagonist of the failed 1863 peasant and workers' uprising against the imperial domination and colonial violence of the Russian Empire. In Soviet historiography, this uprising served as a classical example of anti-colonial insurrection, seen to be exemplary of the contradictions that would tear apart the Russian Empire. Its participants were closely connected to socialist politics and working-class struggles. For example, Walery Wróblewski, one of the participants of the uprising, after his emigration, became an active and important participant of the Paris Commune. This uprising was an important precursor to the February and then October Revolutions that happened several decades later. Uniting peasants with straightened scythes raised in the air, early industrial workers, and intelligentsia, the uprising was violently suppressed. It failed, but it has offered inspiration for generations of revolutionaries to come. Nowadays, the contemporary authoritarian Belarusian state selectively relies on a Soviet interpretation of history, using the Great Patriotic War at its basis and trying to erase all public presence of anti-colonial struggles and uprisings. The monuments have been dismantled, and public memory erased. The city landscape depicted in Hramovich's work refers to the popular practice of yard marches and the local self-organization of people that occurred in 2020. Those empty streets of the modernist district in a black-and-white photograph would once more be full of protesting people. The image acts as a background for the portrait of one of the leaders of the 1863 uprising, appropriated from the other Soviet-era lithograph of Mykola Kupava – a Belarusian artist who depicts a set of standard national narratives, that were legitimized in both the Soviet and early national independence periods. As an art school teacher, he was also responsible for suppressing student strikes, protests, and the development of contemporary art in Belarus in the late '80s and early '90s. Hramovich puts those images together – facilitating tensions between socialist realist aesthetics, national content, anti-colonial struggles, contemporary unrest, and official history. The colors of Kalinoŭski's portrait are however inverted – creating a ghostly ethereal aura, radiating the history itself. Here, we can see

how those tensions expressed in a very straightforward manner, which could be read by anyone in Belarus, create an affective bond and historical continuity between various struggles, as well as their erasure in the context of imperial Russian politics and their adaptation in the context of a complicit Belarusian state. Both the uprisings of 1863 and 2020 have failed – but what kind of failure is this? Do they gesture to something that is not yet there? In friendship (and here, for me, it would be synonymous to comradeship), Elora Halim Chowdhury and Liz Philipose locate a way of guaranteeing that imperial imagination does not control the horizon of our possibilities.⁸ In a similar way, the visual cultures that I frame through the terms of comradely aesthetics are not only representative of struggles but, due to collective ways of collecting and distributing, create affective bonds that enable spaces where friendships and comradeships can last. Even with the rising repressions and commencement of full-scale invasion, they were able to preserve the affection that is intact until now – in exile, as well as inside the country.

These notes place together three speculative spaces and temporalities and their accidental economies – of a defunct factory library, a hidden and inaccessible workers' movement museum, and an empty street in a modernist district. They all are informed by the resting ontology of old and new memories of the bodies that inhabited it, mutating ecologies of work and resistance. These spaces do not only fail, they elaborate and imprint new forms of political and social life. Neglected at this very moment, they still absorb and assemble energies of unrest – as people would compare the dynamics of protest in Belarus to the peat bog fire, invisible yet powerful. It will be too late for the arrest, when it will suddenly uncover itself.

⁸ Elora Halim Chowdhury and Liz Philipose, *Dissident Friendships. Feminism, Imperialism and Transnational Solidarity*. Champaign, Illinois: University of Illinois Press, 2016.

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Diagrams: A Series of Failures

one day,
sitting down over zoom,
thinking how the stories told by
 our parents
 our education
 our nation states
have failed us
with a promise of a collective political body.
the stories we were told
no longer match reality.

the reality is:
 anxiety
 precarity
 alienation
 war

I asked you: would you like to have
 a conversation
 a ritual
 a diagram
about this?
diagrams are
 a subject of fascination
 a research object
of how knowledge is organised
in the world.
how our parents' knowledge was moulded.
how our grandparents' life was governed.
bodies abstracted in the diagrams of control
little points, all watched over
by the statistical gaze.

how to counter alienation?
our own diagram would include vectors;
little lines of flight
out of it.

a flow of awareness directed towards
 the body
 its life
 its experience
 its surroundings;
 thinking-with.

what of diagrams as conditions for possibility?
 adding meanings to the body,
 relations to the world,
 enriching perception,
 possibilities to create shared meaning.
 moving bodies in relation to other bodies and other matter
 rather than fixing a body into a space;
 bodies never have to be fixed.
 diagrams that rehearse unlearning.

//

can there be a collective political body?

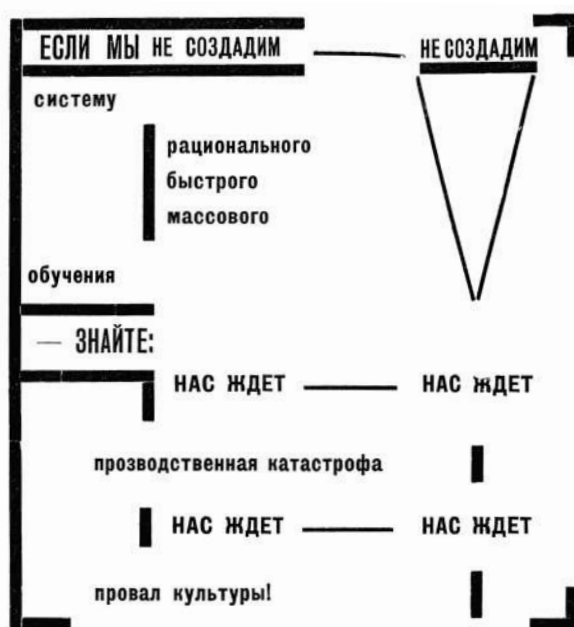
Soviet state socialism moulded one,
 violently disregarding
 privacy,
 bodily autonomy,
 language,
 culture.

my grandmother was certainly moulded within,
 feeling safe and secure in the embrace of ideology.

my other grandmother did not feel like she belonged in that
 collective political body,
 and her mother had a life torn apart
 by its embrace.

Soviet cybernetics
 and labour organisation
 and инфографики,¹
 and чертежи,²
 and госпланы –³
 diagrammatised bodies fit into slots
 of the giant production machine
 which was busy sketching an empire called “the communist
 future”.

«Каждый рабочий должен привыкнуть к графику, к чертежу... Система диаграмм, система координат – это необычайно простая система, которая может уложиться... в любом блокноте в клетку. Техника собраний – доклад с непременно графическими изображениями... Надо увековечить графическую диаграммную форму доклада».⁴



Bodies locked into machinic spaces
 and their energy, kinetic force, time, health
 organised as a collective labouring body,
 within a collectively built world.

//

infrastructure leans against History,
written over the dead bodies sacrificed to build it.

infrastructure as the promise of the great future,
of expanded History,
building dams, deserts, forests, suns, rivers, seas.

there are two different kinds of history:
histories of people which are lived
and History which is written.

in 1991, a junction was formed
History ended
on a path directed towards a new horizon, a new History:
 technology-aided
 democratically enlightened
 capitalism
that was future-proof.

the beginning of a new diagrammatic order
connected through the lines
of another totalising structure,
built on cables, hardware, data.

the democratic Internet of the 1990s
as the solution to the world's troubles,
spawned by unprecedented volumes of information.
events unfolding in real-time,
the power of narrative in the hands of citizens.

//

can there be a collective political body?

big tech moulded another version,
violently disregarding
 privacy,
 bodily autonomy,
 language,
 culture.

my mother disappeared behind the screen
believing this is where she belonged,
collecting friends, likes, shares,
capitalist metrics of organisation.
bodies diagrammatised into networks
of a giant planetary machine.

what was political hope
became political nihilism.
through fragmented stories she scrolls,
refreshes the stream.
a distraction,
disorientation,
synchronicity out of bounds.

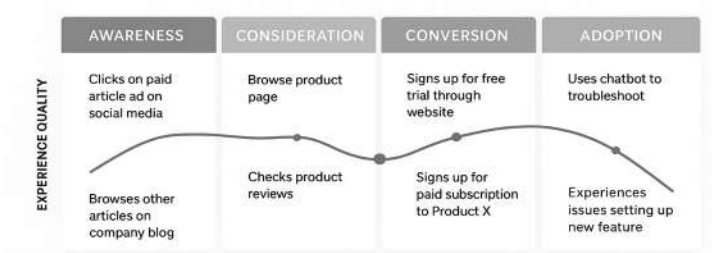
a collective political body
disintegrates in the layers of the network.
algorithmically engineered micro-experiences
 homogenise the gaze,
 standardise experience
 control attention.
dissonance by design.

//

I was born as a user
I wander through the pixels of a digital maze;
what story of my body do I tell?

my user experience
is a journey woven firmly
into the new schemes
of the late neoliberal condition.

Product X User Journey Map—Social Acquisitions



guest check-out, or register,
 I will never
 leave this basket,
 I will never
 refuse cookies,
 I will never
 be able
 to unsubscribe.

I am collected as a body,
 and taken apart
 into discrete sets of targeting characteristics.
 an individually labouring body
 within a technologically built world.

//

can there be a collective political body?

one that retains
 privacy,
 autonomy,
 language,
 culture.

let's draw diagrams that
 rehearse alternative paths
 by continuously sketching different connections,
 adjusting, failing, re-connecting.
 as an active mechanism
 to rehearse adaptation,
 always incomplete
 but slowly constructing

the beginning of an unlearning,
 an open endedness
 that allows
 to find
 to trace
 to relocate
 to keep repositioning
 a collective political body.

later, same month, our bodies meet
 one another
 in a diagram of a protest.
 networks flare up
 with indications
 "I'm here" "Where?" "The signal is bad".
 cafe wi-fi allows to send a picture
 to other distributed bodies
 in solidarity of a planetary connection.
 mired in networks
 still, we meet,
 we talk,
 we persist.

the diagram is of history,
 of our collective action:
 we are in the diagram
 and we make our way out of it.

this ritual is over.
 start again and read it out aloud,
 let another one begin.

¹ infographics

² blueprints

³ state plans (see figures 1-3)

⁴ "Every worker must get used to a graph, a blueprint... A system of diagrammes, a system of coordinates is an incredibly simple system that can exist in any squared notepad. A report with graphic visualisation is a necessary technology for any meeting... A graphic diagrammatic shape of a record needs to be immortalised."

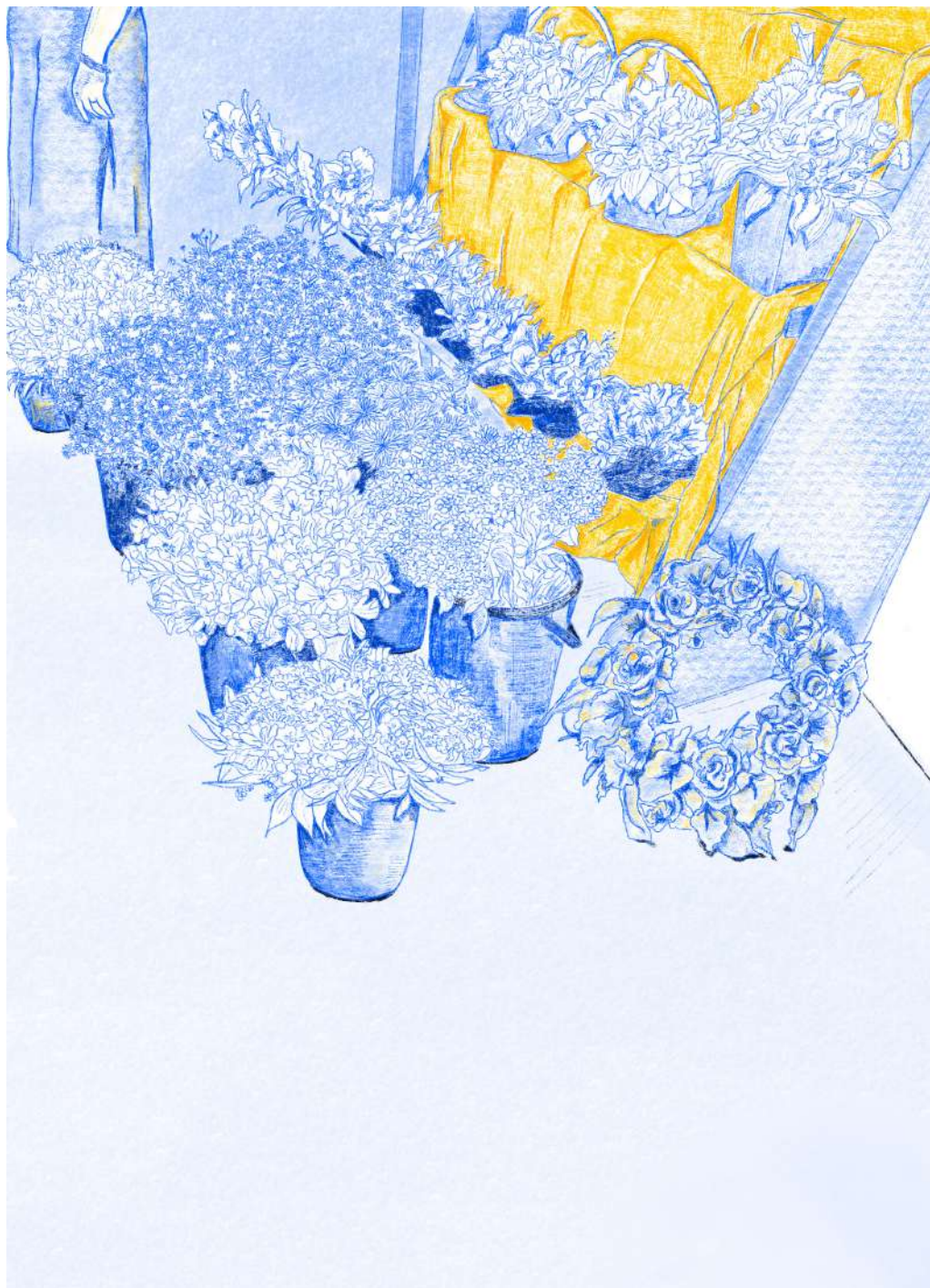
Georgian Migrant Women Diary



"At first, the idea came from me, but the decision to leave was made by the whole family, of course. I would not have gone, if they didn't permit me to do so."



"Everything was strange and dark for me. I thought that I was thrown into a pit from which I could not get out. Then I got used to everything."



"I did not cry when my husband died. He was the best person, I don't remember anything bad about him... he was always good. But the feeling was as if an old family member had died, and not my husband. I blame it on distance and separation."



"The first thing I felt was distance from my family; a hole appeared between me and them. People used to say that grandkids give you more joy and happiness than your own children. I don't have this feeling. Eleven years is not a short time."



"I wasn't like that before, I was happy to go to my neighbor's house and drink coffee. Now I don't care anymore, I want to be alone."



"I can't stand the noise there (Georgia) anymore. I have to be by myself. I got used to life here (abroad). I have the same 'standards' in Georgia as I have here. Everyone is locked in their houses here."

To create this series of illustrations, I drew on my and my community's personal experiences and collected letters from Georgian migrant women engaged in care work in Western Europe. In these letters, they write of the emotional and practical experiences and struggles at home and abroad, which they couldn't have foreseen before leaving.

Based on these letters I designed an illustrated diary intended to be shared with these women who are now planning to leave their homes to provide better lives to their families.

My aim is to create a space for sharing and learning about each other's experiences, struggles, thoughts and hopes.

As if This World No Longer Existed: Three Theses on the Crisis of Political Belonging

I remember the moment, years ago, when Egzilis [exile] was dissolved in Kaunas. We had gathered together to read *The Tyranny of Structurelessness* by Jo Freeman at a friend's flat, in a building near the train station that we had communalized. The text, which criticizes informal organizing for mistaking the wishful desire to live outside capitalist social relations with the actual revolutionary practice of doing so, raised questions about the need to build a formal organization that would offer a foundation for a more transparent, accountable, self-critical mode of belonging. At stake was foremost the question of friendship as the foundation of belonging to the movement. Did our friendships – with their informality, shared pleasures and pains, preferentiality, and almost mystically concocted affinity-based membership – truly offer a viable foundation for unmaking the social bonds of capitalism? Or, as Jo Freeman stipulated, did these friendships 'become a way of masking power [...] by those who are the most powerful'?¹

Following Freeman's thesis that the social division of roles in society – along the lines of class, gender, and race – will be implicitly duplicated in the *structureless* friend circle, we concluded the meeting with a decision to move toward structured organizing, rethinking the politics of our belonging through another type of bond: comradeship. We came to embrace comradeship for its seeming capacity to prioritize shared social conditions of struggle over the voluntarist ethos found in the affinity-based collective practices that shaped the bonds of our friendships.

Before any real steps could be taken in this new direction, we found ourselves thrown into the so-called 'social movement era', responding to an unexpected spread of supermarket boycotts throughout the country, which were responses to inflation after the Euro was integrated as a national currency. Our circle – to some extent dissolving itself before this new sense of belonging enabled

¹ Jo Freeman, 'The Tyranny of Structurelessness', Vol. 2, No. 1 of *The Second Wave* (1972).

by movements messianic interruption of 'life as usual' – took an active role in furthering it: organizing demos, agitating, and eventually instigating occupations in Kaunas and Vilnius under the banner 'life is too expensive'.

In the aftermath of the social movement, the effort to depersonalize political belonging through the building of a deliberately structured organization featuring a membership system, monthly dues, the eventual procurement of a code of conduct, etc. took root. Navigating the many obstacles of organizing on a larger scale, the state and the political party have returned as new priorities. While writing this text, the first explicitly leftist political party in the post-soviet era of Lithuania was launched on 1 May 2024. The reemergence of the state – in Lithuania but also as a broader tendency in the Left today – has come with a further centering of the bond of comradeship as an instrument for mass belonging and political accountability.

Resisting the compulsion – now taken for granted – to divulge details of organizational histories and practices, and at the same time avoiding the regional and temporal particularization of movement knowledge that often comes with these auto-ethnographic methods, I have written this account in the form of a political treatise. The treatise offers itself as an effort to broadly consider the possibilities and limits of different forms of political belonging as they have been expressed through the bonds of friendship, comradeship, and movement messianism. It is organized in three sections; each section includes a thesis (I) and antithesis (II). I begin by introducing a notion of a communist ethics of friendship and its critique of the state and 'Politics'. I then work through a critique of this position as the point of emergence for the political bond of comradeship. I consider the potentials and, finally, the limits and even betrayals expressed by comradeship to arrive once again at its critique. I then turn toward social movements as a form of belonging expressed through the messianic interruption of the historical continuum of forms. I explore how movement messianism circumnavigates both the contradictory ethics of comradeship and the delusional politics of friendship. From there, I convey a critique of movement messianism. The treatise concludes with the opening of a conversation: a letter from a friend in London responding to what has been written and sharing their own thoughts on how we may proceed.

Despite the treatise's dialectical method, you will see it conforms to neither a historical nor a teleological logic – there is no

assumption of an evolution of forms or the wish to offer a new, better political program of action. We are left with a modest reflection on the potential of modes of belonging and their limitations.

It is also important to emphasize that the three bonds I work through are not strictly ascribable to the literal, factual activity of the movements in their different phases. For instance, while there was a drift from friendship to comradeship, it was never really a simple surgical split or paradigm shift from one effort of un/belonging to another, but a messy bridging of different modalities. In the end, a politics of the commons, which I believe is always in the final instance an ethics, must confront the question of 'What is to be done?' as a fundamentally immanent response to the moment we find ourselves in. In other words, there are no conclusive answers to arrive at from the outset. Let us approach theory as a technology for orienting ourselves in the present over any kind of explanatory system of knowledge.

This theoretical exercise is simply an effort to map strategies, to start a conversation on the possibilities, shortcomings, and failures of the commons and communism. And yes, I have my own political preferences and current investments, but those are to remain in a language under language, as secret names and unexpressed deeds of the coming community.

Friendship

*The commune is not a place,
it is absolute sharing between friends.*
– Anonymous, *Friendship as a Form of Life*

In a commune called the Garden on the outskirts of ancient Athens, the good, virtuous life was seen as foremost a matter of sharing one's existence between friends. And in contrast with other philosophical sects of Ancient Greece, the Garden took concrete steps to apply its ethics in defiance of a social order that was built on slavery and the subjugation of women. The ethics of friendship was held as a universal principle: the Garden welcomed slaves, women, children and men (of various social classes). Browsing Epicurean teachings, one will indeed encounter strong resonances with what Peter Kropotkin would later describe as the foundation of communism, mutual aid: 'a wise man will have the same feelings for his friend as for himself and will undertake the same labours for the sake of a friend's pleasure as he would undertake for the sake of his own.'²

Contemporary communist tendencies – most infamously the French collective Tiqqun – have taken up the effort to recover the transformative potential of friendship seen in these practices from both the grips of capital's social network and from the Schmidtian partitioning of the earth. Drawing from Agamben's essay 'The Friend', such tendencies in the contemporary communization movement have come to see friendship as a bond that both precedes and radically upends the social prescriptions of the Political domain.³ Friendship is embraced as a strategy for realizing a post-identitarian form of belonging in a world governed by seemingly endless separations. Friendship is the living practice of a 'politics to come', where our bonds are no longer subordinated to the rules of institutions; where our togetherness is no longer a mere response to enmity: our defense from an enemy other.⁴

Drawing from the Ancients, Claudia Baracchi variously describes friendship as a putting at stake of one's interiority; an act of fidelity to the epistemic precarities of an outside of oneself; an opening of subjectivity to the commons. Interpreting Aristotle's *Ethics*, Agamben shares Baracchi's emphasis: 'The friend is not an other I, but an otherness immanent to selfness, a becoming other of the self.'⁵ The politics of friendship as the common, as shared existence, is sharply contrasted by Aristotle with the 'goodwill' a citizen may feel toward society or a sportsperson toward a competitor.⁶ Goodwill is a relation of exteriors, a nod between drivers on a highway, a 'like' on an Instagram story; or it is the mere fact of sharing a space, of those practices that only reaffirm the perseverance of our separateness, our weakness, and disconnection.

As a bond that cuts through what divides, that opens what separates, Baracchi and Agamben stress that friendship's true manifestations involve a radical breakdown of the social predicates that otherwise govern our belongings. Agamben continues: 'To recognize someone as a friend means not being able to recognize him as

² Here Seneca paraphrases Epicurean teachings. Very little of the original works of the Garden have survived. See: Seneca, *Letters on Ethics*, in Brad Inwood and L. P. Gerson (eds) *The Epicurus Reader*, Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing, 1994, p. 81.

³ See, Giorgio Agamben, *What is an Apparatus*, Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2009.

⁴ See a critique of Schmidt's notion of friendship as a mere response to an enemy in Claudia Baracchi, 'On Enmity' in Claudia Baracchi, *Friendship: The Future of an Ancient Gift*, Indiana: Indiana University Press, 2023.

⁵ Baracchi, *Friendship*.

⁶ Aristotle, book IX.

a “something.” Calling someone “friend” is not the same as calling him “white,” “Italian,” or “hot,” since friendship is neither a property nor a quality of a subject.⁷

It was on these grounds that Foucault saw homosexual relations foremost as bonds of friendship. Neither as isolatable practices – this or that sexual act – nor as codifiable identities – ascribable to this or that social institution – but as ‘unforeseen lines of force’ that threaten to usurp governmentality’s distribution of roles. Foucault goes on to beautifully paint the bond of friendship as a formless formation: ‘They face each other without terms or convenient words, with nothing to assure them about the meaning of the movement that carries them toward each other. They have to invent, from A to Z, a relationship that is still formless, which is friendship: that is to say, the sum of everything through which they can give each other pleasure.’⁸

Friendship as a ‘sharing of that which is not possessed’ brings us to a notion of communism as something beyond any political choice to an ‘outside’. No longer a matter of the form of the governance of our relations to things – i.e. the question of the just distribution of property, its democratic enjoyment – the communism of friendship begins where ownership ends, as a transformation on the level of the possession of ourselves, an opening of that oneness of selfhood to the commons.⁹ Friendship is communism’s practice.

While the life ethics practiced in the Garden was in many ways a living practice of communism, the movement notably stayed away from any direct involvement in Greek or Roman Politics. Already evoked in what I have said above, I believe we can meaningfully interpret this noninvolvement as expressive of a certain genealogy of friendship as an anti-politics. Indeed, Baracchi observes, ‘friendship’s bond, impassioned and exclusive,’ fits poorly with the universalist ethos that came to dominate western genealogies of the Political.¹⁰ Indeed, in the tradition of friendship our ‘we’ is brought into opposition with the We of an abstract, universalizing, political

⁷ Aristotle, book IX, p. 31.

⁸ Michel Foucault, *Friendship as a Way of Life* in Paul Rabinow (ed) *Ethics: Subjectivity and Truth*, New York: The New Press, 1991.

⁹ As Jean Luc Nancy continues: ‘Communism alone took and retained the force of being more than a political choice, a political line and a party. [...] It exists essentially with other existing beings. The with is no external link, it is no link at all. It is togetherness—relation, sharing, exchange, mediation and immediation, meaning and feeling.’ See: Jean Luc Nancy, ‘Communism, the Word’, in Slavoj Žižek and Costas Douzinas (eds) *The Idea of Communism*, London and New York: Verso, 2010, p. 148.

collectivity produced through the mediation of the state's social contract. Communist friendship is an immanent, decidedly partial, minor politics – you are not, as is commonly known, indifferently a friend to everyone.¹¹

II

The purest security is that which comes from a quiet life and withdrawal from the many, although a certain degree of security from other men does come by means of the power to repel [attacks] and by means of prosperity.

– Diogenes Laertius, *The Principle Doctrines [of Epicureanism]*

Although Epicurean communes spread around the Mediterranean – persisting for centuries, while also gaining a more general plebian popularity through slogans, leaflets, and merchandise (e.g. maxims were engraved on the backs of mirrors and combs: 'death is nothing'), the movement never introduced a revolutionary strategy for abolishing the social order that they opposed. Meanwhile, their ethics were partially incorporated into the Roman state by way of figures like Cicero who at the same time supported the reign of inequality by defending the institution of slavery. On these grounds, one can see how the living communism of friendship is at risk of merely becoming a more or less acceptable 'alternative' at the margins of society and coexisting in a functionable tension with the state, the military, and capital.

The living communism of friendship's particular path in the Czechoslovak dissident movement is especially relevant for our purposes here. Seeing the recuperation of the revolutionary demands of 1968 by the state, the movement became disillusioned with the prospects opened by 'reform communism'. Tides changed in a shift from struggles for a revolution in the social organization of society as a whole, to a focus on an existential revolution wherein: 'existence was now supposed to be transformed at its most fundamental level – but the scope of that change was restricted to the small spaces of relative freedom the dissidents were able to carve out of the irredeemable social whole.'¹² In almost direct reference to the Epicurean commune, the dissidents referred to their islands of freedom as 'parallel poleis'.¹³

¹⁰ Baracchi, *Friendship*, p. 4.

¹¹ Although some accounts show that Epicurus had friends on every corner.

Like the Epicurean case, the limits of this anti-politics were in that: 'The tactic of revealing the system's inherent absurdity, while developing alternatives within its remaining autonomous spaces, made it possible to reject the system as a whole without developing a positive program for overthrowing and replacing it.'¹⁴ Making matters worse, by the time of the dissolution of Czechoslovakia in 1990, this interpersonal secession from the social whole came to stand in almost frictionless adjacency with a general imperative of the state and capital: the neoliberal privatization of the social. As Feinberg concludes, under this strategy of secession: 'Existential transformation could be relegated to the internal existence of each separate being, as long as a basic minimum of formal civic freedom was protected'.¹⁵

It is in this sense that the living communism of friendship is at risk of becoming a kind of aristocratic ethics – a metaphysical system of virtue claimed by individuals who make the choice to leave society, with its class divisions, etc. Left to the existential domain, the living communism of friendship offers its solutions without clear consideration of the necessary means to practically implement these desired bonds of friendship in a world that does so much to oppose them. How, indeed, are we to practice a communist politics of friendship in a world of competition, private property, and myriad inequalities? From the Epicureans to Aristotle and on to Kant, it is in the notable absence of any real answers to this question that the Marxist tradition came to be so fiercely critical of ethics as politics.

Marx and the broader historical materialist tradition came to see the undertaking of formulating an idea of the good life in abstraction of historical factors as at best a fruitless idealism and at worst a rouse of reason of the enlightened ruling class. The assumed autonomy of the subject is considered not as a neutral, universal, a priori basis of political practice, but rather as a formulation of politics from the historical, heteronomous standpoint of the owning classes. Feminist theorists orbiting historical materialism, such as Carole Pateman and Ellen Meiksins Woods, have traced the misogyny, racism, and

¹² Joseph Grim Feinberg, '1989: The Triumph of Truth and the Burial of Philosophy', in Jana Ndiaye Berankova, Michael Hauser and Nick Nesbitt (eds) *Revolutions of the Future: May '68 and the Prague Spring*, Paris: Suture Press, 2020, p. 307.

¹³ Václav Benda, 'The Parallel "Polis"' in H. Gordon Skilling and Paul Wilson (eds) *Civic Freedom in Central Europe. Voices from Czechoslovakia*, New York: St. Martin's Press, 1991, pp. 35-41.

¹⁴ Feinberg, '1989', p. 313.

¹⁵ Feinberg, '1989', p. 315.

class prejudice at the core of the Aristotelian genealogy of ethics. Pateman aptly comments that Kant, in predicating the subject of politics as the 'civil personality' who bears the 'Right to the possession of an external object as a Thing and the use of it as a Person', excludes all those who are not self-owners from participation in the ethico-political community.¹⁶ Indeed, while Baracchi insists that Aristotelian friendship emerges 'beyond pre-established roles,' she admits that 'of course, it was precisely these men (free from conditions of servitude and from the restrictions imposed on women) who were most likely to experience the bond of friendship in the full sense.'¹⁷ Aristotle frankly opposed *virtuous activity* – as the foundation for not only political participation but human existence as such – to the toils of the laborer who in not mastering his handiwork does not exist as a person and is but a talking tool. The ethico-political bond of friendship in presuming the autonomy of all as the basis of belonging is able to turn politics into an ethical practice of the community – and possibly a living practice of communism – yet in doing so it risks capitulation to the aristocratic counter-revolution: a politics that presumes the free proprietorship of the individual as a basis for participation in the community of friends. Does, in other words, the abolition of the proprietary individual of class society not rest on the proprietary agency of that same individual who chooses to no longer live that way?

Commenting on Tiquun's communist ethics of friendship, the collective Endnotes presents three critiques that expand on what has already been noted: 1) Ethics is authoritarian – for who decides on the norms of good and bad practices? 2) Sharing, whether in the beloved community of the family or as part of an illegal occupation, is no real threat to capital. The first form is free reproductive labor, while the second is a resource that can be enclosed so that value can be extracted from it later on. 3) Politics as an ethics of friendship is voluntarist. For does the disarticulation of social predicates (i.e. class, race, gender, nationality, etc.) through bonds established with friends, not depend on an act of sovereign refusal by the very same bourgeois subject of autonomy that the group's entire idea of the communist 'we of friendship' is set out to overcome? Endnote concludes:

¹⁶ Carole Pateman, *The Sexual Contract*, New York: Manning Press, 1992, p. 169.

¹⁷ Ibid, p. 42.

The old abstraction of egoistic subject goes through a strange mutation in the present phase in the form of the insurrectionist – a truly Stirnerite subject – for whom it is not only class belonging that can be cast off through a voluntarist aspiration, but the very imposition of the 'self' per se.¹⁸

Is the living communism of friendship limited to the wishful propagation of islands of virtue amidst the impoverished heteronomies of empire – marginal territories purged of the inhumanities of capital? In binding ourselves to communism's beloved community of friendship, are only the most marginal practices at the outskirts of capital's dominions and mediations of the social permitted?

Whatever the answers we may arrive at, it is clear that insofar as the communism of friendship remains a politics of flight, one 'inevitably brings the sands with them, hidden in the folds of their clothes and their lives' and, as Marcello Tari continues, 'The sand begins to corrode that which is at rest. Hostility returns and moves freely within the oases – communes, friendships, lovers, research – making them at first emotionally and then materially identical to all the rest; that is mediocre and uninhabitable.'¹⁹ Finally, the practice of communism as a politics of flight from the world is fully stripped of its teeth, becoming but one fraught effort for authentic belonging amongst the myriad others in the republic of capital. As Pinko collective starkly accounts:

At its worst, community serves as an obscuring fantasy, a fiction we use to psychologically protect ourselves from the horror and despair of life under capitalism. We seize upon a given group of friends, a snapshot of a momentarily vibrant social world, and hope it can last. As it erodes, we set out to find another, or to patch it up where we can. Community serves as an ideological fiction, covering over the relentless harm of capitalist social relation and cruel state policies.²⁰

It should not come as a surprise that one of the most 'successful'

¹⁸ Endnotes, 'What are We to Do?' in Benjamin Noys (ed) *Communization and Its Discontents*, London: Minor Compositions, 2011, p. 32.

¹⁹ Marcello Tari, *There is No Unhappy Revolution: The Communism of Destitution*, New York: Common Notions, 2021, p. 92.

²⁰ Pink Collective, *After Accountability: A Critical Genealogy of a Concept*, New York: Wendy's Subway, 2024.

manifestations of the communism of friendship is claimed, by Martin Buber, to be achieved by the post-WWI Jewish chaluzism (settlerism) movement in Palestine. As argued by Buber in his work *Paths in Utopia*, the Zvuza (spiritual community) organized by the pioneers fulfilled what the European utopian socialists could only dream of. And how did they do this? Buber doesn't mince words when he states that this was through their ability to 'possess' the land. It is here that we arrive at the essential crisis of the bond of friendship. The Zvuza takes shape through the flight of European Jews from the 'apocalyptic' contradictions of capitalist modernity in post-war Europe, while grounding its own coherence as an ethico-political form in the denial of the contradictions it hurled itself into by the fact of participating in a settler-colonial movement of land dispossession.

From the Fourier-inspired phalansteries in the colonial frontiers of the United States, to the Zvuza's of Palestine, and on to the parallel poleis of Prague and the gardens of the Mediterranean, we must confront the simple fact that the sand will always follow those who flee.

Comradeship

Comradeship isn't personal. It's political.

– Jodi Dean, *Comrade: An Essay on Political Belonging*

Communism is what excludes (and excludes itself from) every already constituted community.

– Maurice Blanchot, *The Unfathomable Community*

In Europe in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, the proximity between comradeship and friendship was in fact so close that modes of address pertaining to these forms of relation were often used interchangeably. For instance, the Yiddish word *khaveyrem* is translated as friends, buddies, comrades. This interchangeability points to a politics that saw shared existence and common goals as inextricably bound. Yet, the insoluble contradictions the world confronted in events like the Paris commune of 1871 amounted in an eventual bifurcation between friendship and comradeship as the foundational conditions of belonging to the revolutionary movement. On the one hand, there emerged a mode of acting which separated the means and the ends (comradeship) and, on the other, a

mode which refused this separation (friendship).

Surpassing the contradictions noted by Tari in the commune's politics of flight, the communards of Paris erected their revolutionary bonds of friendship in the metropolitan heart of empire, taking up arms to defend the living forces of communism that would rapidly generate in its tragically short-lived existence.

The commune marked the full revolutionary manifestation of friendship, surpassing the contradictions of its life in the aristocratic circles of the ethico-political community.²¹ And far beyond an expression of French heroism, the commune of 1871 must be seen as the manifestation of 'the universal republic'. Made up of individuals from myriad backgrounds, the commune took its inspiration from the Eastern European peasant commune (*Obshchina*) amongst other agrarian communist formations, which were introduced to the movement by Eastern communards like Vera Zasulich and Peter Kropotkin.²²

Yet, its bloody military defeat raised urgent questions for the communist movements that would follow. As Rancière nicely put it, the commune, in taking the form of a living manifestation of communism – its means and ends reconciled on the level of acts – meant that '[...] it was too much occupied in incubating a new society to attend to the "cannibals" which were at its gates.'²³ Importantly, Rancière does not see this tension as a matter of the communards' pacifist naivety, but as an 'essential contradiction between force of conflict and strength of world, between a mode of acting which separated the means and the ends and a mode of acting which did not separate them.'²⁴

Between 1918 and 1919, Hungarian philosopher György Lukács found himself confronted by the schism that came to politically transpire between these two modes. Lukács opposed what he saw as the Bolsheviks' tragic 'mode of acting' as they encountered the necessity for revolutionary violence, and a tragic 'mode of inaction',

²¹ For vivid examples of how the communards abolished social prescriptions of the capitalist social order see Kristin Ross, *Communal Luxury: The Political Imaginary of the Paris Commune*, London and New York: Verso, 2015. There, we see how the ideas of education, culture, and labor are radically transformed.

²² For more on role of Zasulich, Kropotkin and the east see Kristin Ross, 'The Literature of the North' in: Ross, *Communal Luxury*.

²³ Jacques Rancière, 'Around the Event of 1968 – Politics, Philosophy and Sociology' in Jana Ndiaye Berankova, Michael Hauser and Nick Nesbitt (eds) *Revolutions of the Future: May '68 and the Prague Spring*, Paris: Suture Press, 2020, p. 29.

²⁴ Rancière, 'Around the Event of 1968', pp. 29-30.

which he saw as the individual's only path for the preservation of virtue in light of these events. As Foster extrapolates, 'Tyranny and class rule, [Lukács] argues, cannot be justified [...] based on the mere faith that this will negate "the endless, senseless, chain of struggles."' ²⁵ Yet, only several months having passed since his ethical condemnation of the Bolshevik revolution, Lukács radically readdressed his thinking as the unexpected events of the Hungarian revolution of 1919 unfolded. Joining the communists, Lukács took part in an ethics committee where together with other comrades of the time, his earlier ideas of tragic ethical inaction would be radically rethought. Foster continues:

Lukács reintroduced the classic issue seen, for example, in Sophocles' *Antigone* – that of 'a primary ethic (obligation toward institutions) and a secondary ethic (obligation toward the soul).' The primacy of the secondary (second) ethic over the primary (first) ethic, he argued, 'always takes on a peculiar dialectical complexity when the soul is not sufficient unto itself but is involved in mankind – as in the case of political man, of the revolutionary. Here, if the soul is to be saved, the soul must be sacrificed: starting from a mystical ethic one is forced to become a brutal Realpolitiker and to violate the absolute commandment "Thou shalt not kill" which entails no obligations to institutions' ²⁶

Comradeship is the organizing principle for our navigation of the ethico-individual tragedy at the core of the revolutionary process. The immorality of the revolutionary deed finds its dialectical redemption through the sacrifice made for an emergent collectivity: the egalitarian, communist society of the future. In her book *Comrade: An Essay on Political Belonging*, Jodi Dean hence conceptualizes comradeship as involving an alienation from the personal (my preferences and choices as an individual) in sight of a common goal: the egalitarian future. ²⁷ The personal, as Dean sees it, is not outside politics but is rather produced as a spontaneous reflection of dominant systems on the unthought level of an 'authentic' experiencing

²⁵ John Bellamy Foster, 'Lukács and the Tragedy of Revolution: Reflections on "Tactics and Ethics"', *Monthly Review*, 2022, Available at: <https://monthlyreview.org/2022/02/01/lukacs-and-the-tragedy-of-revolution/>.

²⁶ Foster, 'Lukács and the Tragedy of Revolution'.

²⁷ Jodi Dean, *Comrade: An Essay on Political Belonging*, London and New York: Verso, 2019.

self. Comradeship calls for self-alienation and could then be seen as a process of collectively thinking this structuration of the personal, i.e. its mediation by capitalist power structures. For Dean, this is the first step in being accountable for the inequalities and violences imparted on our everyday relationships by their determinations.

It is on these grounds that Dean is able to see the bond of comradeship as a horizon of equality, which emerges within the struggle itself – a marker of ‘the division between the world of misery we have and the egalitarian communist world that will be.’²⁸ She also writes: ‘The determinations of a sexist, racist, capitalist society unavoidably intrude, but comrade names a relation no longer determined by these factors, providing a site from which they can be judged and addressed.’²⁹ Thus, just as the bond of friendship, comradeship is an organizing strategy for the negation of the socially prescribed roles we inherit as subjects living in a capitalist world. Yet, unlike friendship, which Dean dismisses as ‘exclusive and cliquish’, and as voluntarist and singularizing, comradeship holds a ‘reflex for solidarity that exceeds personal happiness’.³⁰ Beyond a matter of likes and dislikes, the solidarity we show for our comrades is foremost a matter of the collective discipline and sacrifice an individual makes in pursuing the communist horizon; a horizon that exceeds our own pleasures, the pleasures of our friends, our communities, our genders, our nations – comradeship is ‘generic’ and universalizing.³¹

II

Sadness doesn't mean a thing, comrade Kozlov, It shows that our class feels the whole world, and happiness is a far off business anyway[...] happiness will only lead to shame!

Andrei Platonov, *The Foundation Pit*

[...] he will change the world without touching himself and keep running after a certain month of May; he will continue to live his sexuality divorced from thought, and thoughtlessly if possible, in obscure situations where identity and groundwork are not at risk and desire is not exposed.

Guy Hocquenghem, *Screwball Asses*

²⁸ Dean, *Comrade*, p. 136.

²⁹ Dean, *Comrade*, p. 139.

³⁰ Dean, *Comrade*, p. 154.

³¹ Dean, *Comrade*, p. 57.

The ethico-individual sacrifice of the individual domain that the bond of comradeship enables through its horizontal politics permits Dean to defend Stalin as our comrade. Dean argues that Stalin and the broader Soviet statecraft project must be respected in their commitments to the imperative toward communism as a goal. Dean advances the idea that this respect can be maintained without it simply excusing the catastrophic course of action taken for the realization of its ends. To respect Stalin, despite it all, 'indicated belief in collective struggle for a better world'. But why? Because 'even anti-Stalinist skeptics have to admit [...]: the end of the twentieth century socialist experiment killed democracy. The tone of respect was thrown aside. The dream of emancipated equality died.'³² While one could choose to see Dean's defense of Stalin – as our comrade – as but a partial deviation from an otherwise sound politics, deeper questions can be raised that point to contradictions at the very core of comradeship's strategy of unmaking the social prescription of roles by capital.

Central here seems to be the problem of 'progress'. The revolutionary bond of comradeship, in its affordance of principled compromises in achieving its own contents (the living communism of friendship) was recuperated as a form of governance; a force of social control through which desire and power were organized. For instance, in Lenin's *State and Revolution* – written on the eve of the October revolution – the commune is centered as the foundation of communism, while the state-form, seen as an enemy and obstacle for the movement, was to be rapidly dissolved through a revolutionary strategy of the abolition of its functional units. History showed how from this strategic suspension of the movement's actualities as a living force of friendship, a tragic fissure was seeded that would take on a form absolutely contrary to what preceded it.

Walter Benjamin saw the Hitler-Stalin pact as a total discrediting of the Communists and wrote as an immediate response his scathing critique of the movement in 'On the Concept of History'. Concluding that the Soviet's appalling historical conformism followed that of the Social Democrats and National Socialists, Benjamin found that the core of the problem of these modern political forms was their historical progressivism. Comradeship aligned with these progressivist forms of history in asserting the possibility of an a priori goal established outside time which historical time may

³² Ibid, p. 266.

steadily, uniformly aspire toward as a pregiven ideal of political life. Progressivism is thus organized around what Benjamin calls the historical continuum of catastrophe wherein what diverges from history as a homogeneous course of progress must be violently expelled from its form as a deviation from its course. As Hamacher nicely puts it, drawing from Benjamin: 'The domain of forms belongs to the realm of domination, where permanence of forms can only be secured through the suppression of other possibilities – that is, possibilities of happiness – that rebel against such domination.'³³ Whether as an enterprise-form, an institutional-form, a state-form, or the value-form of capital, a form will always place its own perpetuation over any consideration of the consequences of this constancy for the world, for its members (seen as relatively disposable), and finally for the very contents of the future goal it aspires to progressively achieve.

Comradeship was transformed into the bond through which the counter-revolution was organized. It was through its progressivism that the state apparatus was eternalized; the horizon of communism now asserted as a regulative ideal, inducing sacrifice, justifying the perpetuation of unhappiness through the exacting historical science of the planned economy with its 'five year' benchmarks of progress. Comradeship ethically justified the genocidal extermination of the real forces of communism expounded in friendship and dialectically enabled through revolutionary violence.

Movement Messianism

Those who have encountered social movements in their lives should surely be familiar with magic. The magic of life's improbable disruption; the hubris of claiming happiness without duty; the messianism of an event that cannot be accounted for through the arithmetic of the political program's calculable, linear horizon of progress.³⁴

For the messianic movement there is no waiting: redemption, happiness, the shaking off of our prescriptions as this or that 'form'; it does not arrive as the result of a process; happiness isn't affirmed as the gradual organizational labor of producing the completion of a form,

³³ Werner Hamacher, "'Now': Walter Benjamin on Historical Time', in Heidrun Friesse (ed) *The Moment: Time and Rupture in Modern Thought*, Oxford: Oxford Academic, 2001.

³⁴ The notion of happiness is here drawn from Giorgio Agamben's reading of Benjamin in *Profanations*, Cambridge, MA: Zone Books, 2007; and also found in Hamacher's work 'Now' op. cit., ibid.

its final destination on the great highway of historical catastrophe. Messianism is not contained in any form; it unfolds within history as the unexpected possibility of the continuum's destitution; the classless society, as Benjamin saw it, is 'not the final goal of the progress of history, but rather its often failed, finally accomplished interruption.'³⁵

It is in this sense that movement messianism claims to circumvent both comradeship's resigned historical progressivism and friendship's propensity toward counter-revolutionary idealism. The messianic 'we' of the movement should not be mistaken with the notion of messianic romanticism. The claim of redemption is not, as is for romanticism, a form outside of time that manifests in time as the endowment of a subject with the divine power to transform the world through self-acts. The messiah is rather the 'we' of a position within time that is open to time; open to, that is to say, the revolutionary acknowledgement of immanent possibilities we have inherited from our ancestors. This open time is the time of the event: an opening of the world to the possibility of the abolition of the continuum of forms – a breakdown of the prescription of roles by authority; a shattering of our separations as this or that subject of the social order.

Movement messianism is not against the materialism of history but finds in this very materiality the unactualized forces of the thwarted potentialities of communism – those underserved claims of happiness and manifestations of the classless society that were oppressed and excluded by form. The messianic act is therefore an act of commemorative prophecy: not the mystical prophecy of the one who is endowed with a knowledge of the pre-given forms of a future redemption, but as those immanent actions of commemorating the forces already pregnant within this world that can dispose us to its overcoming – now.³⁶

The weak messiah declares that there is no sense in waiting for major events; that the laws, languages, orders, epistemes of our world only remain vital in their outer appearances; that the world we inhabit has long since been emptied of substance; that a new form of life is already pregnant in the old; that it is our calling to act on the historical plane to hasten this ending of the continuum.

As Federici observed, in the 16th and 17th century the eradication of movement messianism therefore came to be essential for the emergence of the capital-form:

³⁵ From Walter Benjamin's *Concept of History*, cited in Hamacher, *Now*.

³⁶ For more on prophecy as commemoration, see Daniel Bensaïd, *Marx for Our Times. Adventures and Misadventures Of a Critique*, London and New York: Verso, 2002.

prophecy was replaced with the calculation of probabilities whose advantage, from a capitalist viewpoint, is that here the future can be anticipated only insofar as the regularity and immutability of the system is assumed: that is, only insofar as it is assumed that the future will be like the past, and no major change, no revolution, will upset the coordinates of individual decision-making.³⁷

Movement messianism returns ethics to politics while circumnavigating the problem of subjective autonomy found in the study of friendship. Messianic ethics arrives to the subject from outside as that openness to the possibilities of redemption located, as immanent possibilities, in the world. Inverting an ethics founded on the virtue of acts – i.e. the responsibility of the community to conform to the virtues of communism – movement messianism begins by naming an historical injustice, basing its ethics on the responsibility to overcome it, and being guided by the weak endowment of the possibilities we have inherited to do so by the past.

II

While movement messianism responds to the contradictions explored in both friendship and comradeship, there is the question of how these untimely openings of redemption persist as living practices after their initial manifestations? As anyone who has taken part in social movements will have experienced in one way or another, the magic has a way of ebbing and flowing over the course of a movement's cycle. The new modalities of togetherness are stretched, repressed, and depleted; social predicates spectacularly overcome in one instance, return in an ever-hardened form in the next. We return to work, to home, to all that ensures the persistence of our forms – the harms, the exploitations, the dominations, the abuses.

Indeed, looking back at the past decades, some have come to bring a healthy sense of questioning to contemporary messianic tendencies that maintain popularity by selling a magical politics that promises communism in the here and now. Vincent Bevins's recent book *If We Burn: The Mass Protest Decade and the Missing Revolution*, is one of the more bitter examples of this critique of messianic politics. I will quote Bevins's conclusion at length:

³⁷ Silvia Federici, *Caliban and the Witch: Women, the Body, and Primitive Accumulation*, New York: Autonomedia, 2004.

What about those magical, radiant days, the moments when you felt that your very soul became fused with the forces of history, that you were bigger and more powerful. That all your differences melted away, and that you and your fellow revolutionaries were literally remaking the world, with each and every thing that you did.

[...]

You can get yourself all fucked up on revolutionary élan, just like you can drink alcohol or take drugs. But it warps your senses and causes you to make poor decisions. It isn't real, and you're going to pay for it later. If you want the feeling of mass ecstasy you should go to a music festival instead of encouraging vulnerable young people to go out and get killed. Indeed, it seems you can probably draw a line from the ethos of the New Left and the arrival of Woodstock, and then, ultimately, to Coachella.³⁸

³⁸ Vincent Bevins, *If We Burn: The Mass Protest Decade and the Missing Revolution*, New York: PublicAffairs, 2023.

A Conclusion or an Opening of a Conversation between Friends

Dear Noah,

Think I remember you suggesting that you don't like the conclusion. Can see that the intention is to end on a note of pessimism or doubt, but the long quote from Bevin is a little like being dropped off a cliff edge into the wrong kind of leftist melancholia. I haven't read his book but get the sense he adopts the posture of 'maturity' disabused of the supposed radicalism of youth. I never really trust that particular perspective since it often, almost always, is a way to accommodate oneself to defeat and assimilate oneself to the ruling order of the world. Anyway, the conclusion definitely needs a little more elaboration or critique, perhaps a restatement of the communist ethics of friendship. In the thought and elucidation of that—most definitely in Tari and the Tiqqun text Theses on the Terrible Community—there is a frequent acknowledgement of the difficulties of maintaining the ethical relation of anti-political friendship. That it is not a given and is frequently undermined by the world that it opposes. That would seem to fit with your introduction and it might be an idea to revisit the origins of your reflections in light of some of the points raised in the body of the essay.

My own perspective is that the modalities of the communist ethics of friendship are fully limned and limited by the brokenness of dominant social relations, are necessarily, inevitably, formed and deformed within what amounts to a series of shared separations. Such ethical counter-relations as you describe are folded within the fragmentary, difficult at times to fully comprehend, totality of the community of capital. Hence, the conflicts that can emerge, the paradoxical mutualities of narcissism, mental illnesses, the tendencies to reconstitute as a racket or simply fall apart. However, this doesn't mean that foregrounding friendship as an anti-political ethics is in some way pointless or needs to be cast aside yet again in favour of formal organisational modes such as the party or some variation on such. This is partly because, while one should never say never, it seems that the time of the mass party or even the mass social movement is definitively over. The political subjects that gave form to these, such as the figures of the worker and militant, have receded, decomposed and shifted to the extent that to invoke them in the shape they took in the twentieth century is to invoke phantasms.

*Dean's notion of reconstituting this is nonsense. The anti-politics of friendship can be viewed, as you suggest, as a response to this. I would go even further and suggest that it is an attempt to theorise in the present what Marx termed the 'historical party'—an important point of reflection for Jacques Camatte in *Origin and Function of the Party Form*—rather than the formal, ephemeral political party with which it is often, even always, in relation. In a narrow sense, the 'historical party' is loose associations of friends, acquaintances and informal groups, in a far greater sense it is 'our party' as the proletarianised class of negation that would dissolve capitalism. Whether a communist ethics of friendship succeeds in formulating a mode of contestation adequate to this and to the events and crises of the present remains undecidable.*

Although, phrasing it in this way only suggests a kind of game of instrumental necessity or historical succession and that is not quite what I mean. In a sense, the communist ethics of friendship is not the 'answer' to a problem of organization, while being on the same plane of composition, since it concerns the problems of being together in some kind of opposition to the existent order of the world. Perhaps, within it there might be glimpsed the articulation, not the prefiguration, of communism as immanent to the very brokenness of this world of capital. The lacks and fractures—the inevitable inability to create a pure garden of communist ethics—that are an element of such relations are also constitutive of the truth of this. Endnotes critique is good as far as it goes but, I think, remains limited by an inability to view 'sharing' as being limited to resources, whereas what is 'shared' is the ethical relation as such. This is not 'voluntarist'—assuming it is not limited to an insurrectionist vanguard—since it is an imperative that arises from being in the world and so is unavoidable. The 'ethics' that arise are not so much 'authoritarian' as immanent to this and marked by relations of friendship and enmity, by the situation itself. So, such ethical relations are never perfected, and this is probably the point I'm trying to excavate. The messianic model of communism that anti-political friendship embodies is fully immanent and not in the slightest teleological. There is no mythical point on the horizon where it might arrive completely formed, where the contradictions of capital have sufficiently ripened or, equally, where we somehow don't always already exist in a miasma of the world as it is. It is an attempt to find new ways to use and unbind the things and relations of this world including, perhaps, friendship. Obviously, not to

say this is in some way enough or communism is so immanent it is here—an undoubted error of this tendency—but in terms of general conditions of collapse and catastrophe it's preferable to awaiting the confirmation of theoretical hypotheses or a desperate realignment towards parodies of the old, social democratic left. Or, rather, the communist ethics of friendship poses a question regarding more conventional modalities of politics that is in itself a certain kind of refusal.

It is also worth noting in terms of 'movement messianism' that the messianic, in Benjamin's sense, is not limited to the event or crisis and also seeps through the everyday and is absolutely profane. I think this helps to formulate the notion of the communist ethics of friendship as not reducible to moments that are laden with 'political' significance. Also, a broader, not unrelated point: some kind of ethics of anti-political friendship is not limited to those who are 'communists' but also to those others, who don't care about 'communism'. While often theorised as elective groups or communes, the kind of anti-politics espoused in such an ethics is—or ought to be—more expansive, open to the more contingent affinities that exist beyond declared 'communists' or militants. This might have great relevance to the question of the 'historical party'.

There's probably more to say but that's enough for now. Enjoyed reading and hope some of the above is useful,

Best,

Anacharsis Cloots Deputation

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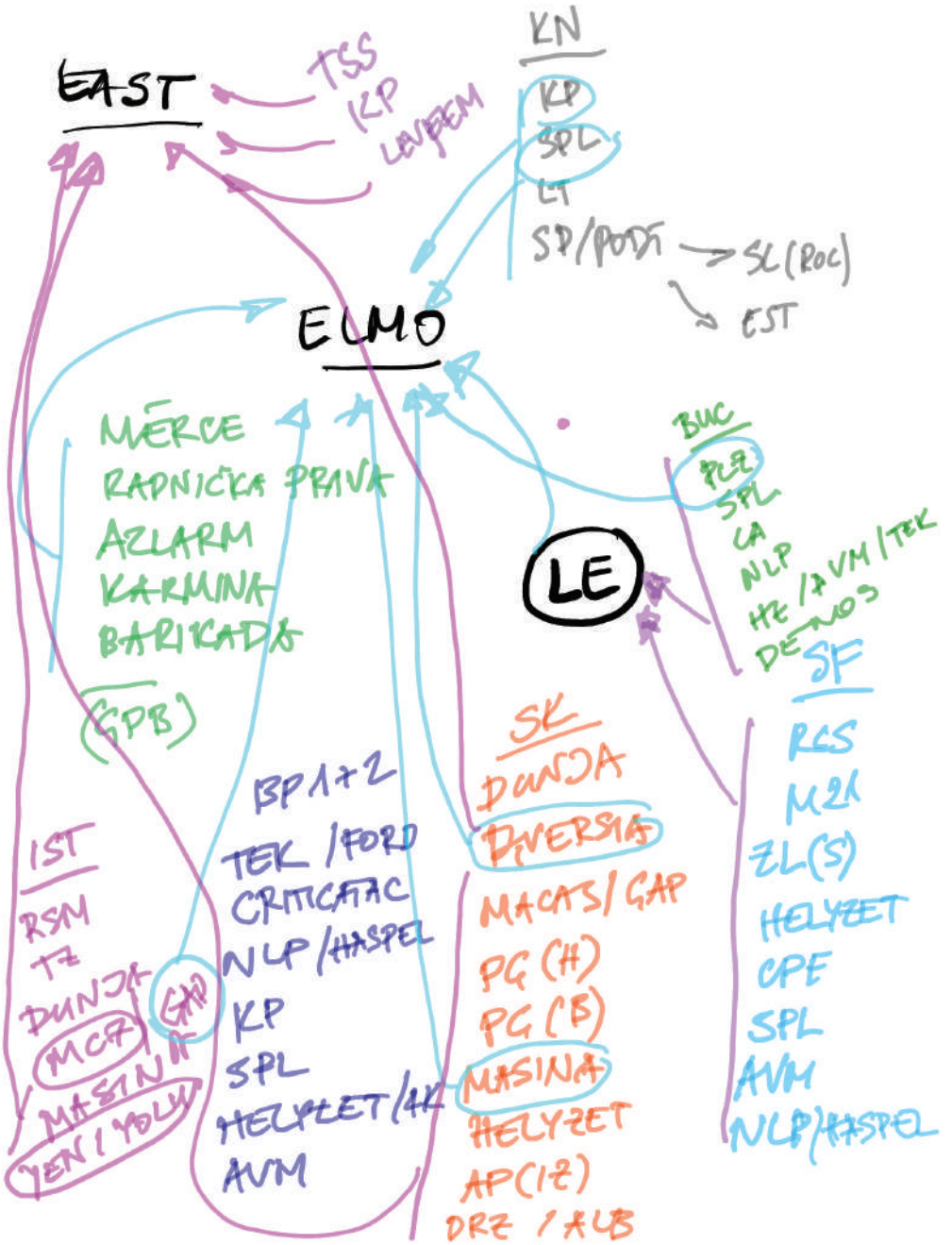
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Fragments towards a Post-Socialist Networked Commons: LeftEast as Praxis

Normally, when I go to the communities I prefer a dialogue, not a conference

– Raul Zibechi, at an event organized around his latest book, *Constructing Worlds Otherwise*, May 10th, 2024

The media platform LeftEast has formally been around since 2013. Most people know of LeftEast as a website where they can read a range of writing from leftist perspectives from/and/about the formerly socialist countries of Eastern Europe and the Soviet Bloc. But what lies behind it is a set of processes which are animated by the relationalities that produce and reproduce it, and to which it also contributes.

In the fragments of conversation below, Mary and Mariya, two members of LeftEast, open up a discussion on the process of producing and reproducing LeftEast as an element in a networked commons of the Left in the region, touching on questions of relationality, affect, cooperation, infrastructure, and the commons.

In our dialogue we stress the relational part of building a dynamic commons that networks the regional new Lefts to one another, to parts of the old Left(s) in the region, and to comrades and formations further abroad. We reflect on the practice of encounter (*encuentro*), a term we have used to describe our summer convergences, but also to reflect LeftEast's relational work. Seen in a relational light, even LeftEast's website featuring articles that excavate the past and analyze and report on the present can be perceived as a conversation, or encounter.

Our convergences and communications beyond the written page (yet whose traces are found there as well) are experiments in developing not just cognitive but also bodily knowledges – affective and relational – that underpin our collective analysis, forms of struggle, and solidarity. When we come together in locations in the region, hosted by fellow activists in the places where they mobilize, learning stories of struggle, developing analysis, and sharing

moments of joy or frustration together, we learn at least as much, and produce at least as much knowledge as we do from the many articles posted on LeftEast, if not more. Across these two media, the written word and bodily presence, we develop complementary kinds of knowledge – *connaître* and the *savoir* – related to networks of solidarity and cooperation in the region and beyond.

This emerging commons of the regional new Left may shoot off tendrils towards the region's old Left previously in institution-alized power, but it is built on the terrain of both the latter's partial failure as well as the coordinated attacks to erase any of its successes. On this terrain where shock therapy has undermined the common resources that were made 'public' under the governance of the old Left regime, the post-socialist Left has had to operate with extremely limited resources, and in a very hostile environment. Thus, as we work to common knowledge that the new Left is developing, we are also building a common movement infrastructure. With an eye towards the dynamic and relational aspects, we can see that this entails a network connected through texts, organizations, individuals, shared projects at different scales, resource sharing, and cooperation. It also includes a shared predicament, as we can often find understanding, sympathy, and solidarity only among those who struggle in a similar context.

Without skirting the serious limitations presented to us by the past, we try to develop and make accessible knowledge that contributes to the political legitimacy and sustainability of leftist movements in the 'post-socialist world', contributing to the 'infrastructure of feeling' of the Eastern European radical tradition.

The Black Radical Tradition is a constantly evolving accumulation of structures of feeling whose individual and collective narrative arcs persistently tend toward freedom. It is a way of mindful action that is constantly renewed and refreshed over time but maintains strength, speed, stamina, agility, flexibility, balance. The great explosions and distortions of modernity put into motion – and constant

The final written word that shows up in a LeftEast article is the result of (and contribution to) sustained relational work among movements and/or their participants, but there also many affective/relational and organizational knowledges that both sustain and are sustained or developed through our praxis. LeftEast, along with many other nodes in this network, is an experiment in how to sustain the movement.

interaction – already existing as well as novel understandings of difference, possession, dependence, abundance. As a result, the selection and reselection of ancestors is itself part of the radical process of finding anywhere – if not everywhere – in political practice and analytical habit, lived expressions (including opacities) of unbounded participatory openness. What underlies such accumulation? What is the productive capacity of visionary or crisis-driven or even exhaustion provoked reselection? The best I can offer, until something better comes along, is what I've called for many years the 'infrastructure of feeling.'

– Ruth Wilson Gilmore. *Abolition Geography. Essays towards Liberation*. London and New York: Verso, 2022.

We experiment with how to produce sustainable Left institutions and organizations, and we also produce and share knowledge about it.

LeftEast thus might also be considered a commons: the forms of collective knowledge production in which we engage mean that we are a host or site of the regional knowledge commons, but also that we – sometimes as individuals and mostly as a collective – on some level function as such. We do this through careful work with authors in the process of developing their texts, and with movements when working on shared events and projects on different scales. In our relational work, we co-produce a sociality and solidarity that (spreads and) contributes to a larger movement infrastructure.

While the relational processes of production may in most cases be invisible to the readers of the texts published on the pages of LeftEast, we speak below of the collective knowledge production that blossoms in the summer encounters (workshops, convergences, or schools), and our editorial practices oriented towards (re)producing solidarity. Discussing LeftEast as a process also means addressing some shortcomings we have experienced along the way, such as the exhausting expenditure of labor and care put into organizing summer encounters, working on LeftEast publications, and contributing to networks such as the East European Left Media Outlet (ELMO). The knowledge we have of the difficulty of sustaining these processes is a valuable part of the commons we are growing. The tension between the experiment in commoning and the (often asymmetric) effort it requires – also *vis-à-vis* questions of internally and externally perceived ideas of efficiency and quality – holds many lessons.

The fragments of conversation below between two LeftEast collective members who have become close friends over a decade of cooperation are idiosyncratic and situated in our experiences and interpretations. These interchangeable and incomplete fragments are moments in our process of revisiting and chronicling a decade of struggle in Eastern Europe through the lens of our work with LeftEast, extending our relations back and forward in time. We ask that you read these fragments that emerge through the rhythms of dialogue with curiosity and openness, anticipating that the questions generated in one moment may only be answered in another, or not at all, as the conversation loops back around. Dates are useful signposts for orientation as you travel through these fragments.

Fragment 1: Encounter

Mary: We've called our near-annual gathering a 'summer university', a 'summer school without teachers', a 'workshop', 'convergence', or 'encounter' over the decades we've organized them, and as they have become a central modality of LeftEast's work. To me, landing on the term 'encounter' in 2015 felt like more than just a catchy word choice. In my life, the term encounter – *encuentro* – has mostly been a reference to modalities developed by the Zapatistas in Chiapas (Mexico). But long before we explicitly used this language, some of us had pushed against a tendency to call our summer meetings 'conferences'.

In the summer of 2013, for example, when we converged at Social Center Xaspel in Sofia, I noticed that many participants, my comrades – activists and scholars working in and on the formerly state socialist region of Eastern Europe – were leaving a big mess behind at the end of each day. It seemed to me that people were so accustomed to the model of the academic conference, usually held in hotels or conference centers with cleaning staff, that there was little awareness about the different kinds of labor behind the event. A group operating within Xaspel had gotten funds to put on the event, and some were paid to do the labor of organizing it, but the emphasis had been on making sure that activists from the region would not have to pay for travel and lodging. Still, there wasn't much awareness among those of us who attended about the labor behind it, or attention to the prefigurative or micropolitical aspects of coming together in a gathering like this. Back to 2015: thinking in the language of encounter, I thought, opened a chance to consciously exercise a learning together around such questions.

Mariya: I remember learning this from you in the Spring of 2011, when you came to Sofia to take part in the Transeuropa Festival, where we were running some events at the first location of Social Center Xaspel. But we had a somewhat static way of organizing spaces and public interaction... we were learning. You came to screen a movie at Xaspel – but instead of expecting us to sit in silence for two hours, you led a lively conversation around a few longer snippets you had curated. We ended up discussing different modalities of organizing on the Left, historically, and also how to organize the space of the social center. It was quite an eye-opening experience for me. I also remember when the question of *encuentro* was brought in some years later – partly as a conscious way to subvert the ‘summer school’ or ‘conference’ language, and partly to signal our location in Kaunas: we called it our EnKaunTer.

Mary: I saw your attempts at this in 2011, as you utilized multiple spaces and modalities – we even went on a ‘derive’, or ‘drift’ – although none of you would have called it that. Coming to Xaspel to show Miklós Jancsó’s *The Confrontation* (*Fényes szelek* – ‘Bright Winds’; 1969) was an opportunity to learn about your work and struggles in Sofia. It was very different from my experience of giving the keynote lecture at the liberal Red House Centre for Culture and Debate, which you also organized, where it was very speaker-audience oriented. I think that in 2015, the name EnKaunTer was influenced by the fact that our co-organizers that year were deeply influenced by micropolitical and prefigurative ideas and methods that had affinity with the thinking of Félix Guattari and Gilles Deleuze and/or had made their way from Latin America to the 15m movements in Spain and to anarchists and anti-authoritarians across Europe. This explicit (perhaps over)emphasis on methods contrasted with the earlier meetings.

The Zapatista model of *encuentro* does not rely on ideology, organizational affiliation, or even identity. *Encuentro* as a political strategy and space should not be confused with a political rally, radical academic conference, or activist forum. An *encuentro* is not a space to

Mariya: This was also a specific moment in my own thinking. On the one hand, it resonated for me personally, as I had just returned from fieldwork in Venezuela, where the language of was used, without explicit reference to the Zapatistas. This was the case when radical students,

impose an already established political program in order to 'conscientize' community to a specific issue. It is not a chic approach to capture activist market share. Rather, *encuentros* are spaces for a collective analysis and vision to emerge.

'It is not an attempt to establish political and programmatic agreements, nor to attempt a new version of the International. Nor does it have to do with unifying theoretical concepts or standardizing conceptions, but with finding, and or building, common points of discussion. Something like constructing theoretical and practical images which are seen and experienced from different places.' (21)

The effort at *encuentro* affirms local struggles while being animated by larger networks of opposition against neoliberalism that 'circulate struggle.' It connects the "first world" and "third world" without implying either a liberal or even a radical tutelage. Zapatismo challenges "the movement" to collectively nurture the space of encounter as "a commons of wealth not yet lost". (22)

– Manuel Callahan (quoting Subcomandante Marcos (21) and Midnight Notes Collective (22). 'Why not share a dream? Zapatismo as Political and Cultural Practice' In Special issue: *Humboldt Journal of Social Relations* 29.1 (January, 2005): pp. 6-37.)

academics, or activists sympathetic to the Bolivarian process, some of them active in militant groups further to the Left of the government, attempted to offer constructive critique from within. Similarly, the New Left in our formerly socialist region was beginning to develop its own voice, offering constructive critique of the socialist past without completely rejecting its progressive elements, even while our societies were constantly exposed to anti-communist education, media, and legislation equating socialism to Nazism.

On the other hand, by then, we – the New Left movements in the region – had moved from more static presenter/audience forms to a broader diversity of formats. We had just experienced – and this time in communication with each other – the region's 2012-13 wave of protests. It could perhaps be seen as the Eastern European 'chapter' of the Arab Spring/Occupy wave, or perhaps as something in its own right that never had such a prominent name or brand. As part of this we had started to develop a relationship to the autonomist Marxist language of reclaiming the commons, making reference not only to a pre-capitalist pre-colonial past, but also to the public infrastructure developed under state socialism and privatized and/or left to crumble after 1989.

In this context, LeftEast – encompassing both the website and the encounters we were co-producing with local groups around the region – acted as a resource. We were not only reclaiming the commons but also producing a new commons: a free resource that we built together and that allows us to share knowledge from the Left in today's lingua franca, English. But it was also to some degree a space for open dialogue, support, solidarity, and care which are scarce resources under advanced capitalism.

Mary: Even though it is not part of the 'content part' of our encounters, solidarity housing comes to mind for me as an example of a relational method that I think is quite productive.

Solidarity housing is such a great way of creating a context in which people get to know each other more and find deeper connection. What starts as a seeming resource problem – our budget doesn't allow for hotel rooms – turns out to be a mechanism for getting to know people, for cooperating, and finding ways in which we relate beyond ideas or platforms.

I think the exercise of resource sharing and resource redistribution, of which solidarity housing is an example (but we could also mention the care work of cooking, cleaning, compiling reading lists, organizing visits and drifts, and other forms of reproductive labor necessary to support the event and its participants) opens up to considerations of prefiguration (I've called it 'transfiguration' elsewhere) as well as affect. These are also essential elements in the sustainability of movement organizations. We do not all need to be close friends, but we do need to develop habits of cooperation. The affective character of this cannot be underestimated, even if there is a mechanical character to it as well.

It was in the space of the summer school that I found myself using the language of transfiguration. In our third summer convergence, held in Sofia, Bulgaria, I found myself using the word transfigurative. I'm not sure if it was simply that the word prefigurative didn't come to my tongue in time, or if I indeed, if only subconsciously,

Mariya: The question of different formats and how we go about knowledge production and sharing – both in the encounters and on the pages of LeftEast – took a front seat for me at our Istanbul convergence in 2016. This was the first time that we introduced a reading list, made of academic and political texts, compiled together by the local group

recognised the gap. That year the summer school was organised by folks running a social centre. We were very lucky to be hosted there at this self-organised institution outside the coercions of universities or conference centers (such as how and when space can be used for what purpose, cooking, drinking, etc.). I had become frustrated with the way that people had slipped into behaviour that is naturalised at academic conferences. People were leaving their coffee cups, plates, other things, laying around as if some hidden cleaning force was going to clean it up for them at the end of the day; without thinking about how things would get cleaned up by morning. I wanted to make sure that my comrades were reminded of the fact that this was a self-organised event and that it meant that we all had to take responsibility for the space (for our community effort; for the movement). So in my plea to them to recognise that our task was not just to talk about these things and enact them on some grand political level, I stressed it was also about solidarity amongst ourselves, about behaving in a cooperative manner.

So I used this word 'transfigurative' quite spontaneously, I suppose because of my contradictory relationship with the

and the international group that included LeftEast editors. I read everything very diligently. I was really curious. Turkey was really an unknown context for me. I read but registered nothing. I didn't remember articles or arguments. It was just a mess in my head.

But then we had this very strange experience because the same night we arrived, the attempted coup d'état against Erdogan took place! I remember how, in the days after the coup, because of this political violence, volatility, and emergency, a lot of this knowledge became useful for me to explain to myself what was going on and to communicate to others. For example: why we were no longer able to meet with some local movements (Alevi and Kurdish ethnic minorities) while others (migrant groups, especially) were able to host us; who the people on the street waving their Grey Wolf flags were; where the Gülen Movement fit in and why its people were now being arrested; what role the university communities were playing. All of it somehow really came into place, like a domino effect. All this literature, including articles we had published on LeftEast, became very useful. And, of course, the fact that we had our comrades there and could share this uncanny experience with them made it much more precious and imme-

language of the prefigurative. I like the former term because I think what it does is it pull us away from the idea that there is this static model of something that we do outside of the dominant social relations that models, prefigures, the change we want to see. I like transfigurative politics because it points to transformation, and when I look at the transformations I (or for that matter other authors in this volume) have been through I regard them as incredibly important to bring about, in cultivating this revolution.

— Mary N. Taylor 'Space, Time, Co-revolutionary Praxis'. In Charlotte Huddleston, Abby Cunnane, Sakiko Sugawa, and Mary N. Taylor, (eds) *Co-revolutionary Praxis: Accompaniment as a Strategy for Working Together*. Auckland NZ: ST PAUL St. Gallery Publishing; pp. 22-23.

diate than anything. The people from former Yugoslavia shared their immediate memories of the wars while the jets were flying over our heads. It was quite a traumatic experience for some, but the conversations that the situation generated were unique.

Similarly to our Sofia convergence in 2013, when 50,000 people were out on the street protesting while our gathering was taking place, and we started to integrate trips to different movement spaces in the city, in Istanbul, too, it was very clear that even participants with significant experience of high-risk activism and movement work had to do a lot of reorienting to really understand and act adequately in the intricate new conditions emerging in the detonated mine-field of a complex political context.

Among the people who come to the convergences, there have been those who have been way more engaged in working with marginalized groups as allies, and others who are more in the field of expert knowledge production, or have been working on building infrastructure for themselves rather than trying to reach beyond their own circle. There have been tense moments when, for me, it's been interesting to reflect on the fact that with regard to the question of knowledge production, the people assembled have not all come from the same place and may have different investments. So, an experience like this, an encounter, becomes a borderline experience of sorts, and somehow puts at the forefront the organizing experiences and modalities of action we all come from as well as how we position ourselves and engage in that shared space that we've created.

Mary: This tension arising from the mixture of differently positioned academics and activists has existed from the founding moments of LeftEast. In addition, we have very different experiences and also politics. We may be living in different parts of the world, with different types of connections on the ground, or none at all, and may be closer to different Left tendencies. This does not just affect our analysis but our methods and tactics as well. I remember that we were surprised at an event when we were hosted by a migrant-run community center in Istanbul, when a participant coming from a more conventional academic background accused us of a kind of 'ghetto tourism.' For those of us engaged in actual organizing work, closely with migrant-run organizations, this was clearly designed as a solidarity-based knowledge exchange. Assumptions such as theirs often don't get addressed and remain in the background, along with resentments of other kinds, lurking behind the scenes as personal judgements rather than political questions. At their best, relational methods can bring these forth to be dealt with.

Another thing that comes to mind with regard to method is again from our 2013 gathering in Sofia. There were some of us close to the so-called creative fields and who use 'artistic methods' or forms of workshop-based and collective knowledge production such as counter mapping in our political work. Two workshops had been proposed: one around housing issues in the region, and the other one to map our movements. In the end, neither took place. There was little interest in the housing workshop, as many felt it was impossible to produce useful knowledge under those conditions – they questioned the utility of trying to produce knowledge collectively in such a discreet and limited way. In the other case, a legitimate fear was expressed of our movements being on a map, making them easy to find and attack. Retrospectively, I realize I hadn't explained that mapping our movements could be a useful exercise even if it would not be made public (the original suggestion had been to make a map to put online), Mapping our movements together – including our goals, methods, successes and failures – has value in and of itself.

Fragment 2: Network

Mariya: Until now, at our workshop in Bidston in the Spring of 2023, we've had 6 encounters. If we include the summer school held at the Central European University (CEU), the first two of these were held in Budapest in 2011 and 2012. New Left Perspectives and Xaspel

hosted one in Sofia in 2013. We then met in Kaunas in 2015 which was a 'post-socialist' context, but the co-organizers included an international group operating out of Barcelona. In Istanbul in 2016 the main organizer was a comrade who studies our region. 2017 saw us in Skopje at Social Center Dunja. We then planned events with collectives in Tuzla and Bucharest, but did not manage to raise the funds to make them happen. After that, the global coronavirus pandemic hit... This coming summer we'll be off to our first encounter since Skopje, in Tbilisi. It would be nice to think together of how our network has grown and changed.

Mary: My participation in events leading to LeftEast's emergence started with the summer school held at the CEU in Budapest in 2011. I was among the organizers; when we saw the character and caliber of the applicants, we realized that it was an opportunity to build relationships through collective knowledge production among leftists in the region. Being at the CEU, we were able fund people from across the region to gather around the topic of crises of capital and the temporality of neoliberalization as related to the region's experience. In addition to selecting activist 'students', and inviting informal participants to join, we also partnered with Hungarian activists and scholars who put together a public component. This all-day event organized by members of the 'right to the city' movement The City is for All (AVM) and the student-run College for Advanced Studies in Social Theory (TEK) allowed summer school participants to hear from and communicate with members of trade unions and the housing movement. 'Students' at the summer school had taken up with incredible intensity the assignment to do collaborative research projects, which already set them in collaborative relation. The following year, a number of them went on to co-organize in Budapest a 'summer school without teachers' with scholars, activists, and organizers from TEK, AVM, and the editorial collective of the journal *Fordulat*.

Others who had taken part in the 2011 summer school were central to organizing the 2013 workshop in Sofia. It was there that you and a few others recruited some of us to join the process of developing the online media platform LeftEast. It was clear to me that LeftEast was partly emerging from and should always be tied to the companion technology of the 'summer school'. And, as LeftEast was consolidated as a loose editorial collective, it also became a core organizer of the summer events. We started to refer to them as con-

vergences, and to move to new locations every time we were able to gather, developing ways of collaborating with comrade organizations that would host us. I felt this was really powerful, because we were really in the thick of it – the experience of organizing the Left in each of these places. We were building shared knowledge from contextualized questions while gaining familiarity with different places, their movements, networks and methods. This roving character is, I think, another relational method.

Mariya: A process of building a network was underway, and it is important to mention the other trajectories that converged with the summer encounters to form LeftEast. By 2011-2012, many of us knew each other through CEU and its extended intellectual network in the region. Some of us studied at the CEU and were part of the student-run satirical and political newspaper *Poisonous Paprika* (Florin Poenaru, one of LeftEast's co-founders, and I were involved in it, as was current LeftEast member Tibor Meszmann). Others had met through the Alter-Globalisation movement after Genova 2001, at European Social Forums, through anarchist networks especially in Greece, and the Balkan Anarchist Bookfair, NoBorders camps, and through other such experiences of Left organizing. By 2001, members from the New Left organizations across East Central Europe had started to meet with relative frequency across the region with support from German party foundations (e.g. Rosa Luxemburg, Heinrich Böll, Friedrich Ebert) or EU funding (e.g. European Alternatives). An active group in one country would invite its counterparts from neighboring countries to a meeting, and then the latter would reciprocate. We shared insights on the political economic situation and obstacles to the Left forming in each country, in English. There were also events like the Subversive Festival in Zagreb and the Transeuropa Festival in Sofia. In that period, I was part of Social Center Xaspel and New Left Perspectives in Sofia, which hosted the summer school in 2013.

In 2012 we had already met in two parallel meetings in Bucharest. One was organized by Criticatac, a Romanian new left media platform, and the other, by European Alternatives (the organizer of TransEuropa festival). It was at the Criticatac meeting that LeftEast was first conceived. A few of the organizations – Spilne/Commons in Ukraine and Criticatac in Romania – were becoming successful media platforms. The question was if we could join efforts in an initiative that would transverse national borders and allow for collab-

oration among these small scenes isolated in the big cities of these different countries.

Our region is characterized by enormous linguistic diversity. There's a new language group every few hundred kilometers and speakers of Slavic and Romani languages are dispersed among those speaking Romanian, Greek, Hungarian, Albanian, Latvian, Lithuanian, and Estonian – each forming a separate branch of the Indo-European if not their own separate language family. Although there are a lot of bilingual and even trilingual people (many Romani speakers as well as other so-called minorities) and there used to be many more, language can really be a barrier today. The idea for LeftEast was to try to do something like these successful media platforms did nationally, but in the English language, as we say on our website 'beyond the straitjacket of the national languages'.

Mary: These networks that you refer to are not necessarily apparent to everyone, even among LeftEast editors or much of the New Left in the region. It's been interesting to see how this knowledge is connected to each of our particular experiences and to reflect on the ways in which we have or have not managed to make these positionalities and relationships explicit. While we often work hard to have these networks animate the convergences, we may not always do such a good job at creating the space in which people would share 'this is where I'm from; this is what I've/we've been doing; these are the groups and activities I'm involved with'. We can sketch the emergence of an initiative such as ELMO – the East European Left Media Outlet, established during the pandemic: it came into being after many media organizations popped up over the years and the question of media had been discussed at various strategy meetings in the region. In 2020-21, during the pandemic, some organizations within our network with different media profiles came together online and discussed building a media network. The idea was to create the conditions for a shared knowledge production practice through the translation of news and analysis across different regional languages, independently of mainstream media sources. A number of LeftEast members have worked really closely with this project and LeftEast is a member of ELMO. I think some of us see clearly that ELMO emerged out of these years and years of network-building and learning to work together on different scales, but also the work that individuals have done to weave those networks.

This points to some of the modalities that we haven't managed to bring forth at convergences: mapping ourselves in space and time, locating ourselves *vis-à-vis* the struggles, or positioning ourselves in relationship to various kinds of power. We have limited time together, and the choices made about how to spend it usually end up favoring talking and presenting, and not so much the body. There is always too little time – even a five-day encounter amounts to only about three days, not including travel time (one of the reasons why we have tried to organize traveling – or drifting-together, as well). It also raises the question of how we could better use the pages of LeftEast in such a way as to allow more space for this kind of relational work and network-building. For example, as you mentioned, a few pieces in the Istanbul bibliography were from LeftEast. What if more of this work was done in advance or afterwards in articles on LeftEast? We've discussed it but have never been coordinated enough to do this – we lack the labor. Yet it remains a fact that much of what shows up on the pages of LeftEast is imbued with these relationalities and helps (re)produce them.

Mariya: Yes, and perhaps the other aspect of that same issue is that when we actually spend time speaking about our struggles, we do this in a more rational register, coming up with an analysis. We often fail to integrate the more embodied part of our work together into the programming, and end up just catching up on a very personal level. This is very important as, over time, it's political and personal friendships and not only links between collectives that develop and act as central nodes in the network. This brings me to the point about who has been present at our encounters. We've had different ways to issue invitations, sometimes through an open call, sometimes not; sometimes we choose a mixture of people or movements that we want to see present. We've often focused on regional representation but also have attempted to cover different types of struggles and causes. It has been quite different each time. But this raises the question of modalities for the relational and affective 'catching up' with each other – personally and politically, individually and collectively, beyond informal catch ups in the pub or in breaks between workshops, or drinking late into the night.

Ideally LeftEast should have been the space, I think, as a media platform, that also allows for self-reflections and reflections from a movement position, and reports on what movements in different countries are doing, what methods they are using, the real chal-

lenges and limitations that they are encountering, and how they go about addressing them. We have had a few of those pieces, but not many and not enough – something like the piece on the Budapest-based ‘School of Public Life’ that you worked really closely with them on. That piece, “‘When is it time to act if not now?!’ Participatory action research about housing movements in Hungary’, went very deep, and spoke about their use of this specific methodology. That kind of text really allows for other groups or movements to reflect on their own methods and cross-movement learning. And for us at LeftEast it allows us to think about our formats and do more of this kind of work with other groups. I don’t think we’ve had many of these inquiries on our pages, while they’ve been addressed in the encounters a bit more. And that means, that again, even among us in the LeftEast collective, different people have quite different experiences and knowledge about what others are doing. There is also, I think, the question of the different groups and movements that members of the LeftEast collective are embedded in but to which LeftEast itself is not central, and it is a bit less apparent to other editors what role we play as activists outside of LeftEast in those nodes.

Fragment 3: Media

Mary: While technically LeftEast is an online platform that publishes articles, you and I have felt an ongoing tension around how to define it – as a media organization or something else. LeftEast emerged as an entity when we launched the website in 2013, and for most readers, it looks like that’s all it is. I remember we felt uncomfortable when a co-editor put us in the category of a media organization at a meeting several years ago. That label misses some of what we are, somehow. But it is also true that the convergences have been organized by a very small number of us at LeftEast and there are quite a few LeftEast members who have never attended any of these, or only one. Even a few editors we recruited after they attended a convergence never attended another.

It’s not just that the knowledge production at the encounters can’t be summed up by the editorial, but it is also that the relationality cultivated at the encounters contributes to what shows up on our pages and how. I remember being touched when a participant at our Istanbul encounter, who had followed us for a while before that, told me (years later) that they saw LeftEast as a conversation.

Mariya: This contrasts a lot, I think, with the conception and editorial policies of journals like Jacobin, Tribune, n+1, openDemocracy, or Eurozine.

Mary: If we looked at LeftEast's coverage temporally, I think we'd find surges of coverage of certain topics right after our meetings, because of the excitement and energy and new possibilities that emerged from the encounter. But I also remember that some editors set out to solicit pieces or conduct interviews at a few of the convergences, yet many of them never surfaced. This was often because folks were too busy with pressing activism, even more so after taking time to converge. Some people recorded interviews at our encounters but found it too much work to transcribe and edit them. We've discussed having places for different categories of writing on our pages but have not managed to set up a system. This is a methods issue, too. Sometimes the standards set for an 'article' are too high for what a person can produce, even with a helpful editor. This might be addressed through style. This is why I like conversations. They can convey a lot of information in a relational, situated, and multivocal feminist way, and are often lower stakes than articles.

Changes in the regional media ecology since LeftEast emerged have also affected us. In the decade since LeftEast was founded, quite a few local language Left media forms have emerged that didn't exist before. They are separate organizations with different people running them, each with its own array of politics and styles, but they emerged from this same networked commons-building process. And a lot of the energy that used to come to LeftEast in the form of movement knowledges now goes directly to these local language platforms. From one perspective this can be seen as eclipsing LeftEast, but to me the process has simply shifted its role in the wider network. ELMO comes in not to replace LeftEast, but to renew and amplify its relationship to the ground. Those of us that have been involved in ELMO and are aware of the mushrooming of these Left media organizations in these geographies see the dialectical move, you know, from CriticAtac and Spilne to LeftEast, to the other local language media, to ELMO, as a very positive thing. But it is true that this expansion, and the shifts in the media ecology, may affect LeftEast's content. If you see LeftEast mainly as a media publication reflected solely in the articles, or are concerned with a certain kind of editorial orderliness or in a clear editorial line, you might not

BUDAPEST
2012

TEK resources and labor
Fordulat resources and labor
individual solidarity resources and labor
mini-lectures
paper presentations
discussions with people representing movements
2019/2020
meetings that initiated ELMO

TUZLA X
2018

SKOPJE
2017

A few small funds
hosted by Dunja social center and Solidarmost
lodging in a combination of hotel and solidarity housing
presentations from social movements
conversations organized around discussion themes
walking tour
dance party
film
advance reading list
dérive from Belgrade

BUCHAREST X
2019

New funding opportunities
brought by 2023 Russian
invasion of Ukraine

SOFIA
2013

hosted by Xaspel social center and New Left Perspectives
grant from big funder (paid labor)
presentations of individual papers .
walking tour
urban theory lab on housing
mapping
lodging in hostel with shared social space
discussion with local activists & visiting daily protests
dance party

ISTANBUL
2016

grant from big funder and small university grant
individual solidarity resources and labor
hosted at Boğaziçi University
lodging at university dorms (in kind donation)
advance reading list
visits to local political groups
film program

TBILISI
2024 →

ZEIMI 2015

- small grants from several sources
- individual solidarity resources and labor
- shared living space (art residency space) and collective social reproduction tasks
- walking tour in Kaunas
- visit to evicted social center
- mapping
- soccer, derive and lake trip on old bus
- cooking together & eating on premises
- dance party
- collective statement

regard that networked process in the same way.

While people are not channeling as much material from on the ground movement directly to us for original publication on LeftEast, we are still very much part of the process of reproducing a common infrastructure. This happens through our maintaining and building various relationships, through our editorial practice, the encounters, and importantly, through ELMO. To me, the fact that ELMO translates movement knowledges, Left analysis, and relevant news across twelve regional languages(!) is a huge accomplishment in terms of the capacity for Left internationalism in this region and beyond.

Then there are the relationalities activated through the editorial process itself, which you mentioned earlier. We might take for example the agreement LeftEast has with the Hungarian language journal *Fordulat*, associated with the College for Advanced Studies in Social Theory (TEK), a hub of Marxist thinking, to publish reviews of each new issue. Some of the reviews have been a bit unwieldy, but the process of getting a review in shape to publish is a long process of working with authors who are often not very experienced in this type of writing and may only be beginning to master writing in English. They are translating complex ideas expressed in Hungarian – they do really have to summarize since most people can't just go read it themselves – while also trying to establish connections to relevant LeftEast articles.

I want to return to what you were saying about how coming together in these convergences over the years has nurtured personal and political relationships and point to the number of close friends and comrades that I've made through my involvement in LeftEast – you included! LeftEast has been a way to contribute to a network of knowledge production around housing and land struggles on the global as well as the regional scale. Or I think of the solidarity and knowledge exchange trip I took with a comrade from the housing movement in New York City to Budapest and Bucharest, not to mention the many Eastern European housing activists I've hosted in New York, connected to movements here in NYC, the US, and the Americas. For me, that's also inevitably connected to LeftEast – it has played such a big part of my knowledge base and in building this internationalist network.

Many of these connections were made via my relationship to LeftEast and also feed back into its content as well. These relations nurture the responsibilities I have at LeftEast, which goes back to the editorial question. I like good writing. I want the pieces that Left-

East publishes to be good. I want our readers to read them with interest and find them relevant. But the process of producing a piece is so varied for those I solicit or that people propose to me, because it may emerge from a conversation with someone from whom I want people to hear, from who's not a 'writer' per se, but is speaking from a movement perspective; maybe they're speaking of methods or strategies that their movement is employing or struggling with. This process of writing is not one of an academic writer and the product is not going to be a classically formatted analytical article. It may not even have a clear message but rather be a reflection. And something that emerges out of the process is the relationality between me as a LeftEast collective member and that person and the context they're in – which is the struggle to become a leftist, to develop a historical materialist analysis, to become an internationalist; to enact leftist politics in this region specifically, with its specific challenges. This is a part of movement relationality that I think is incredibly important. What we're doing in this process is helping each other to understand something but also to articulate it in certain ways. That's a very important aspect of what LeftEast has been to me.

Mariya: Yes, the question of working with authors, and again, the question of LeftEast as a shared resource. LeftEast has not just been a place where we publish brilliant analysis, but a place where we try to nurture a connection with authors. We try to work with them so that their texts improve over time so that the politics behind them becomes more explicit and grounded in the knowledges shared on LeftEast as well. This is so that there can be more voices from the region who can articulate the type of critique that maybe a lot of us feel but aren't confident enough to articulate in writing. And this is, I think, an understanding you and I share; something we haven't explicated, but have taken part in. We don't just develop and evolve texts but relationships with authors through our editorial process with them. That then pays back into growing the movements, growing the people that are politically at the place where they can join the movement with confidence and can produce not just analysis, but a praxis that is relevant within the broader movement ecology.

And following up from what you were saying, the editorial question – as related to the summer encounters and the relationality we are trying to produce – is that we are trying to invest in an organic process, but also one that – and not in this fluffy way – but really,

really includes giving people the chance to develop their language and writing skills in general, as well as in English. In this process, we engage with many aspects of the text, including gratis editing by native speakers: something non-native speaking authors rarely get anywhere. This is one of the ways in which LeftEast can be seen as a resource, or even as infrastructure; part of the movement's commons: as a shared space, resource, conversation. So, these questions are interrelated: how do you get pieces with potential worked into something that has the capacity to resonate with our audience; and how do you cultivate an audience that understands that there's a relational process behind the writing? Our work should be judged on that level of network cultivation rather than simply judging the text as written for any given English language leftist platform.

And I guess we can't go into it now, but we've had very interesting debates over the years about how English language copy editing should work, as some of us have felt that it is nice to keep an inflection of the regional grammars that might be a little unusual in English but not incorrect.

Mary: I could go on for hours about this topic ha ha ha!

Fragment 4: Resources

Mary: One thing that came to mind concerning labor and the encounters is that the upcoming convergence in Tbilisi is promising in the sense that proportionally more LeftEast collective members are interested in attending, as well as planning and organizing, than ever before. To point to the amount of labor, I should note how much work went simply into the initial planning stages and the fruitless search for funding for two encounters that did not even take place! One was in Tuzla (with the Worker's University) and one in Bucharest (with Macaz cooperative). The dearth of labor for organizing the convergences is interwoven with periodic crises of labor at the online platform, in which some of us take on many tasks disproportionately. It's nice to see a strong recognition of the importance of the summer school at LeftEast now.

I do think we've learned a lot over time about what we want to happen at the encounters, and how. It's not as simple as that they were bad in the beginning and they're getting better year after year. Rather, the conditions each year allow us to do certain things, and we get a taste of what is possible. And we have more experience with how to make things happen and what can work. We've

observed both their fruits and missed opportunities over time. But they are also exhausting to organize, which is one reason we often don't manage to pull off some of the best ideas or plans.

Mariya: We just keep on asking ourselves: what could be a better way forward in terms of distribution of labor for our summer encounters? And also the media work in between? One thing that has been a real learning experience is the changing configurations of the relationship between LeftEast and local groups organizing the convergence. I do believe that over time, we have identified not only the very clear difficulties that local committees face and how much labor they have to do as compared to the organizers from other places who simply can't take care of certain things. But a really nice thing we have landed on, in later encounters, was the idea that the local committee should have a large part in identifying key topics and questions to focus on by taking into account and inviting a diversity of local movements. The failure to bring the convergences in Tuzla and Bucharest into being was very much related to the fact that the local team couldn't muster up enough energy. And the same people at LeftEast just couldn't take on all that was needed, even when people from outside both groups offered to help!

I have also been thinking about that in terms of different models that we've used, and some have been better than others. But I'll start from the back: from the second most recent to last convergence (at the time of writing) – in Skopje – when we were staying in shared solidarity housing. It was the night before the last day. I was completely exhausted. I had some bug or flu and I spent the whole night in the bathroom laying on the ground and thinking 'Maybe I won't go there tomorrow'. We had traveled there crossing half the Balkans, starting at another meeting and picking up participants on the way. It was a very complex operation with very few resources, relying on the labor of a very small number of people. A few of us had been organizing most of the earlier encounters as well. And then, lying there on the floor, I thought about what would happen, since I didn't know who the labor could fall onto. There should be a better distribution of labor, you know, within LeftEast as a collective. We always have an organizing committee that in theory rotates but in practice we completely depend on a small number of bodies for our convergences to happen.

Mary: We always plan on codifying techniques that work well, from

deciding with host comrades where it will be, to seeking solidarity opportunities and funds, to setting up committees, to planning the program, activities, and methods, but we haven't managed it. We also haven't managed to really codify best practices for the editors and the website. We have relied on a kind of an apprentice model, and that means we always have to be involved as masters. Our knowledge is embodied in ways that make it hard to impart.

Commons are not given, they are produced. Although we say that commons are all around us – the air we breathe and the languages we use being key examples of shared wealth – it is only through co- operation in the production of our life that we can create them. This is because commons are not essentially material things but are social relations, constitutive social practices. This is why some prefer to speak of 'commoning' or 'the common', precisely to underscore the relational character of this political project (Linebaugh, 2008).

– George Caffentzis and Silvia Federici. 'Commons Against and Beyond Capitalism'. *Upping the Anti* 15. 2013.

Mariya: We also have to find better ways to work closer with the local collective. I think the earlier we start working with a local group, and the better they have identified a number of people to work together in a group, rather than just one person, the more this allows us to have a better understanding of what is required in the local context and how it connects to our agenda as LeftEast with regard to conversations and relations that we're having with other groups in the region. In terms of logistics, that would mean that there is some better connection and communication, hopefully, between the local committee and the LeftEast committee, the group that is in charge.

At the end of the day, the question is not so much if the labor is paid or unpaid but rather, more importantly: how to organize it in a way that it is not concentrated in a very small number of completely exhausted bodies that feel that if they were to leave, nobody could pick up the task(s)? In Istanbul, despite the fact that we did have a bigger organizing committee on LeftEast's side, there was a lot of fluctuation and chaos because of the coup d'état. At the end of the day, only a few people engaged in rescheduling and rethinking what happens next. It was exhausting: a changing program and leading a big, relatively big group in a very volatile situation.

Yet these questions are, to some degree at least, also connected to the question of paid and unpaid labor. 'Payment' for this

labor is rare for us; even when we get some compensation, it has been quite modest, whether financial or symbolic. Of course, somebody could have an investment in something like LeftEast because, for instance, they are building credentials within their own academic or activist space. And I think that's also something important for us to bear in mind when it comes to the motivations that people might have to join or not join a process like this.

But there were quite significant differences between a process such as, say, in Sofia, where there was a local committee (of which I was part), which was quite fixed, managing the program internally. It was inviting people onto their own turf and on their own terms, at a time when LeftEast wasn't quite formed. Sadly, by the time participants arrived, there was a lot of conflict in Xaspel, the local collective, with very different ideas of what we wanted to do with the space and the time we had together. But still there was much less necessity for an international group to contribute to the conversation.

There were significant differences between the constellation in Lithuania, when the conversation was structured by the international group. Sometimes the international group was in conversation with certain local interlocutors, but with the local group acting much more as participants in the events we had developed together. In Istanbul we organized the summer school together with the local organizers, members of the LeftEast collective along with others. For example, the working group that developed the reading list that was offered to everybody in advance included other international activists. There was a program structured around panels where a few participants contributed with conversation starters rather than with paper presentations (like in Sofia) or in workshops that were perhaps over-facilitated by organizers (in Kaunas). So, we have been moving over time to better integrate and develop more dialogical inputs between the LeftEast collective and the local organizers. And that also meant a certain shift in the division of labor, in terms of who contributes to that dialogue and how the topics are distributed to cover both what we think is important for the local committee and context, and what is important on a more regional/global level, and how these converge. So, by now we have a lot of information about what can work and what the challenges that can inform future summer school organizing are, even if they are still subject to actual conditions over time. We've had trouble managing to share this accumulated movement knowledge with newer members of the collective of LeftEast and local groups willing to organize with us.

When it comes to labor, we have touched upon social reproduction more generally, but there is also the question of getting and handling funding. In a way, it was always a great thing that we were really autonomous from any particular funder. And while having more funding is good because more people can come, getting a lot of funds – chasing after funds and handling the bureaucratic aspects of the funding – can be very time- and labor-consuming. We got funding from the Rosa Luxemburg Stiftung (RLS) in different years, directly and indirectly (via local groups whose members attended or organized/cosponsored the event). RLS requires a lot of bureaucracy. Strangely, while in general we knew that RLS was interested in party building in the region, they did not intervene to shift the priorities of our political agenda in that direction. However, it did lean on the local organizing committee regarding certain practicalities. In Sofia, they expected us to provide more luxurious accommodation for participants, whereas some of us thought staying in a hostel would facilitate the experience of living together. At times there definitely was a kind of dissonance between design and desire, resulting from the tension between some of our visions and what the funder insisted on.

At same time, you know, there were other funders that seemed to have no agenda, but you know, you'd still try to guess what they're on about and why they decided to fund you, or they would impose a bureaucracy that is an agenda in and on itself, or impose a type of agent that they wanted as their interlocutor, who has a certain history of funding, that many of the movements that we were working with did not have. This is the type of agent that can offer matching funds or had received an amount of funding, from which they can provide the relevant amount, often a percentage of the budget for the project. Figuring this out and working to find these groups was quite exhausting for many of us and a lot of possible funders fell through because the movements in the region still had not developed a stable and sustainable infrastructure that funders could relate to. These kinds of established NGOs are usually not those we want to work with.

Mary: There is also the question of the people that we invite being aware of our struggle with limited funds to cover the travel and accommodation costs of participants from the region. Even the way in which funded events and conference formats have been normalized encourages invitees to assume there's a lavish funding source

and a lot of labor that they don't have to think about. I remember one year we surveyed the applicants/invitees about their needs. People gave outrageous sums for travel. I don't think that they thought it was outrageous, but it was clear that they didn't understand that we have limited resources. But once we asked them: 'Hey, do you think you could take this route instead of that route or leave this day instead of that day or maybe take a train instead of a plane?', most people were really open to it. But it wouldn't have occurred to them because we hadn't explicitly invited them into this solidarity process. That same year, because we asked about resources, we ended up having people being like, 'Yes, and we can actually give some money, too'.

This idea of appealing to people for solidarity funding (or housing, which we have almost always done) is more than a material issue. There is an affective element to being invited to treat this as a shared responsibility – to be invited not to think of it as a conference that you register for or get selected for after which everything is taken care of for you; to be aware of limited resources and the power of a collective effort. I remember that time when we had appealed to people to consider the cost of their travel and then people who volunteered to give some money, it was really exciting, partly because a few of us had been doing this for years. I missed the convergence in 2012 because I was too underpaid to be able to afford the expensive trip to Europe. But other years you and I, and some others as well, felt our better pay scale allowed us to donate our own trip or give some money in solidarity. Another time we gave the 'pay' we received as organizers. And others who have access to university research funds and so on have been able to offer that.

Mariya: Even when we did crowdfunding, it was never with an open call shared over social media. I myself didn't feel that people were convinced that what we were doing is building shared infrastructure for the movement, which is something that we've always wanted to convey, I guess. I think we're successful in doing that now. And this conversation for me also points to other ways in which LeftEast is part of the regional commons, or infrastructure: the redistribution of resources from some of us who mostly live abroad (whether we are from the region or work on the region) and have a higher income or more time to give. This contributes to and enhances the commons of the movement, that can be shared and used. I have sometimes felt myself to be a shared resource in the way that people

approached me to give them knowledge about things that I don't always know how to activate, partly because of my role within the LeftEast collective.

And so, this is a question about the region's history with sources of redistribution. A lot of times we are operating with a model from the early post-socialist era, when there was a lot of funding available that was very easy to grab. There were whole collectives of people that were just writing project after project to get money and not always fulfilling all their promises. So, by the time the New Left and LeftEast came on the horizon, there was already a new enclosure in the form of a new bureaucratization in which this redistribution was only possible if you spoke the language of potential sponsors, or were part of an established and registered NGO.

This also meant that some of us who came from the older generation are more prone to using some of these means creatively and to see funding as something that you still need to justify more than anything in front of your own consciousness and your own sense of purpose. Not as corruption, but as a manner of reappropriation, or even redistribution. I think that is also a bit more of a generational difference with some of the other comrades; a matter of political culture and experience. Those not eager to do that were way more fixed on what the funder is worth, what we have promised in the project, and what we haven't executed. And that also meant different approaches. Our approach has always been a bit more flexible and a bit more creative. And that also meant that we might or might not work well with specific groups because those that have worked with Rosa Luxemburg historically have had to be very accountable to the organization, which also meant being less flexible. It has also meant sometimes following a structural agenda that becomes more about roles than a political agenda – following the formats that are prescribed. To me, that has sometimes been quite counterproductive. And I've seen it in different instances of this process that we're describing.

Mary: I wasn't in favor of trying to rely on a crowdfunding campaign, because very few people in these movements have any money to spare. And I have often not had funds either, but I guess I have seen the time and care I put into LeftEast as a kind of redistribution in solidarity... LeftEast's volunteer labor model is in creative tension with the idea that people should get paid for their labor. There has been a growing emphasis among our comrade organizations in different

geographies on building a solidarity economy. It is one of the reactions to the problems with grant funding: even if you're lucky enough to get it, the conditions of the funding often limit your capacities and redirect your energy, if not your priorities.

Sharing knowledge on our practices with regard to how to (re) produce sustainable Left institutions was an important aspect of our Skopje convergence. Ironically, it was precisely the event we planned on this issue – survival strategies via cooperative and solidarity economy and the redistribution of resources informally and formally – that did not come to fruition, partly because the local organization lost its main source of cooperative sustainability.

The emphasis on building sustainable organizations and a solidarity economy goes beyond the question of getting funding to pay people. It's connected also to building a different kind of economy altogether. That leads interestingly to the question of shared knowledge production, because we've been talking about organizing much of the content of the meetings around conversations of strategic significance for all of us. A common strategy is to take foundation or other funds to kickstart a process that hopefully then grows beyond dependence on it. In a context and era in which wealth is concentrated so intensely at the top, we should surely take the money and run!

Contributors' Bios

ALEKSEI BORISIONOK is a curator, writer, and organizer who currently lives and works in Vienna. He is a member of the artistic-research group Problem Collective and the Work Hard! Play Hard! working group. He writes about art and politics for various magazines, catalogs, and online platforms such as e-flux Journal, L'Internationale Online, Partisan, Springerin, and Paletten, among many others. He was a fellow at the Vera List Center in New York (2022–2024), and, together with Katalin Erdődi, he has co-curated the Matter of Art Biennale in Prague (2024).

MIHA BREBENEL (they/them) is a Romanian-born white trans disabled queer based in London. Their long-term and expanding explorations are focused on the histories of Internationalism and solidarity, intersections with disability, gender, critical plant studies, law, and social and healing justice. They are a Senior Lecturer in Digital Cultures at Winchester School of Art, University of Southampton and part of the self-organizing group at Massia Artist and Project Space, where they also run the Socialist Herbalism Project.

NOAH BREHMER is a militant researcher and organizer who moved from New York City to Vilnius, Lithuania in 2013. From organizing with comrades in the hospitality sector as part of a solidarity network; to participating in the maintenance of various autonomous spaces over the years, Noah's variegated practice aligns him with the traditions of autonomist and communalist communisms. Amongst writing regularly for journals such as Blind Field, Autonomies, Contradictions, Metamute, and Libcom; Brehmer is the editor of *Paths to Autonomy* (2022, Minor Compositions), and the co-editor of *The Communist Horizon* (2023, Common Notions), and the *ULWC Reader* (2021, Luna6).

ALEKSANDRA FILA is an interdisciplinary scholar, particularly interested in post-socialist studies and intersections of feminist, Marxist and decolonial theory. She is a Doctoral Fellow at the University of Vienna, Austria, where she is working on a dissertation project on the feminist political economy of creativity in the context of Polish neoliberal transformation. Beyond academia, she has been involved in squatting and anti-fascist and abortion activism through numerous projects in Wrocław, Cracow, and Vienna.

NINO GAVASHELI is a cultural producer from Tbilisi, Georgia. She started her career as an emerging visual artist outside of the university infrastructure. She is a member of the first feminist art collective in Georgia, Gorgonas, and has participated in group exhibitions in Tbilisi and Batumi. Currently she works as a graphic designer and illustrator. Her main interests include working on publications and zines in collaboration with others. She works in different media such as planographic printing, digital painting, and installation. In her visual practice she engages with themes such as gender and women's empowerment, urban lifestyle, and the shaping of environment around modern society.

NEDA GENOVA is Lecturer in Digital Media in the department of Film Studies, University of Southampton. She's interested in opening spaces for collaborative, experimental publishing practices that traverse disciplinary boundaries in art, activism, and academia. Her research is situated at the intersection of cultural, media, and post-socialist studies. Her monograph *Politics of Surfaces* exploring the material-semiotic transformations of urban surfaces in Sofia, Bulgaria, is forthcoming with Goldsmiths Press in 2025. Neda is a founding member of the editorial collective for Bulgarian-language journal dVERSIA, which publishes critical Left analyses of contemporary politics, society, and culture.

HANNA GRZEŚKIEWICZ is a curator and researcher working with sound and words. Her practice is centered on the relationship of art with social movements, listening, and sonic fictions. She works in collective, participatory, and public settings, which comes out of her engagement with queer-feminist, migrant, and anti-capitalist movements. She is currently working on projects that explore sonic agency in feminist protests, and Eastern European sonic fictions through queer-feminism and ecology. She regularly produces work for radio and co-created the show 'morning stories' on Warsaw's Radio Kapitał. She was the discourse curator for the IMPULS Festival and is a member of the SONIC TOMORROW collective, with which she co-curated the festival 'Situated Ecologies' at Floating University in Berlin. She was part of transmediale festival's 2022 research group, and has presented her work at the Akademie der Künste (Berlin) and CTM Festival (Berlin), among others.

MARIYA P. IVANCHEVA (University of Strathclyde) is an anthropologist and sociologist of higher education and labor. Her academic and research-driven advocacy work focuses on the casualization and digitalization of academic labor, the re/production of intersectional inequalities at universities and labor markets, and the role of academic and student communities and infrastructures in broader processes of social change especially in transitions to/from socialism. She is the author of *The Alternative University: Lessons from Bolivarian Venezuela* (Stanford University Press 2023). As an engaged scholar she has been a member of a number of platforms, working on topics of anti-racism, labor rights, gender and financial justice, e.g. LeftEast, LevFem, and PrecAnthro.

RASTKO NOVAKOVIĆ was born in Yugoslavia in 1981. Over the years he has co/authored over 60 moving image works. He has been active in the housing, trade union, and anti-war movements. In recent years, he has been working to archive social movements at the MayDay Rooms in London. He runs Inclinations Film/Book Club in Glasgow where he also dances and teaches queer tango. He is a contributor to the following books: *Engaged Urbanism: Cities and Methodologies* (I.B. Tauris, 2016), *The Cinema of Danièle Huillet and Jean-Marie Straub* (Legenda, 2023), *All We Have Is the Story: Selected Interviews 1973–2022 – James Kelman* (PM Press, 2024).

OLIA SOSNOVSKAYA is an artist, writer, and cultural organizer. She works with textual, performative, and visual practices, addressing forms of political organizing, protest choreographies, movement scores, and intersections of festivity and the political within post-socialist contexts and beyond. Member of Work Hard! Play Hard! self-organized platform, intertwining the issues of work, leisure, non-institutional infrastructures, and knowledges through participatory and discursive formats, and the artistic-research group Problem Collective focused on strikes, archives, reading practices and tools for engagement with overseen histories and social struggles. As part of collectives and individually, her works have been presented at Kyiv Biennial, Biennale Matter of Art (Prague), e-flux, Tanzquartier Wien, Kunsthalle Wien, Museum of Modern Art Warsaw, Manifesta Biennial (Kosovo), documenta fifteen, among others.

MARY N. TAYLOR is a founding member of the LeftEast collective. Her research praxis investigates sites, techniques, and politics of civic cultivation, the production of political personhood, the ethics and aesthetics of nationalism/cultural differentiation, and the history of communist experiments. She co-edited *Co-revolutionary Praxis: Accompaniment as a Strategy for Working Together* (Auckland: St. Paul St. Gallery, 2015), and *The Communist Horizon: Futures Beyond Capitalist Urbanization* (Common Notions, 2023). Her historical ethnography *Movement of the People: Folk Dance, Populism, and Citizenship in Hungary* (Indiana University Press, 2021), explores the tension between peoples' movements and populism in Hungary through the lens of folk revival. She is currently working on a dialogical film project about liberation movement lives in the former Socialist Bloc.

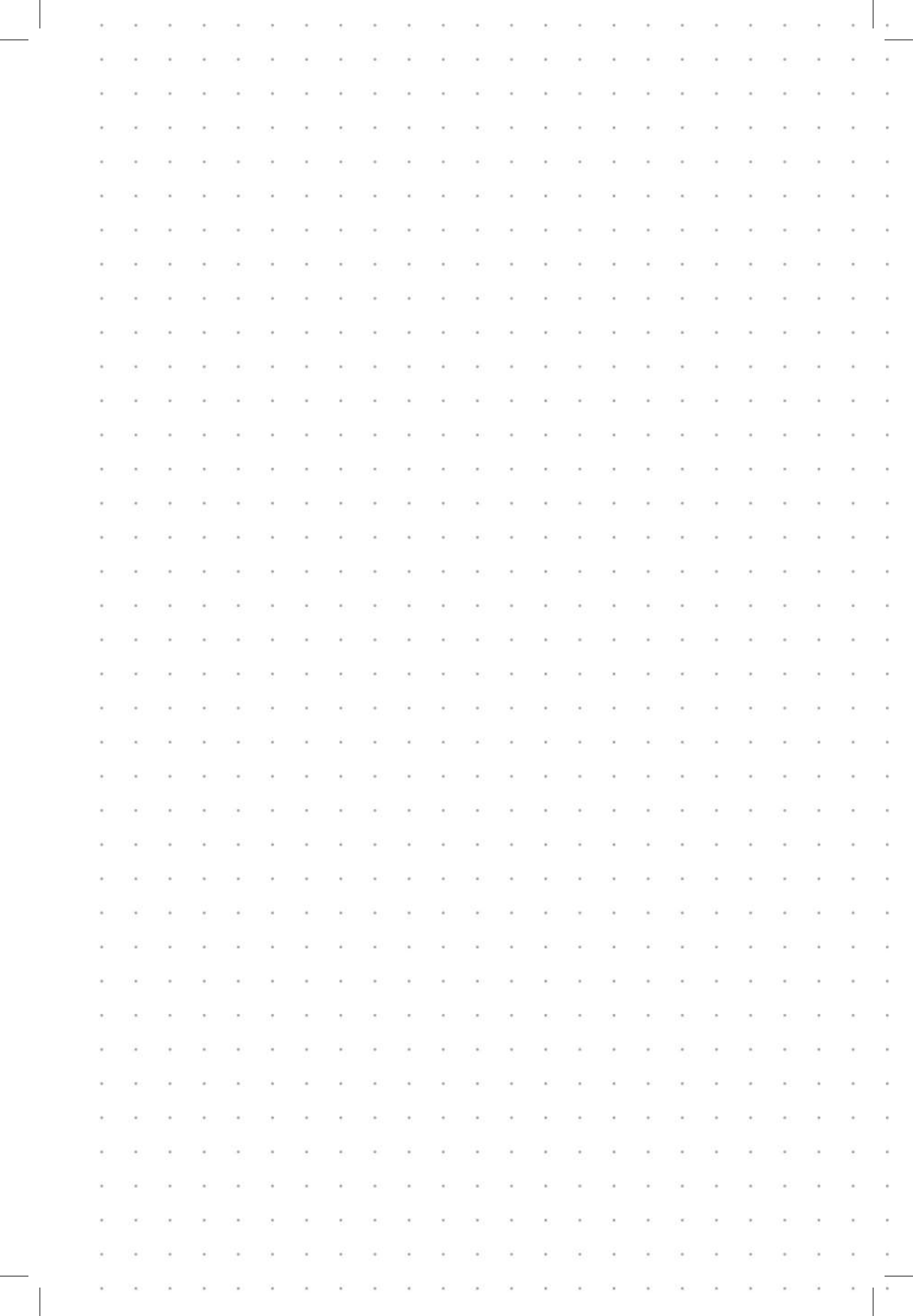
XENODATA CO-OPERATIVE investigates image politics, algorithmic culture, and technological conditions of knowledge production and governance through art and media practices. The collective was established by Yasemin Keskin-tepe and Sasha Anikina. Together they share a practice of co-curating and writing. **ALEXANDRA (SASHA) ANIKINA** is a media scholar and artist whose work focuses on affective infrastructures, algorithmic imaginaries, feminist STS, and technological conditions of knowledge production, governance, labor, and affect. She is Senior Lecturer in Media Practices at the University of Southampton, and co-director of Critical Infrastructures and Image Politics research group. **YASEMIN KESKINTEPE** is a curator working on the politics and poetics of technology and digital culture. She has worked for transmediale, ZKM, Hellerau, and German Hygiene-Museum among others, and is currently a PhD candidate at the University of Potsdam.

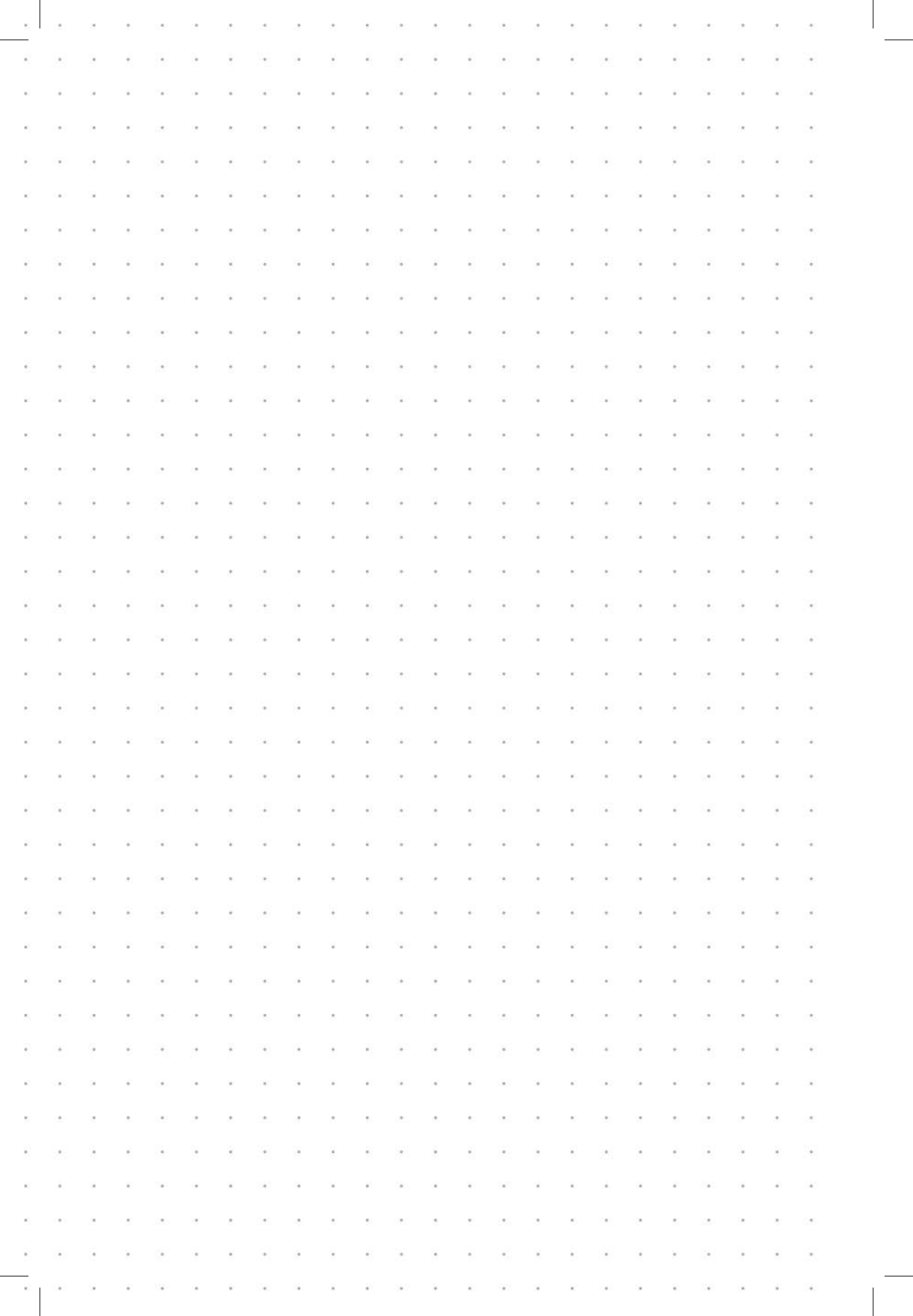
Please use the remaining pages to note down any thoughts in response to the book, its propositions, questions, concerns, tensions or unexplored issues.

To share these notes with the authors and editors of the book, take a picture or scan the pages, and send the file(s) to:
postcommunistcommoning@gmail.com.

This is meant as a way of activating the book's potential to act as a prompt or an invitation for commoning on post-communist grounds.

We are looking forward to hearing from you!





'Post-Communist Grounds. In Search of the Commons' is a collection of interventions seeking to explore and activate practices of commoning in post-communism in a range of genres and media forms, with a specific interest in developing experimental aesthetic practices.

'In our dire times of seemingly failed alternatives, this brilliant book takes on the task of tracing and making a liveable world. Returning to and renewing commoning as a set of experiences, rhythms or rituals gives us multiversal political propositions. These are new, aesthetic, conceptual or practical efforts as well as ways to relate to and inhabit spaces of hope and work, which post-communist territories have in common.'

– Olga Goriunova, scholar and curator in the fields of digital media, arts and cultures

'Post-Communist Grounds. In Search of the Commons' offers a necessary political and affective archive of movements across post-communist geographies. This collection is not a romantic celebration of the commons but a committed, grounded engagement with commoning as a practice of contradiction, risk, and invention. Drawing on shared experiences of crisis and rupture, the book constructs a living infrastructure of solidarity – of being with others – across borders and struggles. Through frictions, experiments, and encounters, the contributors trace how infrastructures in common are formed in the very terrains of loss, enclosure, and exhaustion. They offer us tools to sustain movements – not through purity or perfection but through care, vulnerability, and a radical openness to becoming otherwise. These are not easy or finalized answers but collective invitations to continue asking, walking, and building together.'

– Ana Vilenica, urban researcher, art theorist and editor of 'Decoloniality of Eastern Europe'

